

Phil 220 Modern Philosophy

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 220 • Dr. Stephen R. C. Hicks

Contents

Lecture 1. Birth of the Modern

Lecture 2. Radical Doubt

Lecture 3. The Promise of Individual Empiricism

Lecture 4. The French Enlightenment

Lecture 5. Counter-Enlightenment

Lecture 6. Awakening from the Dogmatic Slumber

Lecture 7. Resurgent Collectivism

Lecture 8. Liberal or Anti-Liberal?

Lecture 1: Birth of the Modern

At a glance — The birth of the modern.

- 1.1 Welcome to Modern Philosophy, and I want to start with this question: "What is the modern?" And let's go to this date, 1500. It's a nice round number, but it's the number that philosophers and historians, when they use modern, like this date. It's an astounding date if you think about the range of revolutionary things that occurred in the generation before and generation after 1500, an extraordinary century. And this is the birth of the modern. We've all heard of this fellow, Christopher Columbus, and the idea that there's a whole new pair of continents that we didn't know about. And then from the people living on those continents, the awareness of the rest of the world. We're just going to start a new era of globalization, learning from each other, of course, doing the usual things that humans do, learning and fighting and all sorts of other things, but globalization and an understanding of the size of the world, new.
- 1.2 And also, the idea that you can go out into the world and have adventures, confidently explore, in contrast to—this is from an old medieval map, which is very indicative. Anytime they didn't know what was there, they would put monsters there. So the idea there is, metaphysically, if we upgrade this, you go out into the unknown world, don't do that. Monsters are going to get you. There's the edge of the world. You will sink to your doom. So the idea that you can sail confidently out into the unknown and have, of course, using your resources and your capacities and your ingenuity, solve problems and have a great adventurous life, that's also part of the modern.
- 1.3 This fellow, Johannes Gutenberg, revolutions in communications with the printing press. As this, over the course of succeeding decades, expanded through all of Europe and then abroad, the amount of information available to people, the cost of publications, the literacy rates, increasing dramatically. That also part of the modern. In the arts, moving from exploration to communication to the arts, this is a piece started in 1501. Of course, it's 17 feet high. Took him a long time to create this thing. It's magnificent. In some ways, it's a stereotypical cliché work of art to us. But think about this in the context of the early 1500s. It is a male figure. It's nude. The idea that we are going to present the human figure not hunched over, not in robes, not with an emaciated body—but the idea that human beings can be beautiful, magnificent, and we're going to portray them as God made them in their natural state without shame or embarrassment, that is also part of the modern.
- 1.4 This is a religious theme we're taking from a religious book, but it is modernized. Now, one interesting thing I like to think about in the connection with the David is there are lots of—David is a popular theme in art history, literary history, and in sculpture. But I think this is the first time where David is portrayed not after he has slain Goliath. We're not reflecting on what has gone on in the past. Instead, this is David, confidently, with a little bit of nervousness, of course, looking ahead to the future. That also is modern—

less looking to the past, more focusing on what's ahead. What am I going to commit to and make in the future?

- 1.5 Early anatomical studies, Andreas Vesalius publishing in 1543, detailed anatomical studies of the human body. Now, for many centuries, doing anatomy was forbidden, legally and religiously. But the idea that we are going to do empirical experimental studies to find out what really goes on inside the body because we want to know this. Of course, down the road, we want to know how to fix things when things go wrong in the body. We're not going to rely on now 2,000-years-old stories about what it is to be a human being or early anatomical studies from 1,500, 1,600 years ago. We're going to look afresh and we're going to have text and pictures so that we can know what's going on here.
- 1.6 Moving into politics. The Prince, of course, a famous, infamous, notorious work. We have this Machiavellian adjective for dark arts, portrayed in the politics in a somewhat cynical understanding. In some ways, of course, people have been cynical about politics forever. Machiavelli then is just a modern variation on that. But also this idea that when we do politics, we think about good, bad, right, wrong, and what we're doing in the laws. We're not going to just start with abstract, handed-down theological understandings about what is good, what is bad, what is right, what the ultimate justice is, and so on, or even an understanding, an assumption that God is ultimately overlooking, and we'll make sure that justice is done. Instead, we are going to look at the world. We're going to look at actual human beings and how they actually think, how they actually feel, how they actually behave. We will do the historical studies and we'll observe actual politicians and others in practice and generalize from that to principles of how we are going to do our politics—more realistic, more worldly, more human-centered politics.
- 1.7 Is God overlooking the whole universe? Maybe, probably. We're not touching on that one too much quite yet. But when we look up to the stars, when we look up to the heavens, beyond earthly concerns, the idea that the Earth is at the center of God's creation, and we are special in some sense, we're starting to challenge that. It doesn't seem to fit the observational data. When we do the math, the numbers don't add up. What if we then shift away to thinking of the sun at the center of the system? Does the math work out better? Does that fit with our observational data better or not? Then we're willing to set aside old hypotheses that seem to say we're pretty special because we are at the center of God's creation. Well, maybe not. We're maybe on just a satellite, far from the center of the real action.
- 1.8 When we move to religion, the Protestant Reformation and all of those convulsions about how we are going to do religion. Now, there had been reformers all through church history, all through religious history, but this was the one that first took root and, as we know, transformed the European religious landscape, largely. A way, obviously, there's lots of things that Luther and the other reformers wanted to argue

about, but do I need to get to God by going through this hierarchy, from priests to bishops to archbishops, to cardinals, to the Pope, and he's the only one who receives direct communications from God? Or do I, as an individual, have responsibility for my soul? And for me, to save my soul, I need to make sure I have a direct connection to God, and if I'm going to do that, then I need to be able to read God's word for myself and figure out what it's about. That's a very modern way of thinking about religion. The point of all of this is now we're surveying exploration and communications and politics and science and religion. And a huge amount of stuff is happening just in a couple of generations surrounding the year 1500. This is exciting stuff.

1.9 Now, I like this image, or this pair of images. We have on the one, on the right side for me, a very medieval image. We notice the theme is very religious. We have a semi-divine figure who is pushing everybody down into hell, and that's what awaits most of us. We got that poor little guy boiling in a pot of something or other. Probably he deserved it, right? This is the portrayal. But then also there is some attention to the architectural detail, but it's a sort of semi-perspective, but not really. Then, by the time we get to the image now on the left, we have people going about their business. It's a soldier, perhaps a merchant, other people, ordinary people going about their business in the natural world. We're interested in the architecture and what's beyond that. And it's in perspective, it's to scale, and so forth.

1.10 Magnificent work, almost an anthem of the Renaissance and early modernity. Again, somewhat clichéd to all of us now, 500 years later, but Raphael and The School of Athens. When we are looking for heroes, whom do we look to? There are no Judeo-Christian religious figures here. We are looking to the Athenians, those awesome, brilliant intellectuals who made philosophy and all of the philosophical schools possible. We have Pythagoras and Diogenes and some of the hedonists and Cynics and Cyrenaics and various others. Then those two towering giants, rather, of the Athenian world, Plato on the left, with his more otherworldly friendly philosophy, Aristotle, his hand out, saying, "No, it's this world." And that's the big battle that is joined, has been joined. And we are reinvigorating that classical debate now and celebrating it.

1.11 What can we learn from the Greeks? Now, this is a shocking thing for European consciousness over the course of a couple of centuries, as Greek and Roman texts got more and more reintroduced into thinking culture in the European West. Plato and religious philosophy, compatibility with Christianity. There are some tensions there, but we can work with that. But what about this Aristotle fellow, this naturalistic, science-friendly, empirical, this worldly seeking flourishing in the world? What do we make of this fellow? And the debate is then joint, of course.

1.12 From the Greeks and the Romans, at a high level of abstraction, it seems like what we are getting is this idea of naturalism. The natural world matters. Let's study it. Let's learn from it and see it as a perhaps self-contained universe, independently of what the gods want for the world. We're going to study it by reason, logic, developing tools of

mathematics. The early scientists we all have heard of—Pythagoras, of course, and the early physicists and Hippocrates applying scientific matters to medicine. The idea that, self-confidently, we, and of course the Greeks and the Romans, have paragons of self-confidence. We're going to impose our will upon the world, and we're going to achieve something, greatness in politics, in art, in science, in empire, whatever we set our minds to. And that seems in strong contrast to what most thinking people took to be obvious, that the Judeo-Christian tradition is the ultimate truth, that there is a God, that it's a superior beyond the natural world that we take as axiomatic and derive everything that exists, everything that is true, everything that is good from that assumption.

- 1.13** Do we prove it? No, it's an act of faith for the vast majority of us, particularly if we are not one of those who have had a direct mystical connection with God. That's a reserve for a few minorities. So, it will be a dogma—firm, inflexible, absolute principles—that we take on faith about what the supernatural is and what he wants for us. And relatively, we are powerless in our knowledge, in our competence, in our moral character. We are perhaps sinful creatures who cannot help but be sinful creatures. And we should largely either not focus so much on the natural world, putting our attention and hopes in another world, and in extreme cases, even renounce entirely any attachment to the natural world.
- 1.14** We have two civilizations, both of them now ancient by the time we are in 1500. Both of them have come down to us. Both of them seem important. What do we do? What's the relationship going to be, of these two? The two options confronting early modern thinking human beings, one comes from Thomas Aquinas, now Saint Thomas Aquinas, the most important thinker in recent centuries, says graphically, "Let's put the two together." In one hand, he is, of course, holding a church. In his other hand, he is holding a Greek text. They are both open to us. They are also both facing each other. They should be open to each other. And also, interestingly, they're both held at about the same level. They are both of equal importance. So these should be treated as in some way important, and they should work together. And that's our project. How do we put these two together?
- 1.15** That's a huge project. Or with respect to Aristotle, I wanted to say just one more thing about Aquinas, especially Aristotle's philosophy. That's the Greek philosophy we need to try to integrate with Christian philosophy. Or do we take the attitude toward Aristotle that Luther and others, and this is just a wonderful piece of rhetoric, so we have to read it all through. "Aristotle is truly a devil, a horrid calumniator." That's vocabulary-building. That means a liar, but a really bad liar, and a horrid, really bad liar. "A wicked sycophant, a prince of darkness, a beast, a most horrid imposter on mankind, one in whom there is scarcely any philosophy, a public and professed liar, a goat, and his followers are locusts, caterpillars, frogs, and lice." Less than human. So, this is obviously a modern debate, localized on Aristotle in particular. Do we celebrate him

and integrate him into Christianity? Or if we are going to maintain the purity of Christianity, recognize it as an opposite to be shunned? And that's part of a new modern intellectual framework.

- 1.16** Now, into all of this is born Francis Bacon, whom I like to think of, and this is controversial, as the father of modern philosophy or the founder of modern philosophy. In the next lecture, we'll turn to his main competitor, Rene Descartes. But what we have here is an image. Bacon's most read work now is *New Organon*. Now, that's an excerpt from a larger work. But an organon is a tool. It's something that we use. It's an instrument. What Bacon is explicitly doing is recognizing that if we go back to the Greeks, Aristotle, of course, is the first systematizer and developer of most of logic that has come down to us. The six books that Aristotle wrote on logic are typically collected into one work just called the *Organon*. These are the tools you need to know to think well, efficiently, to seek truth, to become more logical in your thinking. What Bacon is arguing is that we need a new organon, either an updated Aristotle or innovations and new understandings of the range of logical and other thinking tools that we need in order to go forward.
- 1.17** Now, the image on the cover of the *Great Instauration*, that's from which *Organon* is excerpted, I think it's wonderful. We have a ship sailing between two columns, and of course, it is small, but we are on that ship. Perhaps a little bit metaphorically, one of the pillars of civilization is the Judeo-Christian tradition. Another pillar, the Greek and Roman tradition. We have been inside the harbor, so to speak, protected. But now, what are we moderns doing? We're going to sail out of the harbor, beyond the protection of these two traditions that have come down to us, and we are going to sail out into the unknown. There is a little ship off in the horizon. We're not the first to go out. We're going to be following others, but we are now on this ship. There are untold new worlds waiting for us to discover.
- 1.18** Now, what I want to do next is turn to the text. Each lecture in this course will have some background, some context, but then there's no better way to really get into the philosophers than to let the philosophers speak for themselves. I want us now to plunge into the *Great Instauration*, published in 1620. The *Novum Organum*, or *New Organon*, is one of the parts of it. It's the one that's most often excerpted. But let's read some of the text in Bacon's words to get an indication of this fellow as an individual.
- 1.19** Now, in one of the prefaces, Bacon writes of himself in the third person. "Francis of Verulam," that's his name, "reasoned thus with himself." So he's reporting in a third-person way on a conversation he's having inside his head. "Being convinced that the human intellect makes its own difficulties." OK, so we cause a lot of problems for ourselves, and now we are centuries and centuries and in millennia into thinking for ourselves. We have made a lot of difficulties for ourselves in the [inaudible]. "He thought all trial should be made, whether that commerce between the mind of man

and the nature of things." Let me just pause there. The nature of things, the mind of man—that's the core philosophical assumption. What is the nature of that intercourse?

1.20 "Which is more precious than anything on Earth, or at least than anything that is of the Earth? Knowledge is the most important thing on Earth. Might by any means be restored to its perfect and original condition, or if that may not be, yet reduced to a better condition than that in which it now is. Now, the errors which have hitherto prevailed." This is right at the opening. "The errors which have hitherto prevailed." When we look at the ancients and all of these great minds and great texts that have come down, he's not starting by saying, "Oh, basically they're all true. Maybe I'm just going to tweak around the margins a little bit." He's emphasizing the errors of the past. When we look at tradition, it is not filled with, but substantially populated with, a lot of mistakes. We're not going to start with any uncritical admiration for past texts, either Judeo-Christian or Greek and Roman. That is a warning sign. That's a strong signal at this point here.

1.21 Down a little bit. The entire fabric of human reason which we employ in the inquisition of nature is badly put together and built up like some magnificent structure without any foundation." Wow. Judeo-Christian does not have a good foundation? Nothing we can learn from the Greeks and Romans is on a secure foundation? If that's true, "there is but one course left, therefore, to try the whole thing anew upon a better plan." Let's start over. How audacious. "And to commence a total reconstruction of sciences, arts, and all human knowledge, raised upon the proper foundations. And though this in the project and understanding, it may seem a thing infinite and beyond all the powers of man." Now, is this too much for us to handle? No. "Yet, when it comes to be dealt with, it will be found sound and sober." We can do it. Big project, yes, the time has come. Let's get on with it. We have the capacity to do so.

1.22 A little dedication to King James and just a little excerpt here, and "I have a request to make." Now, Bacon was pretty high up in the English government, and so he was able to speak this way. But even if he were not, "I have a request to make," and he hopes, of course, that King James will read this, but anybody really who reads this, this is the request that he is making of you. "Follow his example"—that is to say, me, Francis Bacon—"in taking order for the collecting and perfecting of a natural and experimental history." So we're going to collect a lot of natural historical facts. We're going to do a lot of experimenting. Those are, again, two signal concepts in the early modern, true and severe.

1.23 "Unencumbered with literature and book-learning." OK, another shot across the bows. Don't just immediately plunge into books, or think there is one true book, and if you just read this book, it has all of the secrets and mysteries of the universe unveiled for your very attention. In fact, turn away from any books. It doesn't matter if it's a religious book or a secular Greek and Roman book. Don't look in books. Look at nature for yourself and start to do the experiments. If we do that, "philosophy and the

sciences may no longer float in air but rest on the solid foundation of experience of every kind." What are the experiential foundations of knowledge, not book-learning and going into the libraries or listening to wise professors who've just read a bunch of other books and are telling you what's in those books?

- 1.24** Preface. "The state of knowledge is not prosperous nor greatly advancing." Another modern theme. We're not making progress. We're not advancing. Things seem static, but we should be advancing, making knowledge. The idea that somehow everything important, we already know it, and we can just apply it to our own lives, take it for granted. There are no great truths left to be discovered—Bacon arguing the exact opposite. "A way must be opened for the human understanding entirely different from any hitherto known. It seems to me that men do not rightly understand either their store or their strength." Now, let's pause on that. What does he mean by that? It means the store of knowledge or the store of books and beliefs, and then the strength, their strength, their own strength.
- 1.25** "But overrate the one and underrate the other." So there's this store of knowledge collected in libraries, and we overestimate how much good stuff is in there. At the same time, we say we're young, I might be a pretty smart person, but I think, "Oh, my goodness, how smart am I compared to St. Augustine, to Plato, to Cicero? Well, they're up there. I'm down here." And so you don't immediately think of yourself as having the strength to be able to stand up, to think for yourself, perhaps even to challenge and go beyond the great people of the past. Those two blocks we need to get out of our minds right off the bat.
- 1.26** Taking up the first, "the excess of honor and admiration with which our existing stock of inventions is regarded." Let's take the existing books that are handed down to us, the ones that we are supposed to admire and revere, and in some cases, take more or less uncritically or even on faith as dogma. We're going to undercut those in Baconian way. "For let a man look carefully into all that variety of books with which the arts and sciences abound, he will find everywhere endless repetitions of the same thing." You read across the centuries and not really anything new. It's just because, previously in the other generations, they were taught, "All truths are in the earlier texts." Who are you to judge them? You learn them and you repeat them and pass them on to the next generation. That's, of course, what's been going on for centuries. It's just repetitions of the same basic themes over and over again.
- 1.27** So instead, and I love this metaphor that he uses in this next section here, "For its value and utility, it must be plainly avowed that the wisdom which we have derived principally from the Greeks," and the Greeks did some amazing things, Bacon recognizes that, "is but like the boyhood of knowledge and has the characteristic property of boys. It can talk, but it cannot generate, for it is fruitful of controversies but barren of works." Boys can be good talkers. Now we're thinking of boys, and this is the point of the metaphor, who have not yet gone through puberty. They are not yet able

to reproduce something new that can live. They're still boys. All of our knowledge is like that. Boys, of course, can be talkative and chattery and so forth, but they are not yet men who are able to, from within themselves in part, produce something generative of something new, vigorous, and living. So we need to grow up.

1.28 Now, in the mechanical arts, that is to say, people who work with their hands, making machines, tools, and so forth, it's different. "We do not find it so. They, on the contrary, as having in them some breath of life, are continually growing and becoming more perfect." So we have inventions, tools, mechanical systems, workshops, and so forth. "As originally invented, they are commonly rude, clumsy, and shapeless. Afterwards, they acquire new powers and more commodious arrangements and constructions." So they get better and better. You make a crude prototype, but you improve it, you tweak it, and so on. And there is progress being made in the mechanical arts.

1.29 But here we have people who are looking at the world. They are interacting with the world. They are experimenting and thinking and trying things out for themselves. Their mindset and their practice is different from philosophers who go into the library and pull out dusty books. And "philosophy and the intellectual sciences, on the contrary, stand like statues, worshipped and celebrated, but not moved or advanced. Nay, they sometimes flourish most in the hands of the first author, and afterwards degenerate." There are geniuses who come along, they think for themselves, they come up with something special, but it does not get carried on to the next generation, partly for social reasons. But notice this line here: "For men have once made over their judgments to others' keeping." People stop thinking for themselves and they turn their minds over to someone else. I read Plato and I say, "Wow, this man was great. I'm 18 years old and I feel a commitment experience. I am a Platonist. I just henceforth, for the rest of my life, look through Plato's eyes at the world, or whatever text it is that first makes a major impression upon me." And that's the vast majority even of thinking people.

1.30 "And let it not be said that the sciences have been growing rapidly till they have at last reached their full stature." So maybe there's another idea. Maybe you're thinking for yourself, but you come up with this idea. Well, there's really nothing new to discover. There's been centuries and centuries of smart people before me. All of the great truths have already been discovered, so we don't need to even try. And Bacon in the 1600s saying, "No, there's a huge amount out there waiting for us." It is true, there have been some people who think for themselves. There always are in some generation, but we need more and more of those people. Line: "If there have been any who, not binding themselves either to other men's opinions or to their own, but loving liberty." This is an intellectual liberty, giving yourself the liberty to think freely, to think for yourself. You are not in bondage to, or under the tutelage of, some text or some institution beyond yourself. Even those ones, that's a big step, and that's a first one. But then there's a more specific method.

- 1.31** Do they look at the world? "There is none who has dwelt upon experience and the facts of nature as long as is necessary." They might just read books, they might just engage in arguments with other smart people. But the idea that they will empirically go out into the world and do, experiencing it for themselves, for long enough, that's also missing, and that's also absolutely important. And part of it, though, is that we don't have the tools yet to know how to do that—all of the observational commitments, but also the observational tools that will enable us to do so. And then the methods of taking all of those observations and yielding, through analysis and so forth, what can come out of those observations. All of that needs to be developed. "As for those who have given the first place to logic, supposing that the surest helps to the sciences were to be found in that, they have indeed most truly and excellently perceived that the human intellect left to its own course is not to be trusted."
- 1.32** Here we have the idea that, of course, we have to have this commitment. We're going to look at the world and we're going to observe it a lot and we're going to collect our observations and we're going to develop all of these analytical tools. But there's also another problem, and that is to say that the mind itself, the basic equipment that we are born with, comes with weaknesses, and we need to learn about those in-built weaknesses and attend to those as part of our philosophical training. "The logic which has been received is not nearly subtle enough to deal with nature." Good start, Aristotle and all of Aristotle's followers, but we need a more sophisticated logic. "Our steps must be guided by a clue, and the whole way from the very first perception of the senses must be laid out upon a sure plan." Now, the technical term here is empiricism in philosophy—the idea that when we start, we start with the senses, and we use our senses to connect with nature. On the basis of that, we're going to build the whole, then, edifice of knowledge up. That is the empiricist commitment.
- 1.33** In contrast to the idea that we're going to start with a mystical revelation from God, or we are going to turn our backs on the world and read in a book, or I am going to listen to some wise professor and use his words and his knowledge for my own intellectual framework. I will use my senses, and for each of us, that is the foundation of knowledge. Another metaphor to, in this case, sailing. "But as in former ages, when men sailed only by the observation of the stars," so they're observing and they're going out, "they could indeed coast along the shores of the old continent or cross a few small and Mediterranean seas." All right, so we're already using our senses and we're already adventurous enough to go out there into the world. But what's holding them back? "But before the ocean could be traversed and the new world discovered, the use of the mariner's needle, as a more faithful and certain guide, had to be found out." This is the mention of a tool that human beings have devised that aid their senses and make their senses more powerful.
- 1.34** We mentioned the mariner's needle here, but we think of sextant. We think, for astronomers, the astrolabe. The development of tools. That's the organon word. We

need to develop more of those. Once those tools are made, then all of the oceans are available to us. But then, going beyond that metaphor, once we have the intellectual tools in place, all worlds will be open to us. But we also need the tools. It's not just "look." It's "look" aided by tools. "Before we can reach the remoter and more hidden parts of nature, it is necessary that a more perfect use and application of the human mind and intellect be introduced." We will use, of course, tools like the mariner's needles and compasses and astrolabes and microscopes are just being invented, and telescopes are just being invented. Actually, I'm not sure about microscopes yet, but definitely telescopes are coming online.

- 1.35 But we also need logical tools, and then, of course, the mathematical tools to use this other organ that we have. Our minds are an organ, our brain is an organ. Each of them needs to develop sophisticated tools. Now, when we start doing this empirical method, if we recognize, yes, it is one thing to have theories and abstractions, and we want to connect those to the natural world, how do we go about doing this? There's then a methodological principle. "Those who before me have applied themselves to the invention of arts have but cast a glance or two upon facts and examples." So they recognize the importance of facts, empirical facts. They recognize the importance of saying, "I've got this principle, for example, and to give you an example," but it's too scanty. It's not enough yet. We need lots and lots of examples, lots and lots of facts, and we need to start with them and then work our way up to the principles. We're needing to reverse that order.
- 1.36 "I, on the contrary, dwelling purely and constantly among the facts of nature." Purely and constantly among the facts of nature. Spend a lot of time, whatever area of investigation you have, in the facts of nature before you get too theoretical. "Withdraw my intellect from them no further than may suffice to let the images and rays of natural objects meet at a point, as they do in the sense of vision." I might start very small, small examples here, looking at them very closely. Then I might step back to see how all of those particular facts fit into a slightly larger perspective. But I'm not going to go so far away where I can't see those facts anymore. That's as far as I will go. Stick to the facts and work your way up from them. And then about—this an intellectual morality point. Lots of smart people and clever people, and they say that they want to be philosophers and so forth, but what really animates them?
- 1.37 "For I do not endeavor either by triumphs of confutation." People who just like to argue for the sake of arguing. The important point for them is, once they are in the argument with you, whatever position they first committed to, man, they are going to win that debate, no matter what. The important point is to win the argument, not the truth, not the facts. "Or pleadings of antiquity," the kind of thinker for whom, important thinker is, constantly referring to and quoting some great authority in the past and letting the authority of that smart person hopefully carry over to you and make you seem like you are a great smart person as well, because you know the right people to quote in the

right kind of context here. "Or assumptions of authority," saying, "Who am I to question, or who are you to question, some great thinker or some great text of the past?" The authorities have spoken, and using the weight of authority, to cow assent.

- 1.38** "Or even by the veil of obscurity." People like to throw a lot of complicated language at it. Multisyllabic words, great cumbersome paragraphs. So at a certain point, the person you know is just going to give up and say, "OK, fine. I'll let you have it." Or the idea built into that is somehow, if you are using fancy complicated words and seem to have this very cumbersome logical structure, well, you must be really smart and know what you do and you get the benefit of the doubt that way. So people who play all of these intellectual games are not true philosophers, not true scientists. "I, by contrast, I lead them to the things themselves." I will point to the facts. This is natural. Let's look at the world together. "And the concordances of things," those are collections of facts, natural histories, "that they may see for themselves."
- 1.39** That's what a good teacher will do. That's what a philosopher will do for the next generation of philosophy. Look at the things, and I will guide you to those things, but you have to look at them for yourself. What they can dispute, can you argue with these? Do you accept these by your own judgment? And what then can you add to the common stock of knowledge? As for myself, I think I'm a pretty smart guy. I'm speaking first person now as Francis Bacon, say, "Am I now one of these authorities that you are supposed to accept on all of these things, and I've got all of these ideas and hypotheses, right, and so forth?" If, "in anything, I have been either too credulous," maybe I've been a little too fast to believe certain things, too credulous, "or too little awake and attentive, or if I have fallen off by the way and left the inquiry incomplete, nevertheless, I so present things naked and open that my errors may be marked."
- 1.40** That is to say, feel welcome to criticize me. Point out my mistakes. I am open to that. And that is also the lesson and the mark of being, by my light, a true philosopher. Now, I suppose—this is an important one for coming methodological debates — "I have established forever a true and lawful marriage between the empirical and the rational faculty." I'm going to pause there. There has been, and continues to be, in philosophy, a divide between those who want to say, "Knowledge is based on the senses and builds up from the senses." That's the empirical approach. And those who argue, "Logic is a function of our rational capacity." We have the senses, but we also have a mind that is able to do conceptualizations, abstractions, universal principles, and to think very big pictures of things. Logical principles, mathematical principles, and so forth.
- 1.41** But what's the connection between the evidence of our senses, which is typically of things that are particular and variable, and our rational understanding of things, which is typically in terms of abstract, general, unchanging propositions and concepts that go into those propositions? The one side wanting to say, look, mathematics, for example, is about absolute unchanging truths. But when we look at the world, we see particular changing things. So if, ultimately, knowledge is rational, and mathematics is a

paradigmatic example of that, it has to have a source other than the senses. So reason has its own resources or access to its own set of proofs. And this is the rationalist move. And this is what Bacon is talking about. "I want to establish forever a true and lawful marriage between between the empirical and the rational faculty." My senses work with my reason. My rationality is based on observation of fact, and those need to be married, integrated, rather than giving precedence to one over the other. Actually, he's giving precedence, of course, to the empirical, but not an opposition, ultimately, to the rational, how the rational comes out of that.

1.42 "The unkind and ill-starred divorce and separation of which has thrown into confusion all the affairs of the human family." In one way, Bacon is exactly right to focus on the philosophy history up to his time, but he's also prescient in saying this is going to continue to be a divide that causes big problems for philosophy as it goes down the road, the divide between the empiricists and the rationalists. "I would address one general admonition to all—that they consider what are the true ends of knowledge, and that they seek it not either for pleasure of the mind." Why are we seeking knowledge? The value issue. Why does it matter? Why is this important? He's saying, "Knowledge is not an end in itself." We don't become philosophers just because we like to think about complicated things and put together intellectual puzzles. We don't seek knowledge of the true and important things just so that we can admire them and contemplate them and bask in their glory, perhaps.

1.43 "Nor for contention." We don't seek knowledge and do thinking for the sake of arguing contentiously. "Or for superiority to others." I'm smarter than you are. I know more than you are. "Or for profit or fame or power or any of these inferior things." Not that those are bad things, but they are not the most important things. "But for the benefit and use of life." Now, the famous formulation that comes out of Francis Bacon is, "Knowledge is power." Knowledge is power. Knowledge is not an end in itself. Knowledge is not for the seeking of it, just fun. It is a tool, an important tool, the most important tool we have for the furtherance of life in this life, in this world, in the here and now. Knowledge is a powerful tool, of course, if we have acquired it correctly and we apply it properly. That is hugely foundational to the modern. We're not trying to get beyond life, beyond the world, to some realm that we are just going to admire and contemplate. Knowledge is for the benefit and use of life.

1.44 Now, that is the general introduction to the Great Instauration, the great rebuilding of knowledge that Bacon is proposing after centuries of often impressive things, but things that have reached a dead end, that are sterile and not productive of new and original ideas, and new original tools. And this was a programmatic work. He did not finish all of it, but he does tell us what his plan for the overall structure was. The New Organon is the most important part, where he starts to work out, what are these new tools? What's the new logic that we want to add to the existing logic? Is there anything in the existing stock of logical understandings that we need to modify, and so forth?

- 1.45 All right. Now, he then starts saying, more systematically, what have we learned from the past? And we're going to skip over all of that. "Having thus coasted past the ancient arts, the next point is to equip the intellect for passing beyond." So, go back to that metaphor of we all have eyes and we can look at the world and we can decide that we are, for ourselves, going to use our own eyes and look at the world, and we can become actively minded and go out and explore the world. But then we also then want to give tools to the eye—spectacles, the mariner's needle, telescopes, and so forth. Now we want to do the same thing for the mind, tools for the mind, intellectual tools that are going to, just as those other tools make the eye more powerful, make our minds more powerful.
- 1.46 "The art which I introduce with this view is a kind of logic, though the difference between it and the ordinary logic is great and, indeed, immense." That's a bold claim. So, Pythagoras and Parmenides, and then, in the next generation, Aristotle, all of these great mathematicians and logicians, now 2,000 years earlier, really smart guys. "Well, I'm going to do something better, something more important." So, that audacity of the modern. "Mine differs from it, the traditional logic, in three points. Viz.," that's namely, "the end aimed at, in the order of demonstration, and the starting point." So where we begin, how we proceed, and where we're trying to get to. "My logic differs on all three of those things." First one is now familiar to us. "We are not using logic just for the sake of arguments." We're making our arguments more complicated, more vigorous, more effective in social debates, and so forth. "Rather, the end is arts, applications." We want to be able to do things with it. Emphasizing that point, as well.
- 1.47 "We're not trying to just overcome an opponent in argument, but to command nature in action." That's why we do reasoning and use logic. Here is then the major proposal that he is making. "For the ordinary logic, almost all the work is spent about the syllogism." This is largely true to this day. You take a course in introductory logic. The first course, the bulk of it, is going to be on the syllogism. The syllogism is a very formalized structuring of reasoning, typically two premises and then a conclusion. The standard example is to say, "All humans are mortal, Socrates is a human, therefore Socrates is mortal." We learn that that is a valid argument. We learn to focus on the structure of the subject and the predicate and how many terms and the relationships of the terms. We look at the formal apparatus.
- 1.48 We also learn that if we try to do syllogisms that have three terms, two premises, and a conclusion, there's actually like 256 different ways of doing syllogistic arguments. So we elaborate all 256 of them, but only 24 of those 256 are valid. The others lead you astray. A good logic course will teach you to recognize those 24, and more or less automate those in your thinking and, hopefully, if you do enough practice examples, when you come across the others, a little red flag goes up in your mind, and you do a double-check and so forth. This is deductive, syllogistic logic, and it's a very powerful tool. It's a very impressive intellectual achievement, largely due to Aristotle.

- 1.49 In contrast to syllogism, which is a deductive argument, is induction. This is the big point for Bacon. One way of focusing on the differences between these two is to say, in deduction, we always start with some general abstract principle, and then we apply that to particular cases. In the example, I said, "All human beings are mortal." Well, that's all human beings. That's a universal. That's a big whopping generalization. I'm claiming of every single human being that they have this property, mortality. I take that as a given, then I apply it to a particular case. Socrates, he's a particular individual. Then I draw a conclusion. Logically, in this case, Socrates is mortal.
- 1.50 If I'm good, I might then start playing around with that general principle. I could say, "Well, all humans are mortal." That is to say, also, I could say, "No humans are immortal." And recognize that that's a logically equivalent proposition. And we will give that one a name. We will call that the obverse of the initial proposition. So all humans are mortal. The obverse is no humans are immortal. And I will check the logic. And if we use that very general principle, even though it's a negative formulation, now the logic still holds. So that one works.
- 1.51 Or I could say, "All humans are mortal." That means, perhaps, that all immortal beings are nonhuman. And we'll then say, "Oh, that actually is logically equivalent." We'll call that one the contrapositive. We're having a lot of fun working with language and flipping it around and positives and negatives all in this general universal space. "I'll become very good at that and become very proud of my intellectual abilities as a logician because I can take all of these formulations and play around with them and sort all of this stuff out." Now, Bacon is impressed, but not that impressed. Of induction, "the logicians seem hardly to have taken any serious thought, but they pass it by with a slight notice. I, on the contrary, reject demonstrations by syllogism as acting too confusedly, and letting nature slip out of its hands."
- 1.52 When I went down this very interesting road of saying, "All human beings are mortal," well, how do I know that? Your logic professor says, "That's just an empirical matter. We're not concerned with that." We're going to take that for granted, and then see what we can do with that. We start playing around with the words and we come up with very sophisticated structures. We give everything a name and proper definitions and we do tables, and everything is beautiful and lovely. But do I really know that all human beings are mortal? It seems like I'm really interested in truth. Yeah, once we get that general truth, it's nice to know that we can apply it in various ways. But how do we get these very general truths in the first place? That's where induction comes in, and Bacon wants to say, "That's the more important thing."
- 1.53 How many humans have you observed? Under what sort of circumstances? Have you verified this for yourself? Before we get to these high general principles, let's do the empirical. "Now, if the very notions of the mind," all these general principles, "be improperly and overhastily abstracted from facts, if they are vague, not sufficiently definite, faulty—in short, in many ways, the whole edifice tumbles." This is Bacon's

criticism. People too quickly get to these general principles or they just receive these general principles from other sources, and then they can be very clever at manipulating them and doing all sorts of things with them. But often, those general principles are not well grounded.

- 1.54 "In dealing with the nature of things, I use induction throughout. Hence, it follows that the order of demonstration is likewise inverted, for hitherto the proceeding has been to fly at once from the sense and particulars up to the most general propositions." Philosophers love their abstractions, their general principles, their speculative principles, and so on, and they get there very quickly. What we want is to be much more careful, empirically, and slowly, slowly build up. "Now, my plan is to proceed regularly and gradually from one axiom to another, so that the most general are not reached till the last." Lots of observations, lots of work to get up to those general principles. All human beings are mortal. That's a lot of human beings you're talking about. We need to do a lot of observation to get there.
- 1.55 "The greatest change I introduce is in the form itself of induction and the judgments made thereby. For the induction of which the logicians speak, which proceeds by simple enumeration, is a puerile thing, concludes at hazard," and so on. OK, and this is one of the criticisms often of Bacon is that he is just a very simple inductive reasoner, and this is to put paid to that notion. Somehow, he's talking about—we're just going to look at things. "I see a bird there. I see this red bird and another red bird, and this red bird is too close to that red bird, so this red bird chases that red bird away." That's one example of two red birds being a little bit territorial. I'm observing nature. Then, a few days later, I look at these red birds over here. "Oh, there's one there and another one there, and this one's chasing that one off." Now I've got two examples, and I said, "Oh, I guess these red birds are territorial," and that then functions as a general principle in my mind. That is simple enumeration. I have this example, I have this example, maybe I have one or two other examples. On the basis of that, I go to a very general abstract principle—all red birds are territorial.
- 1.56 And Bacon is wanting to say, "No, that's childish." That's fine, but that's still at the boyhood level of induction. What I'm talking about is going to be a more sophisticated thing. "What the sciences stand in need of is a form of induction which shall analyze experience and take it to pieces." We're not just observers. We're going to look at things and, metaphorically and literally, take them apart. How does this work? Dissection, of course—we're talking about the birds in this case. We're going to take the birds apart. We're going to be looking at birds in all sorts of circumstances. And the "take things to pieces" is to break things down into their variables, as we now speak it. Then to play around with all of those variables in an experimental way. And only after we've done a whole lot of that with lots and lots of examples, then, cautiously, we will go up to some sort of bigger generalization.

- 1.57 Now, we, of course, can imagine philosophers in this situation and say, "Well, there's red birds, red birds, red birds, territorial. All red birds are territorial. I guess all living things are territorial. Human beings—we've now explained all wars because everybody is just territorial." Then I'm launched off on some disquisition on the nature of human beings and their warlike tendencies and so forth. That is exactly what Bacon wants to reject. "Laborious work, extracted not merely out of the depths of the mind, but out of the very bowels of nature." We're going to get into the very bowels of nature, deeper and firmer and so on. Now, we're valorizing the senses, we're valorizing the empirical, we're valorizing the experimental method, but we have an additional problem—this organ we're using, our sense organs and our mind.
- 1.58 "The information of the sense itself I sift and examine in many ways, for certain it is that the senses deceive; and at the same time, they supply the means of discovering their own errors." We can't even assume that our tools are working perfectly all of the time. What are we going to do with that problem? Then, he's then suggesting here, well, we then have to take a critical look at our own sense organs. Whenever we are using our senses, if we're going to take those observational facts as importantly, have a critical look at the conditions under which my sense is working, and is it working accurately? Because I know sometimes that can be a very slippery, deceptive type of thing to work with. "How are we going to do this?" Well, by experiments. Sometimes things look a certain color. The lighting changes. They look a different color. I look at it from this angle, I look at it from that angle, different color. But I keep tabs on all of that, all of the conditions, all of the angles. Then I play around with that experimentally, so that any resulting analysis of what sensory observation I'm going to take as factual and put it at the foundation, I have checked all of that.
- 1.59 "They would be sufficient of themselves if the human intellect were even and like a fair sheet of paper with no writing on it." Right, here's a tabula rasa mention. Are we to understand the human being, the human mind, in a tabula rasa sense? And in some ways, yes, in other ways, no. All of our knowledge, Bacon is going to argue, has to come through the senses. We don't have an inborn stock of knowledge. But at the same time, the organs themselves, they have some sort of—they're not just sheets of paper that things get written on by nature. Our minds do various sorts of things. We have to engage in a lot of processes. "Since the minds of men are strangely possessed and beset so that there is no true, even surface left to reflect the genuine rays of things, it's necessary to seek a remedy for this as well."
- 1.60 This is the famous "idols of the mind" section. Something about the human mind. We are too quick to want to go to the general principles from the examples. That seems to be an innate feature of the mind. We want to get there too quickly. We have to correct that. We are credulous. We like to take other people's word for things. We're too believing of people, particularly people that we are trusting or are presented to us as authorities. There's something in the mind that makes us very accepting. We have to be

aware of this and counter this. We love our own ideas. "I made this idea up. I have this idea." We are too credulous with respect to our own ideas and less likely to take a critical stance with respect to those. All of these are idols, things that we worship in the mirror, and they come as part of the furniture of the mind. We need to be aware of those, also, and take steps to correct them. It's not only studying nature, it's studying ourselves, operating on nature, operating on ourselves, to make ourselves better and to make nature better. They are hard to eradicate, so it's a lot of work and education to build it up.

- 1.61** Now, I want to jump to some aphorisms from the *Novum Organum*. These are some of the ones that come down to us from Francis Bacon. People who've read Bacon, they know these quotations, and they get thrown around, and we're supposed to know as educated people where these come from. But these are the ones that are justly important, very modern, very Baconian.
- 1.62** Aphorism one: "Man being the servant and interpreter of nature." OK, so that's a theme that's been important here. But now, cycling back to our beginning theme about this is the birth of the modern that we are focusing on. How many works by learned people, prior to the modern world, would start by saying, "Man is a servant of," and it's not nature? I am a servant of some higher being. The whole work is preoccupied with and focused on what it is to be a good servant of the higher being. I am a servant of nature. Now, I'm not doubting a higher being. Bacon is not an atheist, but that's not where we as human beings start, not in the modern world. I'm not trying to interpret the word of God or what God's mind does, or if I'm looking at nature, seeing everything that happens in nature as an omen or a sign of God's plan, or the gods' plan for the world. I am interpreting nature itself for what it is.
- 1.63** Next point. "Neither the naked hand nor the understanding left to itself can effect much." We have a hand, which is an amazing tool that we can use. But what we can do with our hands, when we have hammers and pliers and wrenches and axes, and that whole panoply of tools that human beings—we can take a relatively puny physical specimen and do just incredible things. Bacon is, by analogy, saying the same thing for the mind. Equip the mind with the right intellectual tools. We can understand it. "It is by instruments and helps that the work is done, which are as much wanted for the understanding as for the hand."
- 1.64** Probably the second most quoted line from Bacon ever, this one here. "Nature to be commanded must be obeyed." And both parts are very interesting here. "Nature must be obeyed," and built into that is the idea the world has a causal structure. There are fundamental rules of nature, principles of nature, laws of nature, whatever formulation. The world is what it is. It goes the way that it goes. That has to be our basis. Our attitude has to be, we accept the world is as it is, and we can't change that. But we can command it, if we understand it. That's the second part. We can figure it out. We can take it apart. We can reconstitute it, of course, using the laws or the

principles of nature as it really is, working within them. But we are not slaves to nature as it is. We will obey at the same time we will command, and the new philosophy will give us the tools to command nature as it is upon an objective understanding of the way the world is.

1.65 "The sciences we now possess are merely systems for the nice ordering and setting forth of things already invented." We're just tidying things up. They're not yet methods for inventions or directions for new works. That's very modern. Our emphasis on discovery, production of the new, innovation, as we now like to call this word. "As the sciences which we now have do not help us in finding out new works, so neither does the logic which we have now help us in finding out the new sciences." The new, the new, the new. Forward progress, benefit of human life, working on ourselves for the improvement of the human condition.

1.66 From the ancients, building on Aristotle, criticizing him in some respects, criticizing the Greeks, certainly criticizing those who are now his slavish followers in Bacon's direction, whom he thinks as dominating most of the institutions of learning at his time, but nonetheless, building on the good parts, being willing to challenge, to question, to develop new tools for the mind, to explore this new world that has been opened to us. The modern is born.

Lecture 2: Radical Doubt

At a glance — Radical doubt — Descartes.

- 2.1 "What do I really know?" That is a philosophy question, but it's a particularly important modern philosophy question. When you do searches or read history of philosophy books and you ask, "Who is the founder or father of modern philosophy?", the most common answer is René Descartes. There's a really good case to be made for that historical significance. I want to start in 1596, and that is the year René Descartes is born in France. But obviously, it's toward the end of the 1500s, and a huge amount of cultural and particularly intellectual ferment is occurring. He's born into an extraordinarily vigorous intellectual time.
- 2.2 Now, we mentioned in the first lecture, Andreas Vesalius, with his early anatomical studies, meticulous, careful, important, modern work, founding anatomy as a modern science with all the implications that has for biology in general, medicine, and the improvement of the human condition there. But with Vesalius comes controversy because, not only are we focusing on the body and not on, say, the soul, our modern preconceptions or our modern preoccupations are shifting in a more physicalist direction. There are disturbing things because where is this soul? And it doesn't appear in Vesalius's manuscript. And the anatomists who are following and working with Vesalius are basically saying, "When we look around in the body, we don't find a soul or a mind. What we see is physical parts, and we describe those in great detail. Even when we get to the brain and we start taking the brain apart, we see material processes in it."
- 2.3 One of his colleagues had studied the human heart, and we think of, partly allegorically, the importance of the human heart, the seat of the emotions, the seat of the soul. Well, the part is just a pump. If you look at the heart of a pig and the heart of a human being, they're basically the same. It's a demystification of the human being, a move in the direction of a materialistic, physicalistic, even more mechanical understanding. The disquieting question is, what does this mean for our understanding ourselves as rational, as endowed with a higher consciousness, with a spirit, with a soul? That is a sharply pointed-up question, obviously, in modern times.
- 2.4 Now, jumping then to the next generation—Englishman Thomas Hobbes, also important in this time period, but notice what he gets to in a very ruthless, materialistic fashion quickly in the early modern. "Seeing life is but a motion of limbs." That's a shorthand way. It's only a motion of limbs. It's just movement. "The beginning whereof is in some principal part within. Why may we not say that all automata (engines that move themselves by springs and wheels as doth a watch) have an artificial life? For what is the heart, but a spring; the nerves, but so many springs; and the joints, but so many wheels giving motion to the body?" So we can explain the entirety of the human

being, what it is to be alive, in materialistic terms. That's disquieting in the modern world.

- 2.5 One thing on Descartes' mind is he's friendly to the science, but he also is friendly to some elements of traditional religion. How are we going to put those together ? The Galileo affair is hugely important also for Descartes . We mentioned the older-model understanding , not so much looking inward at the human being, look outward toward the heavens. What is the universe? And this is a model that came down from a great Greek scientist, Ptolemy, that put the Earth at the center and everything rotates in circles around each of the planets and out to the side, and we get out to the heavens. And beyond that, presumably the gods or God . Everything also goes in a circle. And this is something that is pleasing to the traditional mind, particularly a traditional religious mind, that consists of the world as created by a God, and God is a perfect being, and the circle is a perfect shape. It doesn't change its direction all the time . It just keeps going eternally in the same direction. It makes sense that God, when he created the universe, would have created it circularly, and with us on the Earth at the center of his magnificent creation.
- 2.6 So it's unsettling then, as Copernicus does in 1543, publish just before he dies, the idea that we're going to decenter the Earth and put it as a satellite off to the side, orbiting around the planets. What does this say? And then very soon, the idea that it circles is going to give way to what we now think of as ellipsis. So is the world then less perfect? Are we in a less special place ? Are we just automata, like other machines on this planet , orbiting some distant center? Disquieting questions.
- 2.7 Now, Galileo, partly of the affair, was when he was a young scientist, stayed away from these more dangerous debates over whether the sun or the Earth was at the center of the solar system, because he was aware that it was politically dangerous, not only philosophically fraught. And so he focused more on terrestrial mechanics and some work in optics. He made his own telescope , for example, having heard about this being invented somewhere in northern Europe. But he then started to look up at the moon, started to look at the other planets, and got more interested in astronomy. And one very interesting thing he discovered—you can see his excitement in 1610 when he looks at Jupiter with his new telescope, seven-power telescope, and he sees something that no one has seen before. Jupiter has moons.
- 2.8 How exciting is that? And he writes this up, that Jupiter has moons . And immediately, he is in hot water, theologically. Because now, if Jupiter has moons, the problem is, that means that in the system, whether it's a sun-centered system or an Earth-centered system, we have more than seven objects that we are dealing with. You can do the count. Sun, Moon , Earth, Mercury, blah, blah, blah. You get up to seven. If Jupiter has moons, there's more than seven . One indicative debate at this time about the birth of the modern contrasted to traditional ways of thinking is, when we think about the number seven, well, it's just a number in the number sequence, but it doesn't have any

special symbolic or theological significance. We just use it in our calculations. If it comes out seven, seven, fine. If it comes out some other number, fine. Versus seeing numbers as a key to deeper theological mysteries of the universe.

2.9 For example: "This message is sent to you," right out of the Bible, "by the one who has seen the sevenfold spirit of God and the seven stars." Right there in scripture. Seven. Are we challenging scripture? Galileo wants to say, "Well, I saw them with my eyes. And this new instrument, this new tool that aids the eye, the telescope." We can do some calculations and do math and logic and so forth. And it's not seven. It doesn't add up. But seven matters. Now, one of the arguments against Galileo—I love this, just the nature of this argument—why it has to be that there are only seven? "There are seven windows given to animals in the domicile of the head." That lovely archaic language. That's to say, the human head has seven holes in it. Two ears, two eyes, two nostrils, and a mouth. Seven. God's greatest creation, it is made on a seven template.

2.10 "From this and many other similarities in nature, such as the seven metals, which were tedious to enumerate, we gather that the number of planets is necessarily seven." Notice the argument. "We necessarily gather." We conclude there has to be seven planets because there are seven metals in the Earth, and the human head has seven openings. Therefore, this is exactly the kind of logic that Francis Bacon is complaining about in the previous lecture. "Moreover, these alleged satellites of Jupiter are invisible to the naked eye, and therefore can exercise no influence on the Earth. And therefore would be useless, and therefore do not exist. Besides, from the earliest times, men have adopted the division of the week into seven days and have names after the seven planets. Now, if we increase the number of planets, this whole and beautiful system falls to the ground."

2.11 "You're just wrong, Galileo. This is our reasoning." Now, Galileo is not impressed, but he is aware that he's treading on dangerous grounds, religiously and politically. But he's encouraged when Pope Urban VIII becomes Pope because he was a more liberal guy, Galileo thought. He knew him personally. And so Galileo comes out and argues, not directly, but for the new heliocentric, sun-centric, model of the universe. And he puts it actually in the form of a dialogue between one person arguing for the Earth-centered and one person arguing for the sun-centered. But if you're paying attention, by the end of this dialogue, it's clear who's getting the better of the argument, and its characters who are doing the dialogue.

2.12 Nonetheless, he's in hot water, and the church responds relatively quickly with an official proclamation in a codex, 1616. Galileo had been publishing his work, 1610, 1615. Proposition is to be forbidden, explicit censorship regime, "that the sun is immovable at the center of the heaven." Can't say that. "That the Earth is not at the center of the heaven." You cannot say that. "And is not immovable." Can't say that, "but moves by a double motion," spinning on its axis, that's one motion. And then the whole thing going around the sun, that's the double. All of that, wrong, not true. You

shall not say it. This is before separation of church and state. The church is both a religious authority and a political authority. Galileo was working in Italy, Catholic Italy. This is a serious piece of business. He's put on trial. He's shown the instruments of torture. He is confined to, after he recants publicly, to house arrest, not allowed to publish for the rest of his life.

- 2.13** Now, why this matters to Descartes? Descartes, born in 1596, is a young man coming to intellectual maturity. He is a teenager, but a very smart teenager. When all of these debates about human automata, the implications of the new anatomy and physiology, the debates over the heavens and so forth are going on, Galileo is silenced in Catholic Italy. Descartes is in Catholic France, and he decides, as a young man, he's going to get out. He wants to be able to do his philosophy. He wants to be able to do his science. He needs a cultural place where he can pursue his thinking independently. For the rest of his life, except for occasional visits, he did not come back to France. All of his works were published outside of France. He spent most of his time in the northern part of Europe—Holland, especially, the Netherlands famed for its toleration at this particular time.
- 2.14** Now, his most famous work is the *Meditations*, and I now want to spend some time on the *Meditations*. I always think it's best to go to the author and let him or her speak in their own words, partly in the language of the times. Obviously, we're translating into English in some cases here. But this is often seen as the founding text for modern philosophy. Partly, we want to understand it on its own terms, but also to contrast it with Francis Bacon. It's to telegraph what we do know is the subsequent developments in modern philosophy, there's an early split between the rationalists and the empiricists. Descartes is going to take us in the more rationalists direction. They're both modern. They're both advocates of reason, but their understanding of what it is to be a modern and what it is to be a reasonable person are divergent.
- 2.15** I'm going to just take this title here. It's a meditation. That's a kind of rhetorical form where you're going to speak in the first person. What's going on in your thoughts? What you're thinking about. You're meditating on things. The idea often is, you are taking some time away from daily life and the hurly-burly and the noise of the external world. You might have retreated to a cave or some such place, to a quiet place where you can be alone with your thoughts. And that's the rhetorical form Descartes is starting with. And this *Meditation One* is arguably the most influential text for the rationalist tradition in modern philosophy.
- 2.16** But notice how he starts: "Of the things of which we may doubt." So we're not starting with, interestingly, the things that we know for sure, or these are the truths, or these are dogmas, or these are the correct views, and I'm going to argue for them. Instead, we're starting with the negative. There's lots of things, of course, that I believe, but how many of those are actually true? He starts in first-person form. This is also interesting. I'm not writing as a third-person, distant, disinterested, academic writer.

This is me, René, my thoughts, what's going on inside my head. "Several years have now elapsed since I first became aware that I had accepted, even from my youth, many false opinions for true." Let's pause on that. Is that correct? By the time you are a young adult and you're a thoughtful person, then you start to realize a lot of things that I accepted as true, turned out not to be true. So I got thousands and thousands of beliefs kicking around in my head, but a lot of them are probably not true.

2.17 "And that, consequently, what I had afterward based on such principles was highly doubtful." So you start from something that's not true, no matter how logical and reasonable you are. On the basis of that, whatever you infer, is likely not to be true. "And from that time, I was convinced of the necessity of undertaking once in my life to rid myself of all the opinions I had adopted, and of commencing anew the work of building from the foundation, if I desired to establish a firm and abiding superstructure in the sciences." OK, a lot packed into there. High ambition, very modern. Like Descartes, we need a foundation for the sciences, the new impressive sciences that are coming along. I'm going to step up and do my part for the doing of that. We will be doing a foundational project. What are the foundations of knowledge on which we're going to build this magnificent new edifice?

2.18 But the problem is that I'm coming in, in my building, so to speak. I don't necessarily have secure foundations, and a lot of the rooms are populated by beliefs that are not necessarily true, and I don't know which of them are true or which are not. So, I put time aside. I'm going to start this project finally. "Today, then, since I have opportunely freed my mind from all cares, and am happily disturbed by no passions"—I'm calm, cool, collected, I have the time—"I will at length apply myself earnestly and freely to the general overthrow of all my former opinions." I'm going to take the entire stock of beliefs in my mind and overthrow all of them. Then, of course, by extension, the entire tradition, because he's now an educated young man. Some of the best schools in France, and he's read a lot. Overthrow all of that to see what can be doubted and what survives.

2.19 How am I going to do this? There's a problem because how many beliefs do I have in my mind? You don't know, but you do know it's a huge number. How am I going to figure out which ones are true and which ones are false, which ones are probable, which ones are doubtful? If I start by saying, "Well, I have this belief," and then I consider it, then I go on to the next one, well, this is going to take lifetimes just to go through. So I need a method to divide and conquer, so to speak, to carve up the intellectual territory to deal with categories of beliefs. And so, what I'm going to ask then is, all of these beliefs that I have in my mind, how did they get into my mind in the first place? Where did they come from?

2.20 And of course, we then start to say, well, some of them are things that I saw for myself. Some of them I heard from my friends or I heard from my parents. Some of them I read in books. Some of them I'm not sure where they came from. Other ones, I know they

ended up in my mind because I was putting ideas together and making inferences of various sorts. I'm going to try to make a taxonomy of where all of my ideas came from. And one of the important elements of that taxonomy is, of course, my senses. Lots of things I saw from observing the world with my own senses. So that's one possible source of knowledge. What's the status of sensory knowledge?

- 2.21 "All that I have, up to this moment, accepted as possessed of the highest truth and certainty, I received from or through the senses." I recognize, I heard a lot of things from my friends, but 8-year-old kids, 12-year-old kids, those are not the most reliable authorities in the world, so anything that came from that source, I'm going to set aside. That's doubtful. Might be true, but I'm not going to use that as the foundation for all of the sciences. My parents—more authoritative than 8- and 12-year-old kids, but also doubtful. Things I've read in books. Well, we know a lot of times, books contradict each other. Books say all kinds of things that are false. So, the best candidate is going to be this empirical candidate.
- 2.22 "I observed, however, that these sometimes mislead us." That's to say, sometimes the senses are subject to illusions, or I might say, false perceptions. I see things that aren't there or I don't see them as they really are. Or sometimes it might even be that I'm feeling a little bit sick and that plays with my sense organs and things. I'm not tasting them the way they really are or smelling them the way they are. So my senses sometimes mislead us. "And it is the part of prudence not to place absolute confidence in that by which we have even once been deceived." This is important because then what Descartes wants to include is, we are looking for the foundations of the sciences, at those foundations, for them to be secure.
- 2.23 We need to have true things, but absolutely certain things, so that when we start to build, there's no possibility of falsehood infecting the later developments. We're not going to build upon sand or anything that is going to decay over time. But now we have a problem because, if we wanted to say that I'm going to base the sciences on sensory observations, but the senses are sometimes deceptive, that means the senses are not giving us things that are absolutely certain. Therefore, big therefore, the senses are not the foundations for knowledge. The entire empiricist project, we need to set that aside and start somewhere else. That's huge.
- 2.24 So by analogy, you're a kid, you meet dogs, some of them are friendly, some of them are not friendly. You get bitten by a dog. You never trust dogs entirely again. The senses have deceived us. Sometimes they give us good information, but other times they bite. We're not going to trust the senses entirely. We're going to need a different foundation for knowledge. Then he goes on as, oh, come on. That sounds a bit radical. "How could I deny that I possess these hands and this body without being classed with persons in a state of insanity?" Listen, that's a bit much, René. You want me to say I'm not sure that I have hands, that I have a body? Isn't that insane? Well, no, not necessarily.

- 2.25 Then he makes a transition to another argument. He says, well, look, sometimes I take things to be real, and they're not real. It's not just only the issue that sometimes I think I'm looking at things and they have certain qualities, but I find out later that my senses were deceiving me, so I have to do some adjustment there, so I can doubt my senses. But how do I even know that when I think I am sensing the world, I'm really sensing the world, and not just some imaginary thing in my mind? I know my imagination is active and it comes up with its own things, and this especially happens when I dream. Will this be true? "I must nevertheless here consider that I am a man and that, consequently, I am in the habit of sleeping, and representing to myself in dreams those same things, or even sometimes others less probable, which the insane think are presented to them in their waking moments."
- 2.26 So, insane people, when they're awake, can't tell the difference between what's reality and what's not reality. But even if you're not insane, you sleep. When you are sleeping, you're not in a position to know the difference between what's real and what's not real. We have all had that experience of dreaming something and it seems really real . Sometimes it's nice, sometimes it's not so nice, and then you wake up and, "oh, that was only a dream." That's possible for us. That raises another possibility that maybe right now I am dreaming. I think I'm awake, but if I'm dreaming, I'm not in that self-critical state of knowing the difference between sleeping and waking. Maybe in just a few seconds or a minute, I'm going to wake up and realize, "oh, this is all just a dream that I'm undertaking right now." That could be the case.
- 2.27 Do I know for absolute certain right now that I am not dreaming , that I am awake and preserving things? And Descartes wants you to say, "No ." I'm pretty sure, but pretty sure is not good enough. We want certainty. So how do I know I'm not dreaming? How do I know my senses are not deceiving me? There's a couple of things I can doubt. One is, I can doubt that I'm sensing the world accurately , and I can also doubt that I'm even sensing the world right now. It could be that I am projecting. "At the present moment, however, I certainly look upon this paper with eyes wide awake." So Descartes saying, I'm looking at the paper and doing these writings. "The head which I now move is not asleep. I extend this hand consciously and, with express purpose, I grab my pen and I perceive it. The occurrences in sleep are not so distinct as all this."
- 2.28 Maybe I can get out of this because, and this seems really clear and very distinct right now, and dreams are not like that. He said, actually, dreams sometimes are very clear and very distinct. Here he's absolutely convinced that those things are real and happening, so that's not going to work. "I feel greatly astonished," when I think this line of argument, "and in amazement, I almost persuade myself that I am now dreaming." Now, OK, so suppose we go, though, inside dreams or inside the subject. I imagine things, maybe I dream things, and maybe a lot of the things that I imagine or I dream, when I analyze them, I realize they can't actually be true. So even if I'm not sure I'm sensing the world accurately, or even if I'm sensing the world, suppose I'm just inside

my own head. Are there things inside my own head of which I can still be absolutely certain, even if I'm dreaming, even if my senses are deceiving me? And he wants to say, yes, it seems like there are such things.

2.29 Here, he gives some strong examples. Let's look at the sciences, physics, astronomy, medicine, and so on. All of those things are studying objects out there in the world. I sense things and study them with my physics. I look at the heavens and I study them, or I'm doing medicine with respect to the human body. Now, all of those sciences depend on, I'm sensing, analyzing, and I'm actually awake doing so. So, all of those sciences, in fact, are doubtful. I can't take any of the alleged truths that come from those fields and use them as true because I might be dreaming and I might be mis-sensing. But—and this is a big but—"arithmetic, geometry, and the other sciences contain somewhat that is certain and indubitable. For whether I am awake or dreaming, it remains true that 2 and 3 makes 5, and that a square has but four sides."

2.30 OK, let's pause on that one. Two plus three equals. Do I need my senses for that? No. Suppose I'm dreaming and I'm having a strange math dream. Let's do some arithmetic tables. Two plus three in my dreams. Does it matter that I'm dreaming, if I'm doing math in my dreams? No. Math is still math, even in my dreams. So two plus three equals five is true. It can be known to be true, even if my senses are deceiving me, even if I'm dreaming. If we're looking for a true, indubitable, absolutely certain foundation for the sciences and all of our knowledge, maybe mathematics is it. Because mathematics doesn't depend upon empirical validation. Mathematics can be validated entirely self-sufficiently by the resources of the mind itself, even if it's entirely disconnected from the external world. "Truths so apparent cannot," to put it negatively, "fall under suspicion." But how much can I doubt? Or can I even doubt math? That will be our next question.

2.31 He seems to go on a little digression here. One of the ideas kicking around in my mind, one of my beliefs, is a "belief that there's a God who is all powerful and who created me such as I am. This belief has, for a long time, obtained steady possession of my mind." OK, so what do I know about this God? Well, he's all-powerful, and he's also supposed to be all-knowing. He's a perfect being and all good. I have this idea. Do I know that God knows everything? Do I know that God is all good? Do I know that God is all powerful? Well, that's hard because I can imagine that there's a godlike being. It doesn't contain all of those. I can imagine a God that is, say, all-powerful, all-knowing, but wicked. I can imagine a Satan or a devil, demon-type of creature. That's also part of the furniture of my mind. So, of all of the godlike beings that I can imagine in the furniture of my mind, how do I know which God is the real God?

2.32 If there's a possibility that there is a godlike being that is very powerful and very smart but not perfectly good, is, say, a little bit wicked, a little bit deceitful, then can I even trust mathematics? Because if there is such a being, and let's read a little bit here, "How do I know that I am not also deceived each time I add together two and three, or

the number of the sides of a square, or form some judgment still more simple? Perhaps deity has not been willing that I should thus be deceived, for he is said to be supremely good. If, however, it were repugnant to the goodness of a deity to have created me subject to constant deception, etc. , etc."

- 2.33** So the suggestion that we're raising here is, if God is not perfect in all ways, if there is such a being—this is sometimes called the evil demon hypothesis or the deceitful God hypothesis—for reasons of his own, what he likes to do is, he likes to mess with my mind. What he likes to do is watch people do mathematics and think that they are being very logical and very precise. Two, two, careful, plus, careful, three, plus, equals, careful, five. Just as I make that final move, God, this evil God, sticks in his godly fingers and messes with my mind and makes me think, aha, two plus three equals five. I feel really certain and I feel like I've been very careful, but really, he's messed me up. Or any longer chain of reasoning , at some point, he's messed me up, by giving me a little squirt of internal certainty, like I feel like I've been being careful. So possibly there is a deceitful demon. If there is the possibility of a deceitful demon, then even the truths of mathematics can't be known for absolute certainty.
- 2.34** "To these reasonings," and we're wrapping toward the end of this very first meditation, "I have assuredly nothing to reply." Can I prove that my senses aren't deceiving me? Can I prove that I'm not dreaming? Can I prove that there's no evil demon messing with my mind when I think I'm thinking clearly? No, no, and no. And to the extent that I can't prove any of those things, I can't be certain. I have to doubt everything that is in my mind. "To these reasonings, I have assuredly nothing to reply, but I'm constrained at last to avow that there is nothing of all that I formerly believed to be true, of which it is impossible to doubt." Here's further on the the malignant demon, the evil demon hypothesis. We reach the end of the first meditation.
- 2.35** What do I really know? That's my project. I want to know things for certain because I want them to be foundational for the sciences, these impressive new sciences that are coming along. Of course, whatever truth is coming from religion, received religion, I want to put them on a much better, stronger foundation, as well. What do I really know? That is my project. I'm starting with myself, working through all of the things that I believe, sorting them into reliable sources and less reliable sources, setting those aside, looking at the most reliable sources of knowledge, and all of them are doubtful. I need to be a skeptic about absolutely everything. At the end of Meditation One, we pause in a very skeptical place.
- 2.36** This is the famous method of doubt. We want to find certainty, we start with the negative . We try to eliminate as many doubtful things as possible and see what survives. If we try most vigorously to be skeptical and something can survive, that hyperbolic doubt—it's another term sometimes used for this method—then we will have a foundation. But it seems like we don't have anything that has survived. Nothing is indubitable. Maybe we don't have certainty. Maybe certainty is impossible. Maybe

we do need to be skeptical, doubtful, that that needs to be our foundational attitude in the modern world. And that's a strong pill to swallow.

2.37 All right, we come back the next day. Meditation Two. "The meditation of yesterday has filled my mind with so many doubts that it is no longer in my power to forget them, nor do I see, meanwhile, any principle on which they can be resolved." We have these doubts, and the idea is we go away and we dwell with them for a while. We come back the next day, fresh of mind, and we've not seen a way out the doubt yet . But let's not give up too fast. "I will nevertheless make an effort and try anew ." Then he gives a very interesting metaphor here, an example from history, a famous Greek physicist and mathematician, Archimedes, who said that "he might transport the entire globe from the place it occupied to another, demanded only a point that was firm and immovable. So, also, I shall be entitled to entertain the highest expectations, if I am fortunate enough to discover only one thing that is certain and indubitable."

2.38 So he's talking here about the principle of the lever, and what Archimedes discovered was the principle, if you have a, say, something of pyramidal structure, put it on the ground, and it comes to a point, and then you have a long pole with a lever. At the end of that pole , you can put a very heavy weight. And even if you're not particularly strong, you can come over and manage the lever. And the lever will enable you, from your initial position of weakness, to lift vast weights . But it requires that one point, that one fulcrum , on which all of the pressures are going to bear, and all of the resulting superstructure depends on that. Can I find just one thing that I know for absolute certainty ? And if I can, then maybe I can start to build from there the whole rest of the project.

2.39 "I suppose, accordingly, that all the things which I see are false." I'm going to set aside my sensory evidence. "I believe that none of those objects which my fallacious memory represents ever existed." My memory faculty, I'm going to set aside. Those things are all doubtful . "I suppose that I possess no senses." Maybe I'm just a mind in my dream world or my world of imagination. I'm not going to assume that I'm aware of a body. "I believe that body, figure, extension, motion, and place are merely fictions of my mind. What is there, then, that can be esteemed true?" Then we rehearse the conclusion from last time. "There's absolutely nothing certain."

2.40 Well, I can't go to God. Is there a God? Can't know for certain. What about me? "Why suppose such a being, for it may be I myself am capable of producing them? Am I, then, not at least something? Am I so dependent on the body and the senses that, without these, I cannot exist?" So could I just be a mind without a body? What is this "I" that I am talking about? External world, God's self, body, everything except, possibly, my mind. What is this thing here? And then we have this striking conclusion. "It must, in fine, be maintained , all things being maturely and carefully considered, that this proposition, 'I am, I exist,' is necessarily true each time it is expressed by me, or conceived in my mind." OK, let's unpack that one.

- 2.41 This is the famous phrase we often hear, "Cogito, ergo sum." Cogito, Latin for "I think"; ergo, Latin for "therefore"; sum, "exist," first person. "I think, therefore I am." But then notice this very strong claim: "Is necessarily true each time it is expressed by me or conceived in my mind." I can't doubt that. Why is this an exception? Maybe my senses aren't giving me the world accurately. Maybe there is no world. Maybe there is no God out there. Maybe there's just me. But this me is my mind and my body, but maybe I don't even really have a body. I can doubt that. So it's just my mind. And what's going on in my mind is all of these thinkings, and then I'm thinking about all sorts of things, and some of them might be wrong and some of them might be correct.
- 2.42 But if I'm wrong, then it's still me doing the thinking. And if I'm correct, it's still me that's doing the thinking. And so, what I'm left with is, even if I'm wrong about my senses, it's still I who am wrong about my senses. Even if I'm wrong to believe that there's a God, it's still me, the self, that is wrong to believe that there's a God. Even if I am wrong to think that I'm awake, I'm really dreaming, well, there's still the I, the me, that is doing the dreaming. Even if I'm doing math and there's this evil demon that's messing my mind up and making me do my math corrections incorrectly, there still has to be an "I" that this demon is messing with, in doing all of this mathematical thinking.
- 2.43 So, necessarily there is an I, and as long as that I is thinking, it exists. And so, there's one thing then that I know absolutely for sure is true. I exist. And I know that I exist when I'm thinking, because the opposite is impossible. I can't doubt. "I don't exist." Well, that's a thought. Well, who's having that thought? That's a self-contradictory thought. You have to exist in order to have the thought that you don't exist. And so that self-contradiction rules itself out, so necessarily, I exist.
- 2.44 Now, this is the fulcrum. Because if Descartes is correct here, then what we have is one thing that he knows, that he knows for certain, and he now has some sort of a foundation. What can I do with this foundation? Cogito ergo sum. Now, what is interesting, though, stepping back from the text just for a moment, is that notice where we are starting now. We've doubted everything. I've got one thing that I know for certain, and this is going to be the foundation for all of my knowledge. That thing is not God or the gods. That thing is not the existence of an external world that we are going to study with our senses and build empirically upon. That thing is me, the I, the self. I am starting with myself as the foundation, and that's a very modern thing to do.
- 2.45 It is going to be myself first in the order of knowledge, the prior certainty of consciousness, as it's sometimes called. I am a conscious being that has thoughts. I exist. We start from there and build out. But what is this thing, that has these thoughts? Here I have to be very careful. We're going to start with this as our foundation. What can I do next? I have to make sure that I'm not going to make any mistakes in the next step of reasoning. "A thinking thing, it has been said, but what is a thinking thing? It is a thing that doubts and understands and conceives and affirms, denies, wills, refuses, and imagines also, and perceives." So, I am a self. My self is my

mind or my thinking thing, and then I can start with a list of all of the kinds of things that my mind does, some positive, some negative, and inferences and so on.

2.46 So, I want to start from "I exist, and I have all of these ideas." I'm not going to say that those ideas are true or false, but I want to get to the next idea. I want to be able to make some argument or some an inference based on this foundation, to start to build up the edifice. But I immediately have a problem because it seems like, any time I make an inference, I exist, therefore something else, whatever that something else is. It's a possibility that that evil demon is going to be messing with my mind when I go through that inference. I might say I have this idea in my mind, and I think, logically, it leads to this next idea, but this is completely general. Whatever that move is, it might be subject to the evil demon. How can I get out of my own mind? How can I even do any single logical step, if I don't know that I can trust my mind, and that, when I am making clear to me logical steps, I can trust that I'm making those logical steps?

2.47 So what I need is, not only to know that I have a mind, but that I can trust my mind in some fundamental way, so that I can start using that trustworthy mind to make inferences to further things. So how can I validate the trustworthiness of my mind? This is hard because what I need to do is get rid of that evil demon. I have to be able to say there isn't an evil demon that is, whenever he feels like it or she feels like it, messing with my mind. How can I do that? The only way to get rid of an evil demon who has those kind of powers is to have a more powerful godlike being that is able to override the evil demon. I need to somehow get to the existence, to the point where I can say, "I exist and I know that God, the good God, the really all-powerful, all-knowing, all-good God, exists, and that he created me and gave me faculties of reason that are trustworthy, and if I use them well, then I am subject to the evil demon."

2.48 And that's the strategy that Descartes proceeds. We now establish that I exist, but can I get to the existence of a God? And that is our third Meditation, "Of God: That He Exists." Now, this is interesting because we're not, as in many traditional ways of thinking, starting with a dogmatic assumption of God, and then saying, "God then created nature." So nature comes second. And then God created me, or humans. And so, humans come third. In effect, we're going the other order. We're starting with me, and then we're going to get to God.

2.49 We're also not doing what the empiricists do, say, "Well, first, I start with nature. And on the basis of observing nature, then perhaps early in childhood, I build up an understanding of myself." So nature comes first, then myself comes second in the order of knowing. And then, as I become a mature thinker, I might argue my way to the existence of God. So nature first, me second, God third. Not that one either. Me first, then God, and then we'll see what we can do after that.

2.50 All right, now this is Descartes' famous, or infamous, proof of the existence of God. You'll notice that we cannot do when we're trying to prove the existence of God. We can't do what a lot of people like to do when they prove the existence of God is say,

"Well, look at nature ." You see that nature is very cause-and-effect, and there's orders and patterns. We build up this scientific understanding of nature as this causal, patterned, orderly thing. Then we say, "Well, what explains the causal patterned order of nature?" We say, "Well, the best hypothesis is that there's a very powerful God who created nature and the natural rules and all the causal laws," right, and so forth.

- 2.51** We can't do any of those kinds of argumentations because that would be to start from saying there's nature and that the whole scientific project of identifying the patterns in nature, I know to do that, but I don't know any of that sort of stuff yet. I can't say another kind of argument that, well, I see that this thing exists, and it came into existence after this other thing, and this other thing was the cause of this thing. And so, this thing exists after in time and also after in the causal order. And then I go to this thing and I do some history and I say it came from this other thing that caused it to exist. So I can't start this backward progression in time. Then say, well, if we go way, way back in time, way, way back in the causal order, there must be a beginning of this process . Beginning cause, a beginning temporal being, and that has to be a godlike being.
- 2.52** I can't do that kind of argument at all, because then again, that presupposes I'm looking at nature. I'm saying that there is, out there in nature, real things, and that out there in nature , there are real cause-and-effect relations, and time is a real thing, and all of those are subject to doubt. They rest on the senses, they rest on my reasoning, and all of that is subject to doubt. So how can I prove the existence of God, knowing only that I exist, and all of the rest is doubtful? Very audacious argument.
- 2.53** So, "I will now close my eyes. I will stop my ears. I will turn away my senses from their objects. I will even efface from my consciousness all the images of corporeal things." I highlight that one just again to underscore we are rejecting entirely the empiricist project in going this way. We want to do the foundations of philosophy correctly. It's not that Baconian model. Instead, he's strongly saying you have to not be empiricist at all. Close up your eyes. Stop your ears . Don't even let yourself think that there are corporeal things , real bodily things, outside of your mind. What are you left with ? Well, you're left with your own mind, and you're left with a lot of ideas and images and memories and various sorts of things floating around in your mind. So you start to look at those sorts of things.
- 2.54** "I will use circumspection, and consider with care whether I can still discover in myself anything further which I have not observed." So I'm looking inward, prior certainty of consciousness here. Lots of things are doubtful, mathematics, etc., etc. We run through the ideas, but what about this idea of God that I have in my mind? I have this idea. "Sovereign power of a God presents itself to my own mind, and I am constrained to admit that it is easy for him, if he wishes it, to cause me to err, even in matters where I think I possess the highest evidence." OK, so I have this idea then again of the evil genius, but I also have this other idea , "the idea by which I conceive of a God

sovereign, eternal, infinite, immutable, all-knowing, all-powerful, and the creator of all things that are outside of himself."

2.55 OK, so I got all of these ideas kicking around in my mind. I run through all of them . All of them are subject to doubt. Now I've got this idea of a God, a perfect God. Is there anything special about the idea of a perfect God? I don't know if it's true yet, or I don't know that it's false. But there is something special. "It is manifest by the natural light that there must be at least as much reality in the efficient and total cause as in its effect. For whence can the effect draw its reality, if not from its cause?" OK, so let's think about that. What does that mean? We have this idea of cause and effect. We want to say then, there has to be as much reality in the cause of something as in the effect. To put it negatively, you can't get something from nothing. Water flows downhill , it doesn't flow uphill, all of these metaphorical ways of doing things.

2.56 So, whatever result you end up with has to be made by something that is at least as real as it is . So you have a painting; it's made by an artist. You have a painting of a human being, but the painting of the human being is less real than the actual human being. But you actually have to have actual human beings, and an actual human being artist, to make the painting of the artist, which has less reality. So the cause has as much reality, or more, than the effect. When you're thinking this one through, come up with some of your own examples to try to make this principle. So we have this high metaphysical principle that we're bringing in.

2.57 "For whence can the effect draw its reality, if not from its cause?" OK, so whatever is in the effect has to draw its reality from the cause. All right, so high abstract language. Now , let's jump to the effect here and say, let's consider me and this idea of God. The effect in this case is that I exist, I know this, and I know that I exist as a being that has this idea of a perfect being. That's one of the things that's in my mind. So, there is this idea of a perfect being in my mind. Where did that idea come from? Now, one possibility we've been entertaining is to say, "Well, maybe I just made it up. I just imagined it." And Descartes wants to say, "That's impossible." I couldn't have just made up this idea because this idea is special. Because what kind of a being am I? Well, I'm an imperfect being. I know I'm an imperfect being because I believe lots of false things and lots of ridiculous notions and so forth, and I'm subject to all sorts of illusions, and I make mistakes all over the place. So I am an imperfect being.

2.58 But in this imperfect being is the idea of a perfect being. If we then add this idea, that you can't get perfection from imperfection, it follows that this idea of a perfect being could not have come from me. I am less. God is more. You can only get the less out of the more; the less can't create the more. I am imperfect. The imperfect cannot cause the perfect. So, as an imperfect thinking being, it's not possible for me, all by myself, to generate a perfect being or even the idea of a perfect being. Therefore, there must be a real perfect being that put this idea into me. Now, this is an argument that has

generated a lot of literature, as you might expect. Descartes fills out the arguments a little bit more. This is another repetition here.

2.59 "The whole force of the argument of which I have here availed myself to establish the existence of God, consists in this, that I perceive I could not possibly be of such a nature as I am, and yet have in my mind the idea of a God, if God did not in reality exist." I'm imperfect, therefore there would be no idea of a perfect being in me if it were just up to me alone. So, I now know two things. I exist, and there is a perfect God. This is the third Meditation. There's a grand total of six Meditations, but what we have is the important stuff, Descartes' method of doubt, the establishment of his own existence, the prior certainty of the self, prior certainty of consciousness, and then this argument for the existence of God.

2.60 These are our foundations for knowing. But now that I know I exist, and I know that there's a God exists who then made me with my faculties, God being good, would he have given me faculties that are subject to systematic delusion by demons? No. He would give me capacities and faculties that, if I learn them well, how to use them well, they will generate reliable and certain knowledge. He gave me my senses. He gave me my reasoning capacities. He gave us the logical capacities . He gave us the capacity to do mathematics. Yes, I am an imperfect being who can make mistakes in all of those things . But if I am careful using these God-given capacities, I can rely upon them . On the basis of that, I can then make an argument for the existence of my body. I know I have a body. I know that there's an external world, and I know that God, being the kind of being he is, made the world a certain way. And so using my capacities, I can go on to do the science.

2.61 Now, the point of all of this, then, this guy Descartes is modern. The candidate here is that he is one of the founders of modern philosophy. I want to highlight that in the sense that this is a controversial issue in the history of philosophy, but nonetheless, there's a case that can be made that Descartes, with his unique method, is launching philosophy in what is clearly not a premodern way. We are starting with the self, and we are starting with a preoccupied self, and we're going to build our entire edifice knowledge. I am ambitious. I think I can take on this project, and if I am careful, start not only all of my own personal knowledge and put it on a secure foundation, but all of the sciences and all of the stock of human knowledge on a secure foundation.

2.62 So, like Bacon, he is ambitious in that sense. Also, they are both modern in the sense that they are not taking an uncritical attitude, and perhaps they are taking, to put it positively, a hypercritical attitude, with respect all of the belief systems and all of the philosophies that have come down to them. All of them want to say, all of the authorities that have come down to us in the past need to be subject to a critical lens. We each as individuals need to think these things through for ourselves and build a new foundation for the sciences, for whatever stands from traditional religion and whatever we're going to do in our personal projects.

- 2.63** Now, I'll mention, Descartes published *Meditations* in 1641, and this will be our nice transition point to the next. He was very well aware of the Galileo affair, very well aware of the controversies over religion. And as you can see, he does have in his philosophical system an important place for the existence of God. But it's a God that is going to underscore the human capacity for genuine knowledge and discovering new knowledge in the world. All of the politicization of science, of philosophy, that Galileo had run afoul of and had led Descartes himself to get out of the more intellectually oppressive parts of Europe, to seek the more tolerant parts of Europe, were definitely on his mind .
- 2.64** 1641, he publishes his *Meditations*, mature work. He's at the same time doing lots of work in the sciences and building up a scientific system that he thinks is going to be a secure physics as well. Next year, Galileo dies, and he dies in Italy, and one of those interesting coincidences in intellectual history, it's the same year that Isaac Newton is born in England. Newton is going to become, of course, one of the great scientists of all time. But there's a broader point about intellectual tolerance with respect to philosophy as well. At this point, Italy, not necessarily a safe place to do philosophy science, if you are going to be a free thinker, a radical in any fundamental way, and all of the ambitious early moderns are radical and ambitious in very fundamental ways.
- 2.65** It is one of the tragedies that Italy is the home of the Renaissance and the creation of all of those magnificent universities, cathedrals of learning, in the 1300s, 1400s, and 1500s. France, also, following along a little bit later. But the activity shuts down to a significant extent in Italy. It shuts down in France. The activity generates, or moving rather than generating itself, to the farther northern and western parts of Europe. I like the symbolism here that, in 1642, Newton is born and he is an Englishman. In Lecture Three, we will be turning to an Englishman, perhaps the greatest of the early moderns, John Locke.

Lecture 3: The Promise of Individual Empiricism

At a glance — The promise of individual empiricism.

- 3.1** All right. Our title is "The Promise of Individual Empiricism." And in this lecture, I want to emphasize the "individual" word. Obviously, that's come up so far in our previous lectures on Francis Bacon and René Descartes. And Locke is, in large part, a carryover of the Baconian empiricist tradition. But he's aware of the problems that a more Cartesian rationalism poses for empiricism, and he does want to address those to some extent.
- 3.2** I want to begin in the year 1688, and this is a year that finds, actually, John Locke in having been in exile, returning to England. He's an Englishman, but for some years he's been outside of England. And this, of course, is a common theme for free-thinking individuals and intellectuals in the early modern world, running afoul of various sorts of authorities and needing to spend the time elsewhere, where it is safe to do the kind of work that they want to do. So why was John Locke returning from exile in 1688? And this is another year that is a resounding year in political, religious, and intellectual history.
- 3.3** He had been in Amsterdam, renowned for its tolerance. But by the time Locke, an Englishman, is in Amsterdam, he is surrounded with, in other parts of Holland, especially, other free intellectuals who have been attracted to that notion. And this notion of intellectual freedom, intellectual independence, is now widespread among the intellectual classes. It's not just a minority of individuals fighting against an entrenched authority and subject to heavy, heavy repression in some cases. It is now common among intellectuals to sound strongly this theme of thinking for yourself. Now, in Galileo's case, for example—now, Galileo is an Italian, and nonetheless, he is read all over Europe, and everybody is aware of the Galileo affair. But this notion of thinking for yourself.
- 3.4** "I do not feel obliged to believe that the same God who has endowed us with senses, reason, and intellect," pausing—God made us and he made us with these tools—"has intended to forgo their use and, by some other means, to give us knowledge that we can attain by them." Now, that is criticism of traditional faith, intellectual authoritarianism, dogmatism. And what Galileo is suggesting, and this is becoming a very common theme, is if you are a person of faith, if you are a dogmatic, you are in fact not a religious person. You might think you're defending religion, but you are not using the tools that God gave you, that are to be the glory of what it is to be a human being. God gave you your senses, he gave you your reason. He wants you to use them, to understand yourself, to understand this magnificent creation.
- 3.5** People who are doing religion in some other non-rational, anti-rational fashion are betraying to religion. And religion, properly conceived, should be working harmoniously with science, because God wants us to use our cognitive tools to understand his

magnificent creation. So by reading, so to speak, the book of nature, you are also reading the book of, sorry, the mind of God. Just as if you are reading the book of scripture, you are reading the mind of God. There should be a harmony here, but definitely science and its reliance on senses, reason, and logic is what we should, should be doing.

- 3.6 "He would not require us to deny sense and reason in physical matters, which are set before our eyes and minds by direct experience and necessary demonstrations." So, reiterating those themes. René Descartes, disagreeing with that emphasis on the senses, obviously, but notice, also modern. "If I write in French, which is the language of my country, rather than Latin, which is that of my teachers," and pausing just there for a moment—if you're a scholar or if you're an intellectual person, up until 1400s, 1500s, on into the 1600s, the lingua for everyone was Latin. That's what you did if you were a serious person. And now we have a break. Now I'm going to write not for scholars only; I'm going to write for thinking people, and people who can understand in their own language, as well.
- 3.7 Partly it's a democratization of knowledge. It's not that this language and ideas and philosophy is only for the elite who have gotten their education in Latin. This should be intelligible to everybody, and I'm going to write in the language of my place. "It is because I expect that those who use only their pure, natural reason," and there's that theme, their pure, natural reason, "will judge better of my opinions than those who believe only in ancient books." Don't get sucked in by your professors and the literary people who say that all truths are in books. Use your own mind, use your own reason. The assumption here is that this is quite widespread. Everybody can learn to read, and probably, if you're a Frenchman, you're going to learn to read in French first. And so you can ascend the intellectual ladders with your own language.
- 3.8 John Milton. We've gone from an Italian, Galileo, a Frenchman, René Descartes, to John Milton. And here we're going to emphasize the political elements of this. Milton reacting against—Milton, of course, the great poet, author of *Paradise Lost*, but reacting against censorship regimes. And it's not only that we need to use our senses and our reason, and that we can democratize this to some extent, that everybody should be able to do this for themselves, but the political regime of intellectual authoritarianism also needs to give way.
- 3.9 "If men within themselves would be governed by reason, and not generally give up their understanding to a double tyranny," and that's a politicized concept, right, "of custom from without, and blind affections within, they would discern better what it is to favor and uphold the tyrant of a nation." So, there's all these customs, traditions that have come down, and all those are captured by various forms of institutional authorities, both in religion and in politics. If we have thinking citizens, people who can think for themselves and will govern themselves by their own reason, they will be better able to resist that kind of tyranny. But then also sounding that Baconian theme

—inside each of us as individuals are obstacles that we have to overcome ourselves. We need to wrestle with tyrants within us, our emotions and passions that want to dominate us, so that we can free our reason to find the true course in our lives. That's what it is to be a free human being.

- 3.10** Now, Locke is in Amsterdam. Calm, cool, but ferment of activity, politically, religiously, intellectually, scientifically, attracting so many people from all over Europe precisely because of its relatively liberal, tolerant time. Now, why was he not doing this, though, back in England? And as usual, we might expect, the story is bad politics and bad religion. And Locke ran afoul of both of them. So I want to do a little five minutes of British history to set the context for Locke's achievement. So, he is learning from Galileo, he's learning from Descartes, he's learning from Bacon, and so all of that intellectual stuff is going on. But Locke is also a man of the world. He wants to make, in that Baconian fashion, the world a better place. And that requires understanding what has actually gone on in the world, knowing your history, and then being able to learn, so to speak, the lessons of history.
- 3.11** Now, of course, one of the great stories of all time is the story of Henry VIII and his six wives, as it turns out to be. Great soap opera, so to speak. But it's also a story that has hugely important lessons for religion and politics, and every intellectual, particularly in England, needs to know this. Now, we know that he went through many wives, and serious politics was on the line. It wasn't just that he's the king, and the king can have whatever he wants, and he's a man, and we know what men want. So, yes, he did want all of those things, and yes, he was the king, but serious politics was at issue. England had gone through a period of civil wars, which were enormously destructive of the economic and the cultural fabric of England. And Henry's judgment was that, to make sure that when he died, the succession is going to be peaceful and secure, he needs an heir, and it needs to be a male heir. Right. So he's in large part a man of his time.
- 3.12** You know, there had been, of course, female monarchs in past, in English history, but at that time, it was not clear that England would accept a female monarch. So he's desperate for a male heir, and he's not getting that with his first wife, Catherine — stillborn, short-surviving children, and she is starting to get a little bit older. So, what is he going to do? Well, he needs to divorce her and go on to the next wife and try with her. That's the politics, serious politics. I need to get a male heir. But problem is that his wife is Catholic. She is a daughter of Spain. And the king of Spain is controlling the Pope in Rome at that time. And so, the king of Spain is able to put pressure on the head of religion at that time.
- 3.13** And at this time, Henry is a very good Catholic, thinks of himself as a good Catholic, defender of the faith. He was named by the Pope. The Pope says no, but the pope says no because the king of Spain says no. And the king of Spain says no because you're married to my niece, I think it is. So English politics is at the mercy of religion in Rome and politics in Spain. This is an intolerable situation. So, Henry then splits the church off

from Rome. It becomes an English national church. He's then able to get the divorce that he needs in order to proceed, and so forth. So what we then have is the, suppose we can call it, an unholy mix of religion and politics going on in England at the time. And then, of course, his personal soap opera continues on.

3.14 Now, I want to emphasize, though, that this was not whimsical only on Henry VIII's part. There was, of course, some, you know, personal. He loved women and all of that sort of stuff. But this was serious business, and he did not break lightly. Prior to this, he had, when he was still thinking of himself as a good Catholic, spent a lot of time having his men pursue this gentleman, William Tyndale, who was a dissenter, a Protestant, a reformer of a very radical point, who had had the temerity to take the Bible and translate it into English. And the argument there was that, rather than ideas and knowledge and religious truth only belonging to priests and the educated elite, every individual needs to be able to read scripture for himself or herself, so they can manage their own souls. So Tyndale published one of the early translations of the Bible into English.

3.15 And this was an affront to Catholic thinking at the time. Henry's a good Catholic. Tyndale was in exile on the continent. They hunted him for years, all the king's men and all the king's horses going after him. They finally found him, and he was executed very publicly to make a point under Henry VIII's regime. Serious religion, serious politics. Now, things get better after Henry dies, and we would say there's a glory era for England. England does accept a female monarch, Elizabeth I, and she's one of the most successful, long-lived monarchs. And retrospectively, we look back and we say, well, the Spanish were the great power. Now England, with the defeat of the Spanish armada, it survives. It has a sense of itself as a growing power, politically and commercially. This is also the same generation in which Shakespeare, and, of course, Shakespeare is the, you know, the mountain peak, but there are dozens of other enormously proficient playwrights and a flourishing theater scene and literary scene going on in England. These are the glory days.

3.16 Then we get into the 1600s. A later monarch, Charles I. Now John Locke, is born. He was born in 1632. We're marching into the 1600s, and Charles is obviously a monarch, and there's religion involved here as well. But England is once again plunged into civil war, and the war is partly over religious issues. Cromwell is a reformer, a Protestant, and a fairly fundamental one. Of course, there's all of the political issues. So you have the monarchical forces going up against the forces of parliament. Are we going to be a centralized monarch, or are we going to be a more decentralized, parliamentary, democratic regime? And are we going to have the established now Church of England, with its somewhat repression of some of the alternative versions of religion extant in England at the time—Catholics, Jews, Muslims, and some freethinkers as well? Or are we going to have a true Protestant, fundamentalist kind of religion, as we would now call it, ruling? And so there's this huge collision.

- 3.17** The monarchical forces lose. And not only that, we don't send the king into exile, we kill him. We cut the head of the king off. This is an extraordinary action for the English. We know the English, and the British, more broadly, love their monarchy, right on up to our day. The symbolism of defeating the monarchical forces on the battlefield and then executing, in a public way, the monarchy. So we are now going back and forth between more parliamentary, more monarchical forces. And so, parliament has won, and we say it's democratic. But this was not at all a liberal, democratic regime. It was authoritarian in its own force. And so what we find in the 1640s, whereas I'll read this quotation.
- 3.18** "The distracted state of England, threatened with a cloud of blood by civil war, calls for all possible means to appease and avert the wrath of God." So this is parliament, Cromwell's parliament, speaking in the 1640s. Religion and politics mixed, and we need to enact true religion here. "It is therefore thought fit, and ordained, by the Lords and Commons in this Parliament assembled, that while these sad causes and set times of humiliation continue, public stage plays shall cease and be forborn." Censorship. We're going to shut down the theaters. Now, this is striking because this is the nation that gave us Shakespeare two generations earlier, now shutting down all theaters. No more Shakespeare.
- 3.19** Now, this is Locke's youth. He is born into this time of political ferment, this time of religious ferment, and part of his concerns are practical, worldly concerns. How can we put religion on hopefully peaceful, tolerant, solid foundation? How can we do politics in a more rational, reasonable way in the modern world, get past all of these religious wars, political wars, that have torn us apart? And at the same time, he is getting a first-rate education. He originally actually trained as a medical doctor before he was able to turn to philosophy. But how can I take all of the intellectual developments of this early modern world and put them on a more secure foundation than either Descartes or Francis Bacon have done?
- 3.20** Now, the story continues on afterwards. There's a restoration of the monarchy. We now get Charles II. And as you can see, a lot of pomp and a lot of ceremony, and there's a lot of political intrigue and religious problems that are going on. Locke is, at this point, involved with a mover and shaker named the Earl of Shaftesbury, who's involved in some of the political machinations. And he gets on the wrong side of Charles II, and so he decides he's going to go into exile. And at this point, John Locke is associated with Shaftesbury as part of his personal revenue. He's the family medical doctor, but he also decides, "I don't want to run afoul of these political machinations." And so, he goes into exile as well.
- 3.21** There's the great fire of London, in 1666, worth mentioning. Was this just the problem of the new modern world? Congestion, insufficient sanitation, building materials? Do we understand this in secular, naturalistic, physicalistic, and apply scientific causes? Or is this a sign from God that London is sinful, and we need a great purge of London? That is the debate of the 1660s. Now, meanwhile, Locke is in Amsterdam, and this is a lovely,

peaceful image of [inaudible]. And he has leisure to do what he really loves to do for several years, which is to write philosophy in a tolerant, peaceful Amsterdam context.

3.22 Now, back in England, though, in 1688. Finally, there are some major changes. Right there is what we now call the Glorious Revolution. Part of what was glorious about it is that there was almost no bloodshed, major political revolution in the modern world, and almost nobody died. What happened was, the old king died, a new king came along, James. But parliament didn't like this guy for partly political reasons, partly religious reasons. And what they basically said was, "We don't want you to be our king. Would you please go away?" And basically, that's what happened. The king went away, he went into exile, and now parliament is ascendant, and there is something glorious about that. And we now think of that as something very English about that, compared to many other revolutions that had gone on in the world. And very quickly, it's not only that parliament is ascendant, and we have had a relatively peaceful transition of power. They passed, on the religious front, an Act of Toleration. This is in 1689—breathtaking in the scope of toleration that it extends to religious minorities in England at the time.

3.23 Now, in part learning from the good lesson of the Dutch across the Channel, but also the English want themselves to solve problems, and they want to, as we now start to think of it, start to separate church and state, or at least relax the control that religion has over politics and the control that politics has over religion. Now, John Locke is in the midst of all of this. The new king, William and Mary, they've been invited by parliament to become the monarch. And Locke knew them, and he came back on the ship that brought the future queen, Queen Mary, to become the, to become the queen. So he's connected. He's been working on his philosophy. He's in a position, in effect, to become the major philosopher of England at the time.

3.24 Now, we should also mention good times, not only in politics, not only in religion, but this gentleman, Isaac Newton, has just published his *Principia Mathematica*, 1687. 1687, this is published. 1688, the Glorious Revolution. 1689, the Acts of Toleration. Now, only a handful of people in the whole world have math that's good enough to be able to understand exactly what Newton is doing, but already the excitement is there. And what we now think of as, you know, the greatest scientist of the modern world, is also operative in England. So Locke returns in 1688 and proceeds then to publish the works that he has been working on.

3.25 Now, the most philosophical and the most foundational of his work is this "Essay Concerning Human Understanding." Came out in 1690. It's a great big fat book, primarily focused on epistemological issues about knowledge. As we've seen, those have been occupying us with Bacon and with Descartes. What do we really know? "Episteme," the Greek word for knowledge, and then the "-ology" or "logos" to give an account of. So we're trying to give an account of knowledge, and that's the foundational thing that Locke is especially concerned with. But he also is writing on

metaphysical issues and then moral issues as well. So it's a fairly comprehensive work in philosophy.

- 3.26** And this is a work that is read not only by the intellectual elite. One of the striking things is that this book went through 20 printings, 20 editions, over the course of the next ten years or so. So it's, like, not a bestseller, it's like a grand bestseller, blowing, so to speak, the charts off for philosophy publications. And it exerted then a deep hold over the British mind and then, by extension, places that Britain was then to influence over the course of the next centuries as it grew into a world power. But the flavor of this work—I want to give a few quotations to indicate what's going on here. Now, some of these are themes that are now familiar to us as early moderns, but still radical to many people growing up in more traditional households and regimes.
- 3.27** "Men must think and know for themselves. Not that I want due respect for other men's opinions, but after all, the greatest reverence is due to truth. We should make greater progress in the discovery of rational and contemplative knowledge if we sought in the fountain, in the consideration of things themselves." So this is very Baconian, right, in the thinking for the things himself. But thinking for yourself is also Cartesian, as well as Baconian. And this emphasis on, "What do I really know?" And de-emphasizing any sort of an appeal to authority. People need to work everything out for themselves.
- 3.28** "For I think we may as rationally hope to see with other men's eyes, as to know by other men's understandings." Use your own eyes; you can't rely on other people's eyes. Use your own mind; you can't rely on other people's minds. "The floating of other" — this is a little bit of sarcasm you have to put in your voice when you read this part here — "the floating of other men's opinions in our brains makes us not one jot the more knowing." You've heard something from somebody else. Even if it's true, that doesn't make you knowing. You're just parroting other people's ideas, though they happen to be [inaudible]. "Aristotle was certainly a knowing man." But what made Aristotle so knowing? "But nobody ever thought him so because he blindly embraced and confidently vented the opinions of another. In the sciences, everyone has so much as he really knows and comprehends. What he believes only, and takes on trust, are but shreds."
- 3.29** OK, very strongly Cartesian on that confidence element, and with respect to the empirical basis, very Baconian. Now, this issue that had been exercising Descartes and many of the other early moderns, I just want to touch on one of the metaphysical issues. It's not the new science, and our understanding of human nature is threatening to traditional religion, because traditional religion teaches us that we have a body and we have a soul, and that they are two different kinds of stuff. One is material, one is immaterial, one is spiritual, one is materialistic. And so, we have to have this dualistic understanding of human beings. But all along, these new scientists are coming along and saying the human being is just this physical, automata, engine-type of body, and doesn't that threaten traditional religion?

- 3.30** And Locke wants to say, "Well, let's not be so fast," because many of the debates had hardened into that strong materialism versus strong dualism position. What do I really know when I look into this matter as a thoughtful guy? "Whether matter may not be made by God to think is more than man can know." I don't know. I'm not going to speculate and make up an answer and just be a dogmatic on this metaphysical issue. "For I see no contradiction in it, that the first eternal thinking being or omnipotent spirit should, if he pleased, give to certain systems of created senseless matter, put together as he thinks fit, some degrees of sense, perception, and thought."
- 3.31** So if God really is all-powerful and all-knowing, why can't he make material systems that are able to sense and think? That's a possibility. I don't know. And as an empiricist, I'm not going to speculate on this. And we're not going to get worried too much about the moral and the political implications for true religion and so forth, based on our fears, based on abstract theological speculations. We don't know. Let's leave it for investigation.
- 3.32** And I want to make a sideways connection here to Isaac Newton, because of course we know him as a great scientist, but he also was a philosopher imbued with this new modern thinking, and just on this point of not speculating beyond what we actually know. And this is toward the end of Principia Mathematica, when he's saying, I'm doing these investigations into mechanics and gravity and so forth. And then when I get to a certain point, and we ought to ask this kind of metaphysical or fundamental physical question, what is this thing that is gravity, now described mathematically, all of the forces and some of the implications for that? And Newton is quite happy to say, "I don't know."
- 3.33** And for an intellectual to say, "I don't know," and to say that confidently, with no problem, and as a methodological point of pride, is a sign of the modern. "But hitherto, I have not been able to discover the cause of those properties of gravity from phenomena. And I frame no hypothesis, for whatever is not deduced from the phenomena is to be called a hypothesis. And hypotheses, whether metaphysical or physical, whether occult qualities or mechanical, have no place in experimental philosophy." What do I see? What can I tabulate in my category, categorical schemes, my concordances, and so forth? What, when I do my experiments, can I derive? What can I logically prove? When I reach the limit of that, I don't go beyond to these occult or metaphysical or abstract speculations. And that is Newton absorbing this Baconian method, as well as he is integrating, of course, the mathematical methods that Descartes and the others were working on.
- 3.34** Now, into all of this mix, then, comes John Locke. And I want to spend a little more time, though, focusing on this shorter work called A Letter Concerning Toleration. Three takes me over. Very good. Published in 1689, shortly after he arrives back from exile. And this issue about whether toleration is properly foundational for church and state, and to think about how important this is, given the political uses that politicians

have made of religion over the centuries, an extraordinarily powerful tool to shape, control, or if we want to get even more conspiratorial, manipulate people to do what the politicians want. And the same thing with respect to the religion side of things. I have my true religion, and it's important that everybody believe my true religion. And if I have the capacity to do so, I will use the powers that be, all of the political forces, to banish the wrong religions and enforce my political regime.

- 3.35** And this notion of toleration, that religions are going to tolerate each other, and the political powers that be are going to tolerate a diversity of religions in their midst, is a new idea. It had been realized politically at the level of partly saying, as a matter of practical expediency, "Look, we've been hating each other and tormenting each other and, in some cases, killing each other for centuries now over religious differences, just as a matter of practical getting along with life. Let's stop with that and put in place some toleration so that we can just get on with life." But the intellectual development of the arguments, the political theory and the religious theory and the philosophical underpinnings for both of them that are going to support a principled advocacy of toleration, that's what John Locke is trying to support here.
- 3.36** So I want to give you some of the highlights in Locke's own words on this. It's a fascinating work. It's not very long. It also generated a certain amount of controversy in some of the letters in response. Locke took them up and responded and refined his view. So there's a whole cottage industry that's well worth exploring if this issue is one of interest to you. But toward the beginning, and he puts it in the form of a letter, I'm just addressing another regular person here. "I esteem that toleration to be the chief characteristic mark of the true church." And this is striking, if we think of the true church, whatever the true church means to us. It doesn't seem that toleration has been very high on their list of priorities down the century. So he knows he has adversaries. He also knows that, in many cases, it's high people in the church hierarchy, high people in the political hierarchy, although that's not where we're focusing right now, will be opposed to this notion.
- 3.37** So what do I say against people like St. Augustine and others down, down the centuries? "What does it mean, though, to be a Christian?" Well, you can say that you are committed to all sorts of things, but in your practice, "if he be destitute of charity, meekness, and goodwill in general towards all mankind, even to those who are not Christians, he certainly is yet short of being a true Christian himself." So then he says, first, before you are so concerned with other people and their deviances from what you take to be true Christianity, look after yourself. The very modern point—you start with yourself. Your care of your soul and your own well-being is extraordinarily important.
- 3.38** "Whoever will list himself under the banner of Christ must, in the first place, above all things, make war upon his own lusts and vices." So get your own house in order, then consider your neighbor and further afield. But he's going to argue that Christianity, properly understood, should bring with it a tolerating attitude. "Conscience." Big word

in [inaudible]. "I appeal to the consciences of those that persecute, torment, destroy, and kill other men." What's going on there? Now, Locke then says, "It's a pretense of religion." It's not genuine religion. "Whether they do it out of friendship and kindness toward them or no." Because one of the famous doctrines that does come down, I mentioned St. Augustine, notices that you should not tolerate deviancies with respect to Christianity and the true faith. You should, if you love your neighbor as Christ has enjoined us, be concerned about your neighbor, not just whether he's well fed or not, but the state of your neighbor's soul.

- 3.39** And we know that life on earth is short and that the soul is immortal and is going on to the next world, and that we will be judged by almighty God. So if you really care for your neighbor, you will make sure that your neighbor has a good soul, so that when he or she dies, he will be on the right side of God. And so from that perspective, if you are tolerating people who are deviants, who are not believing the correct thing, what you're saying is you don't care about your neighbor, you don't love your neighbor, and you're perfectly fine with your neighbor dying on the wrong side of God and thereby going to some terrible destiny.
- 3.40** Even to the point of torture, that you will torture people if you have particularly recalcitrant individuals who nonetheless you think might die in the, in the near future, and the only way you can get them to listen and to focus and pay attention to this very important issue is to torture them. Benevolence requires that you torture individuals. And this doctrine of benevolent torture had been the most influential doctrine down through the century. So it wasn't just sadism. "I hate you because your religion is different from me." This was authorized doctrine down the centuries, from major theologians in the tradition.
- 3.41** So that's what Locke is talking about here. "If it be out of a principle of charity, as they pretend, and love to men's souls." So this doctrine of benevolent torture. No. OK. "Why then does this burning zeal for God, for the church and the salvation of souls, burning I say, literally, with fire and faggot." Where is all of this coming from? And this is what I need to argue. So, by way of preamble then, "I esteem it above all things necessary to distinguish exactly the business of civil government from that of religion and to settle the just bounds that lie between the one and the other." So what we've had is religious people, with their typical religious enthusiasms, an adversarial relationship with their neighbors. And of course, the neighbors are returning the favor. Whenever any of them is in a position to do so, they will happily use the state, the government, on behalf of their religion, against their neighbors whom they want to dispose of.
- 3.42** And at the same time, we have political leaders, and some of them, of course, are filled with religious enthusiasm themselves. Happily then, obviously, often in a revenge cycle, going after people who are on the wrong side of religion from their perspective, now that they are in power. Sometimes the political people are not particularly religious, or religious issues are not that high on their list of priorities, but nonetheless, political

control of religion is still a useful tool of them. So, all of that needs to be rethought. What is the proper business of government? And what is the proper business of religion? So, let's start with the Commonwealth, and notice that this is the Commonwealth. This is not just the wealth of the king or the wealth of the aristocrats. This is the wealth of the society that we commonly are participating in and creating.

- 3.43** What is the purpose of government? And this is a very modern approach to government, where he wants to say, government is "a society of men, constituted only" — that's always a strong word — "only for the procuring, preserving, and advancing their own civil interests." We come together as individual. We have our own interests and we form societies because we want to advance our interests, sometimes cooperatively, sometimes going our own way. But we form society for that basis. It's not the glory of God, and that we're not serfs under various sorts of aristocrats and so forth, and that we exist for their interests. Rather, we are citizens who have our own civil interests and we form societies for the advancement of our interests. So there's an entire political theory.
- 3.44** What do I mean by civil interests? Well, "life, liberty, indolency, or health and indolency of body, the possession of outward things, such as money, land, houses, furniture, and the like." We start to introduce the language of rights. It's not that we have privileges from the monarch. Instead, as human beings, we have rights to our own life, to our own property, to our own liberties and so forth. That's why we do government. "It is the duty of the civil magistrate." This is not a king or an aristocrat or a lord. He is a magistrate, as some major power in the society. And we have delegated power, "by the impartial execution of equal laws." All of this is now also very modern—the person who is in the magistrate position. There are laws that should be equal. We don't have one set of laws for the royal family and another set of laws for the clergy and another set of laws for the peasantry and so forth. Equal laws that extend to all human beings. And the magistrate is to be impartial.
- 3.45** It does not take sides on any of the issues that divide sometimes human beings from each other. "To secure unto all the people in general and to every one of his subjects in particular, the just possession of these things belonging to this life." And notice that emphasis at the end on "this life." There's no mention here that the job of the civil magistrate is to look after your soul in preparation for the next life. This is a secular, worldly institution based on individuals who have their own interests. We can elevate that to rights, coming together socially to form a government, to delegate some powers to the government. And those who have the political power in the government, are impartially to respect those rights.
- 3.46** Now, that's to take all of Locke's what we now know of his two treatises of government, and boil it down to a couple of paragraphs. And that's a work well worth reading in your political theory classes. But that's a strong claim. And Locke says, "The whole jurisdiction of the magistrate reaches only to these civil concerns, and that

all civil power, right, and dominion is bounded and confined only to the care of promoting these things." That's it. "And that it neither can nor ought in any manner to be extended to the salvation of souls." Now, I need to make an argument for that. So we understand, sure, my life is mine, your life is yours. I shouldn't kill you. You shouldn't kill me. So if anybody wants to be a killer, yeah, we understand that the magistrate's job is to protect people's right to life and stop that sort of thing. Stop people from stealing from each other, enslaving each other, right and so forth.

3.47 But those are all bodily things. What about the soul? Why is that not also part of the proper function of the state? He's looking after our body in some sense. Why is he not also to look after our souls? And then Locke proceeds to make an argument. These are philosophical arguments why that is not only wrong, but in many cases, impossible. "First, because the care of souls is not committed to the civil magistrate, any more than to other men." We're now thinking more democratically, more in terms of a parliamentary system. Where do the powers of politics come from? Well, in that system we give powers to the politicians. Did we give the power over our souls to the politician in the last election? To put it bluntly, was that on the agenda or referendum? "I hereby vote for the civil magistrate to take control over my soul." No, right? It wasn't committed to the civil magistrate. I let him appoint the sheriff, I gave them powers to appoint judges and so forth. But this is not a power that I give to the civil magistrate. My soul is mine and control over my soul belongs to me.

3.48 Why? "Because it appears not that God has ever given any such authority to one man over another." So not only did I not give control over my soul to another person, there's nothing that says God gave this person control over everybody else's soul. "Nor can any such power be vested in the magistrate by the consent of the people, because no man so far can abandon the care of his own salvation as blindly to leave the choice of any other." This is a very interesting point about self-responsibility on this matter. So, suppose we said, "OK, well, I don't know, let's put it on the referendum." The referendum is going to be, this person is up for election as the magistrate and let's make him in charge of everybody's soul in the town.

3.49 Can we do that? Well, of course we could go through the process, and we could vote for. But Locke is making a point, saying you actually cannot do that. You cannot delegate control over your soul to another person. You can formally say, "Look after my religious life for me." That is empty words and has no effect whatsoever over the status of your soul. And why is that the case? Because what is religion? What does it really mean to have religious belief? And this is Locke's next point. "All the life and power of true religion consist in the inward and full persuasion of the mind, and faith is not faith without believing." Only you control your mind, only you control your soul. You cannot metaphysically transfer that power to someone else. No one can make you believe; no one can make you understand. Only you can do that for yourself.

- 3.50** It's a metaphysical impossibility. Souls are individual. Control over the souls are individual. That cannot, as a matter of metaphysical principle, be something the civil magistrate does. So, if we try to even imagine it, what am I supposed to believe about the Trinity? The civil magistrate says, "Well, you believe this interpretation of the Trinity." I say, "OK, I believe that interpretation of the Trinity." He said, "Well, do you understand that?" "No, no, I don't understand it, but he's in control and so, therefore, my religion is what he has said." Am I really religious? Do I really have a position on the —no, I don't. That's right. It's impossible. That's Locke's point here.
- 3.51** "In the second place, the care of souls cannot belong to the civil magistrate because his power consists only in outward force." Now what does that mean? That is to say, of course, he has outward force. He has the police, he has the sheriff, right, and so forth. They, outside the view, can issue threats, financial threats. They can threaten to beat you with sticks and put you in prison and maybe even kill you. All of that is outward force. What does that have to do with religion? "True and saving religion consists in the inward persuasion of the mind. And such is the nature of the understanding, that it cannot be compelled to the belief of anything by outward force." Very strong claim.
- 3.52** I won't use a contemporary example, but I just take a big stick and I threaten to hit you with that stick unless you believe what I want you to believe. Can I make you believe what I want you to believe by threatening you with the stick? No. I can, of course, probably get you to say the words, as long as I am holding the stick. But it has absolutely no control over your mind. It's not going to change your mind at all. And all the civil magistrate has is outward force. Religion is an inward thing under the control of the individual. "Penalties such that the civil magistrate can enact are in no way capable to produce such belief. It is only light and evidence that can change, that can work a change in men's opinions." The light of reason, the providing of evidence. I can give you evidence, but you have to do the work. It has to be the light of your own reason that changes your mind. Force is completely irrelevant to this.
- 3.53** So if we are really interested in changing people's minds, we don't want them just mouthing whatever we want, the politicians tell them to mouth. We want them really to believe. And the only way you can get people really to believe is, since they have their own reason, is providing them with evidence that is convincing to reason and letting them do that work themselves. "In the third place, the care and salvation of men's souls cannot belong to the magistrate because, though the rigor of the laws and the force of penalties were capable to change men's minds"—OK, let's pause on that. That's the hypothesis. Suppose it was possible to change people's minds by the use of force. We use strong brainwashing techniques. And I get you to the point where you are so fearful or so broken down that you actually change your mind. And it's not that you're just saying what I want you to say. You really feel in yourself, "OK, I believe that. I believe that. I believe that." Suppose that could happen.

- 3.54** Locke then says that's not going to make a slight amount of difference to the person's salvation. "Yet would not that help at all to the salvation of their souls." Jumping down a little bit. "The necessity to quit the light of their own reason, and oppose the dictates of their own consciences, and blindly to resign themselves up to the will of their governors," that's just going to turn it into a regime of chance. If that's the regime, whoever the political power that be, suppose he has this extraordinarily strong brainwashing power and he can make people say and believe whatever he wants them to believe, then we know there's this great diversity of civil magistrates, local powers all over the world. It is just going to be a matter of accident. What regime did you happen to be born into, such that you were forced to believe whatever that particular king or monarch happened to put? Is that really going to save anybody's soul?
- 3.55** I suppose it's true that you then show up at the pearly gates, metaphorically speaking, and God is judging you and deciding whether you are going to be acceptable or not. If it turns out that the only reason you believe whatever you believe, even if it's a true account of God, was because you were forced to believe that by your civil magistrate, you are not saved, because you did not, by your own reason, come to that correct judgment. You were forced. Force is completely irrelevant to matters of religion and should be abolished. He goes on and points out, if you look at how many different political regimes there are out there, how many different religious regimes that are out there—if we have, as a matter of principle, that the civil magistrates can just use force to make their citizens or subjects believe whatever they want, that means we're not really interested in religion. We're just interested in something else. We're interested in compliance. The only way to get people to save their souls is the inward light of their own reason.
- 3.56** Now that then is to say, on the side of government, Locke is arguing, leave religion alone as a matter of firm principle. Your job is to protect people's life, liberty, property, and so forth. Settle their disputes over those matters. Religion, hands off. Now we go to the other side of the divide. Now let us consider what a church is. "A church, then I take to be a voluntary society of men, joining themselves together of their own accord in order to the public worshipping of God in such a manner as they judge acceptable." All right, so what is a church? And notice the words that are emphasized here. Voluntary. Of their own accord. You become a member of a church by choice, of your own accord, something that you make a decision to commit to.
- 3.57** And Locke is going to insist on this point in a fundamental way, because they want to say, well, what? No, you're born into a religion. You're born into a community. You're born into a family. The family has its preexisting religious beliefs, and you are raised in that religion. You don't choose. Locke says, no, that's actually not correct. "Nobody is born a member of any church. Otherwise the religion of parents would descend unto children." And here again, he's insisting on this self-choice point. If the reason why you say you are a member of this church or you believe in this religion, if your only reason

is, "Oh, well, that's what my parents told me, or my parents take me to this church, and that's why I am a member of this church," that's not religion.

3.58 It's not religion until you, by the light of your own reason, have said, "I know what this church stands for. I know what forms of worship are involved here. I think those are the right ones, and I choose to go there." So it requires that free and voluntary consent. So the fact that someone is born into a religion is also then going to imply that it's inappropriate for the authorities within that religion to say, in any way, shape, or form, "Sir, you are ours. You were born into our church, and we own you, or we belong to you religiously," so to speak. That's an inappropriate, that the church's proper attitude should be, the people who are our members are people who have joined with us by their light of their own reason, and voluntarily.

3.59 And then he wants to say, well, look, this also implies that we should have free entry and as well, free exit, because often we make mistakes. Religious matters are very complicated. And maybe for a certain number of years I thought this was the right approach to religion. So I did freely and voluntarily join with this church. But now I've been thinking more about various things, and I think I made a mistake. I am still a free agent, still responsible for my soul and to follow the light of my reason. The morally responsible thing for me to do, then, is to withdraw from that church and go to a different church. Freedom of entry, freedom of exit, are both going to be important, and churches need to tolerate that if they are interested in genuine religion.

3.60 Now, what about the authority relations within? Because many religions will want to say, you know, we can't just let anybody make their own decisions about what their religion is going to be. There's got to be a place for religious authority. These matters are hard. Some people are lazy. And so what we need is to have religious authorities who guide people, and guidance comes in various degrees of strength. So, we don't want people to get lost in high theological matters or, if they're a little bit lazy to just, you know, wander away from the church. So maybe a church should be a little more authoritarian, in the benevolent sense, and a little bit more forceful in the benevolent sense, to get people on the right kind of page.

3.61 And here, we know Locke is especially going after the Catholics when we start talking about bishops and presbyters. Actually, the Presbyterians are the Calvinists up in Scotland. "With ruling authority derived from the very apostles, and continued down to present times by an uninterrupted succession." So the idea here that there's Jesus, and Jesus is God, and Jesus anointed a successor, and that therefore that successor has Jesus' authority and is the head of the church. So, if you question that authority, it's like you're questioning Jesus himself, and questioning God himself, and that's wrong. And that that has happened in unbroken succession right down to the 1600s. And so, you're not in a position to think for yourself on religious matters. You need to follow the authority. Locke is saying, absolutely not. Of course, that is a religion, but it's not true

religion, from Locke's perspective. We need to get away from it. Individual self-responsibility on religious matters.

- 3.62** Now, if you take even that road, though, if you look at the history of the religions that have tried to say, "We have a hierarchical structure," even among those people, very well educated, in many cases, very well committed, their beliefs on theological matters are all over the map. They disagree with each other all over the case, or even within any generation, across various generations. So even the most centralized, hierarchical, authority-based religions you can imagine, we have now long history of that in Europe. They cannot, so to speak, keep their act together. And so what that shows each of us is we can't just trust the authority of someone else's mind. They don't have it locked down for sure. I need to work it out for myself.
- 3.63** Now, he then turns, as one should do, if you're going to appeal to Christians, look at the text. "That the church of Christ should persecute others, and force others by fire and sword to embrace her faith and doctrine, I could never yet find in any of the books of the New Testament." Now, New Testament. OK, so there's a little Biblical argument here. And of course, we know people on both sides of this debate will have their preferred passages, but the invitation is, "Read the Bible for yourself and come up with your own best interpretation of the important, the important sections here as well."
- 3.64** OK, now the conclusion then is on religious matters. If we're really interested, as religious people, in other peoples being genuinely religious people, force is irrelevant, and threats of force and intimidation are irrelevant to true religion. "No force is here to be made use of upon any occasion whatsoever. Force belongs wholly to the civil magistrate." On the political side of things, the protection of rights to life, liberty, property, people who are physically threatening other people, to kill them, to steal them, to enslave them, and so forth, force can be used to prevent that, so that people can go about their civil business in their own way. When we're talking about inward matters of the soul, inward matters of religion, force is completely irrelevant. We are free agents. We are fully in control of what we believe, how we practice. And so force is completely irrelevant there.
- 3.65** Now, this is a very strong argument for toleration. It's also a very strong argument for separating church and state. Religion is about freedom; the state is about force. Those are two very different things. You shouldn't mix them from either direction. If, from the religion side, you start to use force, well, you're giving up on the freedom that is essential to true religious attitude. If, from the political side you start to use force on people's religion, or you are using a weapon or a tool, force, that is completely irrelevant to what's true. Separation of religion and politics. And this is the beginnings, in the modern world, of separation of church and state as a matter of philosophical principle.
- 3.66** Now, how far, though, do we need to go in this toleration business? Because then we start to think of all of the extreme cases and the weird cases. What if people were

doing this, that, and the other things? What about if someone shows up in your church and says, you know, well, you have your 10 articles of belief to be a member of that church, and the person just starts arguing with everybody all of the time? And this is now a time for prayer, where the person still wants to argue and says they don't believe this, that, and the other thing. What can you do with that person? Locke says you don't have to tolerate him in the sense of letting that person be a member of your church. You can kick him out. You can excommunicate people from your religion. That's part of your freedom. It's a voluntary, free association of people who want to believe and worship in a certain way.

- 3.67** If you have someone who clearly doesn't want to do that, part of our freedom is we can, so to speak, exit from that person. Whatever you want to do, fine, but don't involve us. Right? So, excommunication is legitimate. We don't have to tolerate people in that sense. So, here we have the doctrine of excommunication. "Secondly, no private person has any right in any manner to prejudice another person in his civil enjoyments because he is of another church or religion." So, what about my neighbor who belongs to a different church, and they do things really weird over there and they just believe all of the wrong stuff? Do I have to tolerate that? Yes. Yes, you do. Absolutely. These are not, as he puts it here, "the business of religion." He is not violating your rights in any way. So you are not allowed to use force in any way with respect to that person. Tolerate that. Put up with it as part of what it is.
- 3.68** Further, as a Christian—this is a narrower argument—Christianity is supposed to be about forgiveness and charity and a measure of benevolence with respect to your neighbor who believes all of the wrong things and practices the wrong things. The only way you have a chance ever of convincing him otherwise is if you have good relations that keep the lines of communication open. That's going to require some tolerance. If you start to use any sort of threats or force, that's going to shut that down and make it impossible. Now this is the strong claim about separation of church and state. "The church itself is a thing absolutely separate and distinct from the Commonwealth." That's the blue part there. Politics and the church. The state and religion.
- 3.69** "The boundaries on both sides are fixed and immovable. He jumbles heaven and earth together, these things most remote and opposite, who mixes these two societies, which are in their original end, business, and in everything perfectly distinct and infinitely different from each other." Separation of church and state is not just a matter of political convenience or socially putting bad history behind us. It is a matter of principle, philosophically, and that's the argument Locke is making. But this is not all. And we can ask more about other kinds of toleration. But when we switch back to the other side of the divide, how far do I, as a religious person, need to tolerate differences in my community with respect to religion? What if I'm now the magistrate? What if I'm the one with the political power? How far do I need to tolerate weirdnesses that are going on with respect to religion?

- 3.70** He wants to then say, well, I've already proved, we've already proved the care of the souls does not belong to the magistrate. But what if someone is clearly being lazy with respect to religious matters? Intellectually lazy. Doesn't care, doesn't want to think about it, has a certain kind of lifestyle. Wouldn't a good magistrate say, "Hey, you ought to think about your soul a little bit more." Perhaps put some incentives in place to get the person to go to church more often. Maybe subsidize the price of scriptural work so the person, everybody can have a hope of doing so. So Locke wants to say, no, that is not the responsibility of the magistrate, even in those cases. Just as I am responsible for my body, I am responsible for my soul.
- 3.71** The magistrate is only to protect my bodily interest, not to make sure that I am attending to my soul properly. That's between me and God. And if I've decided I'm going to be lazy with respect to the salvation of my soul, even God is not going to save me. And that's the point here. "God himself will not save men against their wills." Now, why not? And then Locke wants to make some arguments here that appeal to our regular understanding of what it is to be a human being. On what possible grounds would we think that civil magistrates, people who go into politics, are better on religion than average people? Think about your elected officials. Are they somehow more knowledgeable, more skilled, more morally focused on religious matters than the average person? It doesn't make any sense. The reason people become politicians, or in positions of political authority, has very little to do with their superiority on religious matters. So it would be a matter of great irresponsibility to turn political, sorry, religious authority over to the politicians as well.
- 3.72** Now some might then say, well, OK, that's fine, politicians, maybe they're not very good on theological matters, but that's why we need to have the politicians working with religious authorities, the big brains who are running the various religious institutions, and they can, at a very minimum, serve as advisors to the magistrates on religious matters. And these are the people who are smart and really good and so forth. So, some will say men are bound to follow the affairs of religion to be in the civil magistrate, but in the church. Right? So we still have an integration of church and state with this advisory role, and sometimes a more muscular advisory role. And Locke wants to say, this is where history matters a lot, because if we look at how politics and religion have actually mixed, we're empiricists now on these political matters. We are empiricists on religious matters.
- 3.73** When we look at just recent British history, is it the case that the monarch took advice from the religious authorities and put that into practice, and good religion and good politics resulted? Is that how it went? Or is it not actually the case that what happened was the politicians wanted to do what the politicians wanted to do, and then the religious authorities went along with whatever the politicians wanted, sometimes cravenly, sometimes being bought out by material rewards, changing their theological

tune, changing their practices in accordance with politics. So, instead of this idea that politicians will follow true religious teachings, the practical reality is the exact opposite.

3.74 "I answer: Who sees not how frequently the name of the church, which was venerable in the time of the apostles, has been made to use to throw dust in the people's eyes in the following ages?" And then he goes through a whole series of examples in recent British history. What happened in the regime of Henry VIII? Henry VIII wanted to get his divorce. How many members of the clergy said, "Oh, OK"? How many, after Henry officially broke from the church, says, "No, we resign from our position in protest"? And how many of them instead said, "Oh, whatever Henry wants, I guess we'll go along with, and we will find ways to manipulate the text in order to provide theological support, and we will just hope that Henry will continue to pay our salaries," right? And so forth. And then the same thing that happened under Edward VI, under Mary, under the—"how easily and smoothly the clergy change their decrees."

3.75 So if you think in any way, shape, or form that the church should be the advisor, or church in bed with government, what you're in effect setting yourself up just for is politics using religion as a tool for its own political purposes. That's what the lesson of history teaches us. Now, coming back to tolerance issues. "You will say by this rule," this strong tolerance, "if congregations should have a mind to sacrifice infants"—there are some religions that practice infant sacrifice, right? "Or to lustfully pollute themselves in promiscuous uncleanness." Uncleanness, rather. They have sex orgies as part of their religion. Are we supposed to tolerate that or practice such heinous enormities? You know, huge numbers of animal sacrifices and throwing blood around and doing all sorts of things. What about all of those? Are the magistrates supposed to tolerate those?

3.76 And here Locke says no. These are not lawful in the ordinary course of life. You're not allowed to kill children. Children have a life. They have a right to it. Part of the job of the civil magistrate is to protect people's rights to life. So the fact that you have a religion that says, "According to our religion, we're supposed to do that," no, it's not a religious matter at all. This is a protection of individual civil interests. Right to life. So that's law. And if we have laws against, you know, public orgies, as a matter of the ordinary course of things, the fact that some people say we have a religious reason for trying to have this public orgy, no. It's not that we are objecting to your religion. We're saying, in the normal civil course of things, that's not what we do and so forth. So you can't use theological reasons to suppress, but if there's things that you think on ordinary political grounds, go ahead and do so.

3.77 Now, a couple of exceptions that are worth thinking and arguing about, and these are ones that, in the subsequent debates over Lockean toleration, are very interesting. There's a question of how far this toleration is going to extend. So we've got a lot of different religions out there. We're going to tolerate all of them, let them go their own way. But who does Locke have in mind when he's writing here? "That church can have

no right to be tolerated by the magistrate, which is constituted upon such a bottom that all those who enter into it do thereby ipso facto," that is to say, by that fact alone, "deliver themselves up to the protection and service of another prince." And here, Locke is talking about Catholics, and we have this very wide-ranging, robust toleration, but not for Catholics. And what's the argument here?

- 3.78** If you become a Catholic in England, who is your highest allegiance? Your highest allegiance is to the Pope, in Rome. And what is Rome? Rome is another political state. It's not a separation of church and state. So, on political matters, if you are a Catholic, you have a divided allegiance. Are you loyal to England, or are you loyal to Rome? And this is to abstract the issue of religion, the particular religious beliefs, that differentiate Catholic religion from others. This is to say, if you are saying, by your religious commitments, that you are going to do what the ruler of another country says, then I have no guarantee that you are going to follow the laws of this land. And so, I am not going to tolerate that. So it's an interesting case to think about, because there we have obviously a mixture of religion and politics in that particular religion. And the civil magistrate, Locke wants to argue, is not entitled to let a religion do an end run around ultimate obligation to respect the laws of the country in which you are in.
- 3.79** OK. "Lastly, those are not at all to be tolerated who deny the being of a God." Atheists? No, not yet. Right, this is still early in days of toleration. Because you can't trust them, the argument is. They can't swear an oath on the Bible. You can't trust them in courts, contracts, and so forth. But Catholics are an interesting exception. Atheists are an interesting exception. But all of the different Protestant denominations, right, Muslims, Jews, toleration. Locke is entirely in favor of it.
- 3.80** I want to make a quick transition here. Setting up for the next lectures here, we're pushing hard on separation of church and state. There's one other thing that is going to redound across the coming generations, and that is this right of revolution. Locke, with strong individual self-responsibility, free agency, and so forth, wants to argue that citizens always have the right to rebel against unjust rulers. The powers that the politicians have come from, the people, it's a strong parliamentary, democratic kind of model, or republican model. Power comes from the bottom up. It's a delegated set of powers for a particular set of purposes. When that trust is broken or abused, the power devolves back to the citizens who have the right to rebel, to get rid of the old monarch, and to put a new monarch in place. This is in second treatise of government, which I—people who always have their original liberty, that is never alienated.
- 3.81** A point looking further afield is across the ocean in the American colonies. Lockean ideas became, so to speak, the political Bible, the philosophical Bible, the religious Bible, enormously influential there. And the US Declaration of Independence is a very Lockean document, as is the Constitution of the United States. So, Locke's importance as a philosopher is not only on technical epistemological issues, it's also on these matters of religion and politics. And then closer to home, this is where we will be

turning tomorrow, is across the English Channel. Lockean ideas had enormous influence, largely in the person of Voltaire, who will be our central focus next time. And Lockean ideas, along with Baconian ideas and Newtonian ideas, the ones we have been developing in these three lectures, are transported across the Channel to France, to revolutionary effect there as well.

Lecture 4: The French Enlightenment

At a glance — The French Enlightenment.

- 4.1 We're turning to the "philosophes" and the French Enlightenment today. I want to start in the year 1716. This is a special year for a number of reasons. There were two women in England who were burned at the stake for being witches. It's striking that there were two women. Their names were Mary Hicks and Elizabeth Hicks, mother and daughter. There's some significance. My last name is Hicks. I feel a connection. Perhaps more significantly, though, for history, is that these were the last women in England to be burned for witchcraft, a sign of changing times as we are entering modernity, because the practice of torturing and burning witches has a long history in England.
- 4.2 But we're into modernity, and one of the things that is being modernized is justice, our understanding of what justice is, as a general principle, but also the instantiation of justice in the practice of human life. Justice is a normative concept, and where normative concepts come from is a huge philosophical presupposition. Of course, traditionally, for many centuries, the view had been that God, of course, is the source of justice. He is the source of everything, but he's also the source of the standards of good and evil, and he, so to speak, lays down the law, and we follow the law.
- 4.3 Now, what does that mean in practice? Well, of course, we appeal to scripture, and scripture says different things at different times, and there's a long history. Do we take this passage from Exodus and say, "But if there is any further injury, then you shall appoint as a penalty, life for life, eye for eye, tooth for tooth, hand for hand, foot for foot, burn for burn, wound for wound, bruise for bruise." So the bad guy did something, and the justice system does the same bad thing back to that person. At one level, this sounds rather barbaric. What do we do in bizarre cases of rape? Are we supposed to rape the person? Well, then we say, "No, that's too barbaric." So what we need to do is understand this a little more abstractly. There's a principle of proportionality at work. In some sense, the effect should match the cause or the crime, and the punishment should be at the same level. And so we are working toward that. Nonetheless, this is still a harsh standard of justice. And in practice, it can, of course, be harsh.
- 4.4 Or do we rely more on a passage like this one from Romans? "Never avenge yourselves, but leave it to the wrath of God, for it is written, 'Vengeance is mine, I will repay,' says the Lord," which at one level seems to say that we should never try to do anything to bad people because that's not our responsibility. God provides not only the standard of justice, but also the administration of justice, and it's not up to us. And so we should adopt, perhaps, a more pacifistic or hands-off notion. Now, which of these passages and, of course, the many others in scripture we choose to emphasize—long-standing debate. But nonetheless, in practice, over the course of many centuries in Western history, it was the harsher version of justice that typically prevailed.

- 4.5 So one example of this is, all through the Middle Ages, even on into early modernity, is we're going to put bad people on trial. And what, of course, we want to know is, is this person guilty or is this person innocent? And how do we go about doing so? There are several standard techniques of doing so. One of them is this idea, though, of a trial by ordeal. We put the suspect under an ordeal. The idea is, if the person passes the ordeal, that shows that he or she is innocent. If he fails, that shows that the person is guilty. The idea here is that we are going to do something that seems bad or painful to the person. We use this as a working example.
- 4.6 We will take the person's hand and we will take an iron bar that has been heated to red hot. That's the bigger picture here. We see the flames. To the left of the image, we have a person reading scripture, officiating, and then we have the person holding, embracing from behind, the person who is going to be subject to the ordeal. Is that a restraining gesture? Is that a protecting gesture? That is an interesting matter for interpretation. But the iron hot bar is going to be put in the person's hand, and we will, at the end of that, see if it leaves a burn mark or if it does not leave a burn mark. The idea is, if this person is innocent, God will not allow bad things to happen to an innocent person. That's justice, God's goodness in action. We will then know the person is innocent, protected by God. If, by contrast, God allows it to go through, and the person is burned, then that is indicative of that the person is guilty because God is then allowing punishment to occur.
- 4.7 Trials by ordeal, many of them very creative, the medieval mind at work, were put in practice. This, of course, is one that is famous as a cliché, the practice of repeated dunking. You take a person, perhaps a suspected witch, put them in this circumstance, dunk them underwater, and make them stay there for a while, bring them up, put them under for another while. The dark humor here is, if the person drowns, well, that shows that they were a normal human being and couldn't withstand that punishment. On the other hand, if the person survives this, that means dark forces are at work because no normal human can survive this, and that proves she perhaps is a witch, in which case we need to burn her at the stake.
- 4.8 So, there is a kind of logic to this administration of justice, but it's a logic that is increasingly under question as we get into the modern world. We need to modernize justice. This is in an earlier lecture. We mentioned the doctrine of benevolent torture. St. Augustine, going back to the early days of the institutionalization of Christianity as the Roman Empire is declining. Christianity comes to be the dominant religious intellectual framework, and the idea then of the many diverse religions kicking around in the Mediterranean basin that we can no longer be tolerant of this. There is one true faith, and it is now backed by the power of the Roman state. And so we will enforce conformity and uniformity in religious practice. So that means dissenters of various sorts need to be dealt with rather harshly.

4.9 But again, here, the idea was that we're not just being politically power-playing or we're just not being individually sadistic individuals. We really think there's only one way to get to heaven, and that is by believing the true faith. If you have people who are not believing the true faith, you need to get their attention somehow. And torture does exactly that. It concentrates the person's attention to give them one last chance. If you really love your neighbor, you will be willing to do so. So, as we get into the modern world, this is a quotation from Montaigne, an essayist younger than Descartes. But as we get into the modern world, this ironic stance toward this long-standing doctrine of benevolent torture. He's saying, "Do we really know God's mind? Do we really know that God has sanctioned these kinds of punishments, these kinds of tests of guilt or innocent? What do we really know?" And that somewhat skeptical question that the moderns put them to themselves increasingly firmly.

4.10 In this ironic remark on this notion of benevolent torture: "It's putting a very high price on one's conjectures." Your conjectures, you think, really are worth a lot, but notice he uses the word conjectures. These are not truths that we know for sure. They're just your conjectures with respect to religion. "To have a man roasted alive because of them." Do you really know well enough that you are in the possession of the absolute truth, that you are willing to roast someone else alive, burn them to death, because you are so convinced of the truth? Now, Montaigne's answer, and increasingly the modern answer is no, we don't. We need to rethink our standards of justice, and that means thinking as moderns do. What is the evidence? What is the logic? What is the rational way of administering justice? So all of that early modern epistemology starts to do its work in the administration of justice.

4.11 Now, there's another theme that we started to see, particularly in the more empiricist tradition, but also in the rationalist tradition as well. Not so much about the epistemological issues, but how we understand the human being. One characteristic of modern justice is we have this notion of the presumption of innocence as we go into a court of law. We are not going to assume that the person is guilty instead. There's a presumption of innocence. We put a burden of proof on the prosecution. You have to prove beyond a reasonable doubt—notice the word reasonable doubt. All those modern phrases coming to the fore—that this person is guilty, and if you do not meet that standard of proof, we will let the person go as innocent.

4.12 Well, that is a turnaround from the long-standing notion that we should presume the guilt of people when we go into law. There, the then burden of proof is to put it on the person who has been accused to show that he or she is not guilty. That burden-of-proof issue becomes very important in the administration of law. If you cannot prove that you are innocent, then we will assume that you are guilty, and the law will take its course. Now, behind that, though, are some heavyweight philosophical issues. If, as a matter of philosophical principle, on your views of human nature, you think that people are, by nature, evil, bad, sinful creatures, then of course you're going to expect them to

do by and large bad things. And if they end up in a court of law, well, then the expectations is there for a good reason. So the presumption of guilt makes a whole lot more sense.

4.13 By contrast, if your understanding of human nature is more optimistic and you think that perhaps people are naturally good, or at least that they are born naturally neutral, *tabula rasa*, blank slate, and they can become good or they become evil by their own choices, and perhaps with good upbringing, and if they are taught to be rational, they'll by and large make good choices and so on, then you're going to assume that people are innocent at birth. And of course, some of them will become bad, but then we have to show that they have bad and done bad things in a particular case. So a philosophical view of human nature, combined with epistemological standards of evidence and proof, are reworking the justice system in the modern world.

4.14 We find then a very lively debate about where, ultimately, our sources of justice are coming from. In the modern world, we had all four of these positions based on principles that are revealed to us by God and/or they are principles that have been worked out in the tradition. And so, even if we don't know the origins of that tradition ourselves, we should, as citizens, have an attitude of reverence toward the traditions as they have been worked out in institutions that have come down to us. The government knows best, by and large. Is it a matter, more cynically, of just power? Whoever the king is or the Lord is, that person makes the rules. There's no higher standard, perhaps. But we're not in a position to change the king's will. So, justice just is whatever the king says.

4.15 Or, and this is the modern answer, that none of those is correct. Justice is based on reason. Justice is based on actual evidence, actual logic, and, increasingly, the use of science and its techniques to work out what we can and should use in the court of law. And then the stylized forms of argumentation, back and forth by the prosecution side, by the defense side, and we make a judgment call about who has the better facts, and interpretations of the facts, on their side. All of this then is being worked out in the early modern world and depends on the philosophies that had been developed—Bacon's philosophy, Descartes' philosophy, Locke's philosophy, in the 1600s.

4.16 Now, there's another interesting conception that is working with this, and that is, how do we even conceive of God himself? Now, we have our question: Do we really know that God exists? And if we believe that God exists, that we know, that we understand, who God is and what he wants for us accurately or not. So all of those epistemological issues are important. But also, how do we even understand God himself? A piece of terminology that starts to become more prominent in the early modern world is, to the extent that we believe in God, and by and large, people were still believers in God, do we think of God in the old-fashioned way, as a personality? But he is a personality who has strong ideas and strong emotions, and he's actively involved in the world, and sometimes he's angry, and sometimes he's loving, and sometimes he seems vengeful,

and sometimes he seems to say this, but he changes his mind and he acts a little bit differently this way.

- 4.17** This is a theistic God, in the traditional sense. As we get into the modern world, we start to say, well, yes, there is a God, of course, who is overseeing the world, but our understanding of God is as a more rational being. He's not driven so much by changing emotions, and he's more consistent in his thinking and in his actions. When he makes up his mind, he gets it right the first time, and we can follow that logically and consistently across the generations. And this position came to be known as deism, in contrast to theism. And it's a God, but he is a scientific God, or at least the kind of God that, if you are a scientist, and as we are getting into the modern world, you are going to be a more scientifically minded person. And think of then the God who perhaps created the world and created the laws of the universe and then put them into place according to some grand plan as a rational, scientific, mathematically minded God.
- 4.18** So that when we, scientists, we start to observe nature, using the equipment that God gave us, and then conceptualizing it and doing the experimenting and working our way up to those universal rules and laws that we understand the universe to be operating in terms of, we are doing God's work, but also what we are doing is figuring out God's plans for the world. Basically, we scientists then, with our fully worked-out theory, are going to be reading the mind of God, and the best scientific theory ultimately then will be a restatement of God's design and plan for the universe. But the laws of nature are not whimsical. They don't change their mind. They're not passion-driven. They are rational, cause-and-effect, systematic, logical, predictable, and so on.
- 4.19** I like this image from the late 1700s that God here is designing the world, but then we have all of the symbols of science and mathematics at work. We have the perfect circle, we have the triangle, and God is using that compass to design things that we know everything is going to be very precise and turning out very well. Now, of course, it's not only theism and deism, but we start to have people saying, well, maybe we can't actually prove the existence of God. Maybe we don't really know the existence of God. Perhaps we should be willing and open to the idea of agnosticism. And agnosticism, to go back to the Greek root, agnostic is someone who claims knowledge, insight, "gnosis" of a certain source. Then the "a" is always a negative prefix for whatever it is that you are putting in front. Maybe we don't really know that there is the existence of God, and we shouldn't start from the assumption of God as a matter of dogmatic principle or a matter of faithful belief, just because that's what we've been taught to believe.
- 4.20** If we are going to be rational people, we put everything to the test. We put everything to the question. And even as Jefferson, this is now starting to be an international movement in the 1700s. "Question with boldness, even the existence of God, because, if there be one, he must approve—more, rather—approve the homage of reason than that of blindfolded fear." God does not want people who are just complacently going along with what their parents taught them, under a matter of social pressure,

believing whatever it is they want, believing all kinds of things that they don't really understand, but they find them comforting in various ways. We are, as human beings, creatures of reason. If God made us with the capacity of reason, he wants us to use that capacity to come to understand him. He does not want fearful, conformist believers. That's not what true religion would ultimately.

4.21 Then it's a matter of, where does reason lead you? Does it lead you in the direction of belief or in the direction of disbelief? That is the responsibility of each individual in the modern world. Now, all of this—ideas, these are ideas now that we've seen coming out of Francis Bacon, out of René Descartes, out of John Locke. They are starting to work their way across the Atlantic to the colonies in North America, South America, also. But also they are starting to work their way across, after John Locke, across the Channel, rather, to the continent again, and especially to France. What I want to focus on now will be the leading thinker, now in the early 1700s, who came to be the most famous name associated with the French Enlightenment, and this is Voltaire.

4.22 That's a pen name that he chose for himself. But as a young man, extraordinarily well educated, extraordinarily clever and gifted with words, he wrote plays, he wrote poems, and he was, immediately, from the time of his intellectual maturity, a proto full Enlightenment thinker and very distrustful and sarcastically attacking any sort of intellectual authoritarianism and political authoritarianism. And of course, that is rife in France at his time. Now, there was a lively regime of censorship, and this led to a widespread underground network of publishing. All kinds of pamphlets and books would be published anonymously on whatever the political and religious issues of the day. Voltaire entered enthusiastically into this. Often, the censors, on behalf of the king and on behalf of the church, who were working together quite closely, still in France at this time, would not worry about many of them because they were so ignorantly and badly written.

4.23 But Voltaire was brilliant from a young age, and he had a way with words. He started then to come under suspicion, and then outright accusation, with respect to the authorities. He would name names when he was attacking people who were members of the aristocracy, members of the church, for their various inconsistencies and hypocrisies and so forth. He started to be subject to punishments, temporary exiles to a place out of Paris, put him out in the provinces, so he's not going to be problematic. But at a certain point, he went after the Chevalier, de Rohan-Chabot, and words were exchanged between the two of them. But you don't really want to get into an exchange of dueling words with Voltaire. And it got to a point where Voltaire said, "I'm going to challenge this guy to a duel," which was probably not a very good strategic move for Voltaire. Good with words, but he's not going to prevail very well in a duel with a member of the aristocracy who, from youth, is trained in the martial arts and would probably kill him pretty easily.

- 4.24 But fortunately for Voltaire, the Chevalier thought it was beneath his dignity to actually engage in a duel with this commoner, this mere commoner. But nonetheless, this guy is very problematic. He's an irritating individual. So the decision was that, after a short time in the Bastille, in prison, they're going to send him into exile, a more serious exile. So they sent him to England. And he agreed to go to England just to get him out of their, I guess, out of their hair, but out of their wigs for a while. So Voltaire goes into exile in England, and he's a very active-minded guy, and he is curious about what's really been going on in England. He's read some of the English authors, so he knows Francis Bacon, he knows about Isaac Newton, he knows about John Locke. Of course, he knows his own French intellectuals. He knows Montesquieu, he knows Descartes, very well-educated young man. He also has somewhat of a reputation, so many doors are opened to him, and he meets a wide variety of people.
- 4.25 What he then decides to do, while he is there, is to write a series of letters about what he's doing in England. He originally has them published in England, but his real audience is back in France, and very quickly, they are published in France as well. This is one of the works that makes his great reputation. I love going to the original words of our authors. Let's go into the Letters Concerning the English Nation, or Letters from England, as they are sometimes translated, and get a sense for what Voltaire's mind is doing and what his agenda is.
- 4.26 I want to start by having a quick look at the table of contents. He actually ends up publishing 24 letters on a wide variety of topics—religion, politics, commerce, trade, the arts, and the humanities. But what are these first seven letters? We have the first one on the Quakers, another one on the Quakers, another one on the Quakers, and now for something different, another letter on the Quakers. And then the Church of England, or the Anglican Church, as we now call it, or in the States, the Episcopalians. Then the Presbyterians, which is the main church up north in Scotland, inspired primarily by the Calvinists, out of [inaudible]. Then the Socinians, or the Arians, or the Anti-Trinitarians, another sect, and so on. What this tells us, though, is, right off the bat, Voltaire is going to start with religion. Religion is a number one issue, and he knows, of course, back in France, there is no separation yet of church and state, and there is still a very hierarchical monarchy and a very hierarchical clergy, and they are integrated tightly with each other.
- 4.27 So one of the interesting things is, we're going to take this religion issue first. A little bit later, you notice we'll talk about parliament and government, how the English do their politics. We'll talk about trade and how the English do their commerce. How did they become so rich from being this island country basically out in the boondocks, the northwest, away from the center of action. A little on the sciences, and practical science of inoculation. A letter on that. Then letters on individuals we recognize—Bacon, Locke, Descartes, and Newton. Then there are some other letters, but we won't have time at all to get to those ones as well. We're going to have a comprehensive

intellectual, sociological understanding of what's going on in England, including its history.

- 4.28 But why the Quakers? Why the Quakers? What I want to suggest is, of course, Voltaire has an agenda right at work here. He has read Locke, and Locke's Letter Concerning Toleration, and he wants to push that in France. How can we get this idea of modern, rational, individual understanding with respect to religion, and especially, socially and politically, the idea of toleration? That's very hard for the French for, as with many countries in Europe, the religious hatreds and the revenge cycle and all of the doctrinaire ideological disputes were harsh, harsh, harsh. So we have a huge social and intellectual obstacle to overcome.
- 4.29 The idea here is that the Quakers are a kind of Protestant denomination, so they are not at all in favor of establishment Christianity, Catholicism. They're also what we call low church, in the sense that they don't believe in high doctrine, hierarchical churches, elaborate ceremonies, people having titles—"your worship, your eminence, your specialness"—and so forth. They are very basic, plain, egalitarian in their approach to religion. And so the idea here is that the Quakers are, as a religion, almost the exact opposite of high church Catholicism, as it is in France. And so what we want to do is put these in contrast to each other. And of course, it's going to be to the detriment of the Catholic version as instantiated in France and in favor of the Quaker version.
- 4.30 But also as we go through, notice that he's giving the Quakers a say about what their doctrines are, but he puts it in the form of a conversation. He meets with this Quaker individual, and he asks him questions about what his beliefs are and what his practices are. But he puts himself rhetorically in the voice of being a rather naive, younger Frenchman. "So you say this, but why do you believe that?" And then, of course, when the Quaker says something that is very opposed to religion, as it is understood in France, Voltaire pretends that he is outraged. "How can someone say this sort of thing?" And that is meant, of course, to be an ironical device, but also to protect himself against potential censorship once the word gets out. Because then he goes, "Look at my reaction here. I was not going along with this crazy zealot who is believing these entirely wrong things." So let's dive into the text a little bit.
- 4.31 "I made a visit to one of the most eminent Quakers in England, who, after having traded for 30 years, had the wisdom to prescribe limits to his fortune and to his desires and was settled in a little solitude not far from London." All right, so this guy is very successful in business, but now he's rich, but he has the good sense to realize "I am rich enough to live as I want, and so I'm going to go into retirement." How is this guy? Well, he is "a hale, ruddy-complexioned old man who had never been afflicted with sickness." Something about his diet and his lifestyle. The contrast is meant to be, if we think of old men who are in the church hierarchy back in France, who have been, of course, drinking and eating very well and overindulging in various ways, who are, in

many cases, corpulent and suspect to all sorts of diseases and so forth, there's a sickness issue there and a health issue here.

- 4.32 "He is dressed in a plain coat." All of the finery that members of the church hierarchy like to wear, silks and furs and tall hats to augment themselves. Dressed very plainly. "He did not uncover himself when I appeared," that is to say, he didn't take his hat cap off, "without once stooping his body. But there appeared more politeness in the open humane air of his countenance than in the custom of drawing one leg behind the other." So he did not, that is to say, bow and scrape and do all of these things that French civilization and its niceties. It's not that, "Oh, you're special, and who am I to be in your presence? I need to bow and lower myself." You're a man. I'm a man. We approach each other as equals. We shake hands. We're going to have a conversation.
- 4.33 Then we get into more serious issues. So, Mr. Quaker, were you ever baptized? "'I never was,' replied the Quaker, 'nor any of my brethren.'" So these are Anabaptists. They don't believe in the baptism ritual. Does this mean that they don't believe in original sin, that babies are born with the stain of evil evil on them? It needs to be cleansed from them early in their lives. Do they believe that we're born naturally good or naturally tabula rasa? This is a shocking doctrine to a country in which —Voltaire's response: "'Zounds!' I say to him. 'You are not Christians then.' 'Friend,' replies the old man in a soft tone." Notice he doesn't get angry, the way religious discussions often go. "Swear not. " Don't swear. "We are Christians and endeavor to be good Christians, but we are not of the opinion that the sprinkling of water on a child's head makes him a Christian." There's no magical ritual that occurs here. Of course, the child doesn't know what's going on. So this Lockean notion, you don't really become a member of a church until you know what you believe and you are making your own commitment and so on. So the argument here, baptism ritual, doesn't make any sense in a lot of different ways.
- 4.34 "'Heavens!' say I, shocked at his impiety." And then he gives a counterargument. "'Haven't you forgotten that Christ was baptized by Saint John?'" It's right there in the Bible. Baptism is part of their religion. "'Friend,' replies the mild Quaker once again. 'Swear not. Christ was indeed baptized by John, but he himself never baptized anyone. We are the disciples of Christ, not of John.'" So did Christ do any baptism? And so what we have here, though, is a reasonable discussion about Biblical issues and important theological matters. But the Quaker is modeling how these should go. And of course, Voltaire is pretending to respond as the more emotionalist, not very rational Christian. "I pitied very much the sincerity of my poor worthy Quaker, and was absolutely for forcing him to get himself christened." All right, so there I'm pitying this guy, but I'm in favor of, in effect, using force as traditionally doing so.
- 4.35 Then there's a counterargument that the Quaker comes up with about circumcision. He points out that Jesus had one of his disciples circumcised. And so does this mean that, if you're going to be a Christian, you need to get circumcised? The Quaker then has this counterargument and says to you—you, Voltaire—"are you circumcised?" And Voltaire

then goes on to say, "No, I'm not circumcised." And then the logic then seems to be, "Well, then you probably aren't a Christian then." But Voltaire says, "I had more sense than to contest with him, since there is no possibility of convincing an enthusiast." So basically, I'm going to run away from this argument. I don't have a counterargument to this. This is, of course, just a representative of the way many religious debates go. The person doesn't have an answer, so they run away and call the other person names and so on.

4.36 Here we highlight the issue of what is it to treat another person of the religion? Are we supposed to have this hierarchical structure, where I'm down at the bottom as 90% of the laity are, and I revere everybody up on this hierarchy, and everybody has increasingly special clothing and increasingly special titles as they get up and up in the hierarchy? In contrast to this more democratizing understanding of religion, we are all perhaps subject to God, but we are not special, socially, with respect to each other on this religious matter. So, we get rid of titles. We don't flatter ourselves. We don't flatter other people. And we just call people "thee" and "thou," this personal direct form instead of all of these flashy titles.

4.37 We dress plainly. We don't go to assemblies of pleasure. We don't do gambling. We don't go to various sorts of places where we might become alcoholic. We don't swear, and they follow through on that, no cursing and so forth, and we don't war or fight. We are pacifistic all the way through. And so, already on this first letter on the Quakers, we have this contrast between Christianity as practiced by Quakers and Christianity as practiced by the establishment in France, and the contrast could not be greater. And the idea here is, if you're a reasonable person and you listen to this Quaker, he seems like a good guy. He seems like a reasonable guy. So why would we be persecuting these people? Is it just prejudice? Do we have good arguments against it? That's the question Voltaire wants us to think through.

4.38 He gets invited in letter two to go to the church, rather, to the assembly with the Quaker. And what he notices is there's several hundred people, men and women. They're all seated together. It's not that we have the men here and the women are up in a balcony elsewhere or behind a screen further, so more integration. And nobody talks for 15 minutes, a quarter of an hour. Can you imagine? You're sitting there. What's going on? "Then one of them stands up, takes off his hat, and, after making a variety of wry faces and groaning in a most lamentable manner, he, partly from his nose and partly from his mouth, threw out a strange, confused jumble of words, which neither himself nor any of his hearers understood." So we now call this speaking in tongues. And the idea is, it's not, of course, expected that God speaks English or that God speaks French. God speaks God's language. But what sometimes can happen is that God will speak through a person. It can be any person, not necessarily special people. So you wait for the spirit of the Lord to move within you, and then whatever comes out, comes out.

- 4.39 All right, so this happens in the church, and of course, Voltaire is shocked at this. The Quaker starts to explain, and he says, "We even allow our women to hold forth." How very early modern. Allowing women. But, "'You have no priests then,' I say to him"—I, Voltaire—"No, no, friend," replies the Quaker, 'to our great happiness.'" We have no priests. We have no hierarchy. Religion is done in a more egalitarian, people are free to speak or not, fashion to our great happiness. Then how do you know then, this is our question, how do you know when this guy is speaking in tongues, if he's really speaking, or the Lord is really speaking through him or if he's just making stuff up? Partly the argument is going to be, well, that's between that guy and the Lord. That's not my business, so to speak. It's an individual relationship. He doesn't have to convince me, and I don't have to convince him. We're going inside the individual.
- 4.40 "'Whosoever,' he said, 'shall implore Christ to enlighten him, and shall publish the gospel truths, he may feel inwardly. Such an one may be assured that he is inspired by the Lord.'" You don't need the hierarchy. You don't need a priest or a bishop or anybody to tell you that they are saved or to engage in rituals and to forgive you and so forth. It's you and the Lord, and you, in the inwardness of your being, will know. So a very strong individualization of religion. And recognizing, again, that this is highly controversial and likely to be prejudicial to Voltaire's fortunes when he gets back in France. He softens the blow a little bit by mentioning a famous French philosopher, Malebranche, who had been a younger contemporary of Descartes, and they'd engaged, very smart guy, very well respected in France. But Voltaire is pointing out this, actually, philosophically, is what Malebranche was arguing for, not in theological context. So the Quakers might seem very alien, but really, there's a good French way of articulating this doctrine.
- 4.41 Very interesting letter on the Quaker. He mentions William Penn, who was an Englishman, but who had gone across the Atlantic Ocean to America. Pennsylvania, the state, is named after William Penn, but he was a Quaker, and he took Quaker doctrines to America. If we're interested in now the future of what's going to happen in America, we can expect that this new modern approach to religion is going to be important in America. "He had established a universal toleration with regard to conscience in America." So America, the brand new country—actually, it's not a country yet, but the brand new set of colonies—doesn't have this old traditional hierarchy that is connected, to deal with. It can start over and hopefully do things right.
- 4.42 We turn then to the Church of England. Notice some differences there in the Church of England. They let their priests get married, in contrast to traditional Catholic doctrine. Then if we think of all of the sexual irregularities and immoralities and weirdness that can go on in the history of religion involving unmarried priests and monks and nuns, maybe there's something a little healthier in this modern way of doing religion. Move on to the Presbyterians. This is the Calvinists, renamed for the Scottish, and, of course, they're very strict and severe, believe in a strong form of predestinarianism and so

forth. But in the middle of all of this discussion of Presbyterianism and its place in Britain more broadly, Voltaire makes this interesting passage about how, in England, religion is not simply a matter of people have all of their different beliefs and they are widely tolerant, but they are able then to deal with each other in the ordinary course of life, peacefully, tolerantly, in contrast to what has now been 1500s, 1600s, on into the 1700s, history of religious hatred and intolerances and persecutions.

- 4.43 He has this striking passage about the stock market in London, the Royal Exchange in London, where, no matter what people's religion are, they're able to leave the religion at the door, so to speak, when they go to do their daily business in the market. "The Royal Exchange in London, a place more venerable than many courts of justice, where the representatives of all nations," it's this very cosmopolitan place, "meet for the benefit of mankind." They get together and trade stuff all over the world. "There, the Jew, the Mahometan, and the Christian transact together, as though they all professed the same religion and give the name of infidel to none but bankrupts." The only religious sin here you can have is to go bankrupt. It's a nice metaphor. "There, the Presbyterian confides in the Anabaptist, and the churchman depends on the Quaker's word."
- 4.44 So it's not only that commerce brings people together, which it does for their mutual benefit and the benefit of mankind, but also the English have worked out a way to park religion, separate religion, not only from the state, separate religion from business. Get on with business, get on with politics, and then religion is this private individual responsibility that we all bear. Then, "if one religion only were allowed in England, the government would very possibly become arbitrary." A religion has a monopoly. What happens in the case of monopolies? They become arbitrary and abusive of the power that they have. "If there were but two, the people would cut one another's throats. But as there are such a multitude, they all live happy and in peace." So, religious diversity is a good thing. Religious tolerance is a good thing. Somehow the English have worked it out. And the important lesson for the French is to learn from the English how to do so.
- 4.45 Just a quick remark on the politics. He has a couple of the letters on how the English do their politics. And we know the English had their own civil wars, but they did have that peaceful Glorious Revolution where the power seriously transferred from the monarchy to the parliament. It is now more functioning as a democracy, and it has some separations of powers and some actual acts of toleration and other things as well. And he points out that the English really are exceptional in this. Lots of civilizations—and we again go back to Rome—have had civil wars, interior civil wars, and all of them ended worse for the nation that engaged in the civil war. But somehow the English were the first to have a civil war, and out of that came liberty. Out of that came freedom. What can we learn from the English?
- 4.46 But also we have Voltaire emphasizing a more general point about history, and this is one of the themes of the letters from England. We need to learn from history, not just

abstract philosophy, abstract theology, traditions that have come down. As empiricists, read what has happened by actual human beings, engage in the actual course of life, and generalize the lessons from the history. So, of course, we have our French history. We all learned Greek history, Egyptian history, Roman history. We learn all of those histories as well. What is the lesson? Here we have a success case. England is doing it well. So we need to learn English history and how they did it. So hopefully we can do something like that for the benefit of France, when we get there.

- 4.47 All right, I'm going to skip over all of that, but there's a mention here of the Magna Charta, or the Magna Carta. The first big transition from a more absolutist understanding of royal power to a somewhat decentralized notion where the aristocrats, the lords of England, were able to get some powers for themselves to force some concessions from the king. And so there's a decentralization that starts to occur there. And then, as England becomes more prosperous and a little more cosmopolitan, some of the other classes start to get powers increasingly for themselves. So there's a long history about this transition from an absolutist, tyrannical model of how society and politics should go, to a more liberal democratic culture and politics as we have in England. Let's learn our English history, so those of us in the rest of the world can achieve these successes here.
- 4.48 A point about equality. It's not just that the English are free people, they are an equal people. "No one is exempted in this country from paying certain taxes because he is a nobleman or a priest." Everybody pays their taxes. They pay a proportionate amount of taxes, and there's only one taxing body. Parliament is the only body authorized, instead of all of these different jurisdictions under the control of different people, many of whom have paid money in order to have a certain taxing privilege, and then pass it on to their son and so forth. Instead, one uniform tax, one body elected by the people that adjudicates that taxes. Trade, good.
- 4.49 I have to say a few words about this wonderful letter on inoculation, where he notes that smallpox is a great ravager of the human condition. He makes a point that, just recently in France, or in Paris alone, over 20,000 people had died from smallpox, and it affected people all over the world. But it came and went. Nobody had a clue what was causing it or what to do about it. Voltaire then makes a point here that's a somewhat modern point. As we go around the world, we start to learn new techniques that people have developed to solve various sorts of problems. Just as we can learn a lot from the English now, back in France, on this more scientific and medical matter, there are lessons that we French people can learn from others around the world.
- 4.50 Now, we think, of course, that the English are crazy in various ways, but one of the things that the English have started to do is inoculate their children with smallpox. The idea here is smallpox kills a lot of people, but some people survive it. Typically, though, they are quite disfigured from the pitting and scarring that the smallpox will leave. But what they have found is that, if you give the person a mild dose of the smallpox when

they are young, the vast majority of children survive it, and then they seem to be immune to smallpox for the rest of their life. So the English are doing this, and we're looking at them and we're saying, "Crazy, what? You're going to inject your child with a disease? That's just bad. That's immoral. What kind of people are these English?"

- 4.51 But he goes on to point out that the English didn't discover this themselves. There's the mention of how many people were killed in England, but that the English were now travelers and traders and becoming increasingly cosmopolitan individuals. And they had learned it from the Circassians, who had, apparently, very beautiful women. And a lot of these beautiful young women were, of course, sold into sex slavery in various harems and so forth. But all of that aside, nonetheless, they wanted to keep their children from being disfigured, and so they would do this inoculation, and it worked. So their children were, by and large, immune from the smallpox. But then pointing out that the Circassians seem to have learned it from the Chinese, who perhaps discovered it even more.
- 4.52 But then again, we have this modern notion, that it's not the right that we in our culture are doing everything exactly right, and we have all of the revealed truths. We're in a big world, and we're dealing with people all over the world, and lots of people have come up with things that we can adopt and learn from. We should be much more cosmopolitan in our notion. Learn from the Chinese, learn from the Circassians, learn from the English. Open not only our borders, open our minds, to the big, broad world.
- 4.53 Now, we'll just do one more point from the Letters on the English. I recommend you just get a copy and read it for yourself at your leisure. There's a lot more there. But this fascinating question —those of us who like history, like ideas, we have our heroes, and we like to think about who our heroes and heroines are. Voltaire here raises this question: "Who was the greatest man in history?" And then we have a standard list. Well, Caesar, Julius Caesar, the first successful dictator of Rome. What about Alexander the Great, who basically conquered most of the known world before dying young? What about Tamerlane? What about that Englishman Cromwell? And so forth. And so, very standardly, when people start generating a list of the greatest men in history, it's people like this, and these are all military people. These are conquerors.
- 4.54 Or we might mention kings, who had a certain amount of splendor and glory associated with their regime. If we are religiously minded, we might mention saints or men who are semi-deities themselves and so forth, perhaps Muhammad or your interpretation of Jesus. Was he the greatest man in history or was he the son of God? But someone answered, "somebody answered that Sir Isaac Newton excelled them all. The gentleman's assertion was very just." This is fascinating because Sir Isaac Newton is not a conqueror. He's not a religious leader. He's not an aristocrat or a monarch. He is a scientist. And he is a near-contemporary. He's just died recently. He's a modern, not some great person from antiquity. Why? "If true greatness consists in having received from heaven a mighty genius and in having employed it to enlighten our own mind and

that of others." He enlightened us in a most important way, opening the doors to understanding nature in a brilliant way and developing new mathematical tools, including the calculus, for us to do so.

4.55 He enlightened our minds, and that is the greatest gift anybody can bestow upon a human being. It's not "I conquer you, and my glory is in part your misery." It is "I understand, and, therefore, put you in a position to understand nature." It's our mutually beneficial thing that is occurring, rather than a conquest model. And this is very modern. And then, "I shall begin with my list." And then notice who is on Voltaire's list of the greatest man in history. He cheats and says, "The greatest men in history—Bacon, Locke, and Newton." Bacon, Locke, and Newton. And all three of them are philosophers or scientists. All of them are modern. And then, the very interesting point—all of them are English. And here we have a Frenchman, not doing that standard national chauvinistic thing. "Well, of course, the greatest man in history has to be a Frenchman." Or if you're a Turk, the greatest man in history has to be a Turk. Or if you're whatever.

4.56 A willingness to say, people of some other country, some other nationality, some other ethnicity, have achieved something great. These are the great heroes of all time for human beings. They are not conquerors. They are not religious people. They are not politicians. They are people who enlighten us and put us in a position to learn from them, so that we ourselves can become enlightened, improve our lives, and improve the lives of those around us. Now, I commend to you the whole of the Letters From England, where there's a great deal more. Eventually, Voltaire returns from exile to France, and he has inspired the next generation of intellectuals. What comes to be known as the French Enlightenment is largely due to the direct influence of Voltaire. Of course, Voltaire is recommending that everybody learn Newton, everybody read Locke, everybody read Bacon. They did, and they started to apply those.

4.57 Now, these two individuals are from the middle part of the now 1700s, Dennis Diderot and D'Alembert. And they were co-editors of an extraordinarily ambitious project that began in 1750s. The project was to say, "We are now in an amazing age of new discovery, new knowledge, new technologies. We have become enlightened. And what we need to do is collect all of the knowledge that has been acquired and publish it in an encyclopedia." This is the first great encyclopedia project in history. And they work on it for 20-something years, publishing a multitude of very fat volumes containing articles written by people with expertise in all known fields, all of the sciences, all of the technologies, articles on all of the religions, all of the politics, and it is written in French. And the idea here is that everybody, any Frenchman, will be able to read this book.

4.58 It is a great democratizing-of-knowledge project. We want to produce an encyclopedia available to every person who is able to read, so they can read on all of these issues and become enlightened individuals themselves. An extraordinarily ambitious project, and these were the two co-editors. Most of the work ended up being done by Diderot,

though. He was more on the humanity side of things, as we now think of it. D'Alembert was much more mathematically and scientifically minded, so they were a good team in that sense. Another important thing is not only that it's written in French and the idea is that we're going to collect all knowledge in this new, enlightened age and make it available to every person to be available, but that Baconian idea that knowledge is not just an end in itself, that knowledge is meant to be used, that it's meant to be applied, that it's supposed to be practical.

4.59 Of course, all of these theoretical issues, we have to discuss them as theoretical issues, but we need to know what they mean for improving the human condition. And so we want to take theoretical knowledge, abstract scientific knowledge, integrate it with technological knowledge. We want to take philosophical knowledge and integrate it with our understanding of politics and how we understand religion in the modern world. It's all got to be connected and applied to life. I have a plate here where they would have articles on, in this case, on how to run a tannery, how to take the skins of animals and to treat them with chemicals and then turn them into articles of clothing and various other operations. And so everything is described. And there's also pictures. Here are all of the tools that you are going to need. And here's how you make all of these tools. Here's how you build a ship. Here's how you make a water wheel.

4.60 And all of that is next to articles on, this is what the Socinians in religion believe. This is what the Greeks did with respect to this, that, and the other thing. So we're trying to put all of the human knowledge into these volumes for everyone, and it is going to be applied. And one of the results was that there was a lively intellectual culture, not only in the fashionable salons in Paris and other places, but reading groups of common people getting together, and they will pool resources and get a copy of the volumes. Not every one of them could read, but somebody could read, and they would have someone read this, and they would look at the pictures, and they would have discussions and arguments about it, so livening the intellectual culture of France more broadly.

4.61 Now, this is another striking point. This is straight out of Voltaire. This is an ambitious project by French people. But in the dedication of the Encyclopedia, as is common for authors, to give special recognition of those who have been most helpful, influential to them, the dedication to the Encyclopedia cites these three individuals. It's dedicated to Francis Bacon, John Locke, and Isaac Newton. For leading French intellectuals, speaking, so to speak, on behalf of France, to recognize, if you think of the long history of animosity between the French and the English for centuries, the idea that we will now honor three Englishmen as the greatest of the great, is a very cosmopolitan modern notion.

4.62 On this theme of cosmopolitan, we start to see also, getting past traditional chauvinism, any number of authors very interested in exploring what's going on in other cultures, and what can we learn from those other cultures? That essay I

mentioned earlier, the name Montaigne, about roasting people alive based on your conjectures. Here he wrote an article on cannibals. And of course, cannibals, people eating other people, how barbaric, how savage. And Montaigne uses that as an introduction to say, "Well, yes, of course it is. But in other respects, the cannibals seem to be a lot healthier and less neurotic, as we might now say, than we are in other areas of life. And if we adopt the perspective of people from this tribe and we look at how we Frenchmen do various things, wouldn't many of the things that we do seem rather bizarre to them?" In fact, many of those things do seem rather bizarre.

4.63 So, the king has his eye on this lovely young woman here, but she's married to this gentleman over here. So the king orders this guy into battle so he can get killed so that he can have his way with this woman over here. A standard practice. Isn't that pretty barbaric? Isn't that pretty immoral? So are we really the height of civilization? Are they really the depths of barbarism and savagery? And what we need to do is this scientific contrast and compare, and be willing to change our habits and adopt habits from other cultures. A similar thing by Montesquieu, with his *Persian Letters*, being fascinated by that part of Asia that is south and west, and a longstanding culture, Persian culture, with a rich history. What can we learn from the Persians?

4.64 Diderot, on this *Supplement to Bougainville's Voyage*, one of those ship captains who had done a huge around-the-world type of navigation. What can we learn about the, in this case, very interesting—the sexual habits of people in Tahiti, who seem much less repressed and neurotic with respect to their sexual relations than all of the bizarre things that occur in contemporary French society and so on. And just a passing mention, of course, of Othello, who is a Moor, the hero of Shakespeare, the Merchant of Venice, an Italian, Mozart's *Abduction from the Seraglio*, which is a Turkish harem. So this idea of being fascinated by other cultures, but also, in a way that we can learn from them. How can we improve our culture by doing so?

4.65 This name, Enlightenment, an age of illumination, and we are illuminated, we are enlightened. For the first time, we start to see in the 1700s, this self-conscious recognition that something special in human history has happened since 1500, reaching a philosophical maturity in the 1600s, with Locke, Descartes, Bacon. Scientific maturity in the case of Isaac Newton, and now it's spreading into the entire culture. We're trying to enlighten the entire culture. What makes the Enlightenment an Enlightenment? Now, some small print here. Well, this is a more analytic chart, and I want to talk through just some of this a little bit with you. What we find is the increasingly scientific analysis of how to improve society, the idea that we can improve society. We can make progress. The idea that, in some sense, there was the great old days and all of history is just a decline into worse and worseness, or that it's just slight improvements and then we decline again, slight improvements—a cyclical view of history—that we should be able to figure out what problems kept human beings down for all of those centuries.

Identify the cause of those problems, identify a solution, and instantiate that solution in an analytic, scientific kind of fashion.

- 4.66** For example, vast majority of people have been ignorant for most of human history, not aware of the broader world beyond them, not aware of what's going on in the village beyond them, not able to read, not being able to do mathematics, just mass ignorance. And you read many ancient commentators, it's just, "Most people are stupid. It's just the way it is. They're not meant to be improved," and so forth. That's a problem that is identified. And in many cases, there is an explicit intellectual authoritarianism. Knowledge is the province only of a special elite of individuals, and they will jealously guard that. And they then go out of their way to keep the vast majority of people ignorant and so forth. But then the enlightened thinkers come along and say, "That is not true. Most people have the capacity. They have their senses. They have their reason. They have the capacity for learning. They can learn to read. They can, in fact, become enlightened."
- 4.67** If you believe that, philosophically, then you will try to do something about it. You will engage in mass literacy projects. You will mass-produce various sorts of works that you think are important and find ways to distribute them as much as possible to various people. You will go on the offensive against all of those intellectual authoritarians who want to keep people in the dark, who keep the important works out of their hands, who enact regimes of censorship, who want to protect their religious monopoly or protect their political monopoly in order to keep the masses servile and in an ignorant fashion. What you find is, on all of the important dimensions of society, the Enlightenment thinkers are working this out, and this is just one example of that. And so, what we then should have is a social science, not just a natural science, but a science of society such that we can diagnose every problem, figure out a solution to it, and then, with goodwill and increasingly good resources that we have, solve all problems.
- 4.68** Now, this is what I call the Enlightenment vision that came to be articulated as we get into the 1700s and the Age of Enlightenment. It's not to mean that these are the only causal arrows at work. There's lots of interplay here, but the basic notion is, first and foremost, in the modern world, there was an intellectual revolution. We know the names Bacon, Descartes, and Locke. They disagree with each other on some issues, of course, but all of them are opposed to any sort of intellectual authoritarianism or intellectual elitism. Every human being has the capacity of reason. How that reason works, they differ amongst themselves, of course. But to the extent that you win that debate, knowledge is not revelation, knowledge is not faith, knowledge is not tradition, knowledge is acquired by reason. That is a game-changer.
- 4.69** If you emphasize that reason is able to successfully study the natural world, then the scientific project starts to become intellectually understood and put into practice. You then start to see, over the course of the 1600s, 1700s, physics, astronomy, chemistry,

increasingly coming on board as real sciences. You take those sciences and you apply them to, that scientific mindset, to machinery, then you are generating an increasing age of invention. It's then not accidental that, by the time we get to the 1750s, we have the Industrial Revolution starting to take off, again, first in England, where these ideas had first put into practice. If also you emphasize science and a scientific way of thinking about things, and you apply it to the human being, we are a natural being, then you are going to be much more observant, much more distrustful of old traditions, much more experimental, using various new technologies to apply to medicine, and you're going to see the modernization of medicine. And that does come on board in the 1700s.

- 4.70** If, by contrast, you emphasize that reason, epistemologically, is a function of the individual—every individual has their reason, and they can learn how to use it and apply it well—then individualism, as a moral principle, becomes more important. I'm not just part of a group. I am an individual. I have my own mind, and I can think for myself, and we're going to be more respectful of individuals thinking for themselves and then acting individually on the basis of their own lives. Then you will find, and it's not a coincidence, the development of liberalism, democratic, republican forms of government, the Glorious Revolution, and not yet, those revolutions in America and France, but they are in the offing in the latter part of the 1700s. If you think that people are rational and self-responsible, then in the economic sphere, you're going to be more willing to say you are on your own. You can go into any line of work that you want, do business with anybody you want. And as a consumer, you're responsible for negotiating your prices and managing your household budget. And so we see the development of early capitalism.
- 4.71** And the idea here is that all of these intellectual ideas are being put into practice socially, and we can then project optimistically that we're going to make progress. People are going to be wealthier, they're going to be freer, they are going to live longer, they're going to have more stuff available to them. And as a result, people can and should be—happiness, the pursuit of happiness, becomes a realistic goal for human beings. Now, it does require, though, that we do a certain amount of activism against all of the authoritarians, and this does get very fiery in French fashion. "Erase the infamous thing." And by this, what Voltaire is talking about is not religion in general, but any intellectual form of religion top-down that has been practiced, in fact. Get rid of it. And even more strikingly, this phrase ascribed to Diderot, "Men will not be free until the last king is strangled with the entrails of the last priest."
- 4.72** So in France, but then there's a more general lesson here, where are the worst offenders with respect to authoritarianism? Not only intellectual, but political. It is the monarchy and it is the church. We have to get rid of both of those. Fiery words, revolutionary stuff. But if we carry on with this project. This is a wonderful line from Condorcet. "We have this vision, and we know what we are doing, and we can project a

time will come when the sun will shine only on free men who have no master but their own reason." That's Voltaire and the French Enlightenment.

Lecture 5: Counter-Enlightenment

At a glance — The Counter-Enlightenment.

- 5.1 All right. In philosophy, everything is controversial. So our theme now is Counter-Enlightenment. And the Counter-Enlightenment was inaugurated just as the Enlightenment was reaching its height. But I want to start with this date, 1789, as a date. Important, of course, in political history, because it is when the French Revolution, one of those great watersheds in modern history, occurred. There's a journalistic announcement of what's starting to happen. Things are riling up, getting tenser and tenser, worse and worse.
- 5.2 Now, intellectually, the lead-up to the French Revolution does significantly involve these two individuals, Voltaire and Rousseau, Jean-Jacques Rousseau, and they, to put it bluntly, hated each other. They knew of each other, of course. Rousseau was younger, Voltaire was the older, great light, and Rousseau, rather, is the younger upstart, but he was quite the provocateur. And once he became known, there was exchanges of letters over some years, some of them arguing, some of them nasty. Very interesting history.
- 5.3 But to come back to French Revolution and a little bit of French political history, as relevant here, obviously, France has a centralized monarchy. All of the Louises, Louis XIII, XIV, XV, XVI. And there's a power struggle that is developed over the course of two centuries of French history. And essentially, the monarchy wants all of the power, power centralized and focused on itself. The aristocrats, who were pretty powerful, but they had been losing significantly to the monarchy, but the aristocrats wanted decentralized power in this context. They wanted to be able to control their own aristocratic regions and not be so much under the force of the thumb, or the thumb of force, of the king, rather.
- 5.4 Now, to a large extent, though, the monarchy was successful, but as the Age of Enlightenment, intellectually, kicks in, but then also economically and politically, the monarchy starts to become weakened in the second part of the 1700s. And then the aristocrats see an opportunity. Always take advantage of your enemy's weaknesses. What they are then able to do, in 1789, is force a calling of the Estates-General, as it's called. France is organized into three classes, three estates. There's the aristocratic estate, the clergy, and then the commoners. And very rarely they get together to deliberate on various things, and they can advise the monarch, and the monarch can take their advice or not. But it had not been called for a long time because the king did not want it to be called and was successful in doing so.
- 5.5 But by 1789, the aristocrats were able to force a meeting of the three great estates and all of the representatives of the great, the three estates, meet. And in the first phase of the French Revolution, there's a complicated story here. Entire courses and books, of

course, just on the French Revolution. But I'm going to just simplify the story to three phases. And the first, the aristocrats dominate. They, in effect, bring the king to the discussion table. They collect all of the important voices in France, in one place in Paris, for discussion of what's going on in France in the day. And so there's many hundreds of delegates meeting in this very grand hall to discuss.

- 5.6 Now, very quickly, though, the aristocrats lose the initiative. And one of the interesting things about the France Revolution is it stops being so much a class-based movement and turns into an ideological movement. And so, what was interesting is that many of the aristocrats were actually Enlightenment individuals. They were not old-fashioned conservatives in the French style. They were sympathetic to Enlightenment ideals, so they were actually pro-reason, pro-individual, pro-liberty, and so on. And they, in effect, defected, many of them, from their class, and joined what was now a liberal movement inside the Estates-General.
- 5.7 Many members of the clergy were in favor of the more enlightened approach to religion, a more enlightened approach. So they did not vote with and take the side of what we would expect to be the traditional hierarchical church interests. They became, and many of the commons, were also liberal. And so there was then an ideological faction of liberals who came to dominate. And then the move became away from, "Here we have some grievances against the king, and can you, your majesty, please reform in these particular ways to a much more ambitious and aggressive program?"
- 5.8 It's during this liberal phase of the French Revolution that the famous Declaration of the Rights of Man and the Citizen is written. And notice this notion of the rights of man, a very modern notion, that we are not people who have privileges who might be granted by the king. Instead, there are human rights, and they are universal rights, not special rights and privileges for different parts of French society and so forth. Very Enlightenment. And the citizen—that's an important political concept. We are not a subject to the king. We are a citizen, and that is a very significant, normative political concept. What is your relationship to the government? Are you a subject to it, or are you a citizen of it? And that has important differences.
- 5.9 The first draft of this declaration was written by Lafayette, who was a liberal. He was a member of the aristocratic class, but he has also come to be known as hero of two worlds. If you know your American history, you know that Lafayette had military experience as a young man in France. But it was inspired by the American Revolution and its ideals, largely Lockean ideals. Went across and worked with George Washington on the military campaigns and the eventual successful prosecution of the American Revolution, then returned to France, wanting to bring many of those American revolutionary successful ideas and techniques to the French situation.
- 5.10 It's also the same time where we have what we might call the first feminism articulating itself. The idea that all human beings have reason, all human beings can be self responsible, all human beings should be free and equal. And if we then look at women,

we say, well, all of those things then should apply to women—and increasingly, people willing to extend that Enlightenment understanding to women as well. So, Olympe de Gouges, Frenchwoman, articulated a document, 1791, very early form of feminism. But notice the themes here. "Woman is born free." So freedom is the natural human birthright and extends to women. "And remains equal to man in rights." So all of these liberty rights, and they are equal, to be distributed and recognized for men and women. Any social distinctions may be based only on common utility, but within this free and equal rights-based system.

5.11 "The purpose of all political association is the preservation of the natural and imprescriptible rights of woman and man." Right. See, these are natural rights. Not only are they not privileges endowed by the monarchy, they are not supernatural. They are part of us as human beings in this world. Among these rights are "liberty, property, security, and especially, resistance to oppression." So what, in a nutshell, we have is a very liberal Enlightenment phase of the French Revolution. What then, not too quickly happens, though, is the liberals get outmaneuvered by a group that came to be known as the Jacobins. And the Jacobins have a very different agenda, a very different ideology, a very different understanding of what society should be, and a willingness to use very different strategic political tactics.

5.12 Now, who are these Jacobins? Well, the most famous of them are Maximilien Robespierre, also younger guy, Saint-Just, actually in his early twenties, Danton, and Marat. That's a picture of them. And it is they who then turn the Revolution into what came to be known as the Reign of Terror. And this is the era of the guillotine, mass arrests, mass torture, mass executions of anybody who disagrees with the politics of the Jacobins and a new kind of dictatorial regime. So it goes from an aristocratic reform movement to a liberal Enlightenment movement to some form of terrible, self-destructive Reign of Terror. Now, who were the Jacobins? And we're in a philosophy course, not a French history course. They were all disciples of Jean-Jacques Rousseau, self-descriptively so.

5.13 So, for example, Robespierre, in his own words: "I am imbued with Rousseau's doctrines. I live by Emile," which is an early 1760s work by Rousseau on how properly to raise and educate children. Very influential on French philosophy of education and educational practice. Georges Danton became politically active in his own words from his reading of Rousseau. Rousseau was the inspiration. Jean-Paul Marat, who had a skin condition, but he never bathed and apparently he stank, and any of the pictures of him at the assemblies and meetings of the three estates, always you see him, and then there's some many yards separating him from the next people because nobody wanted to sit near him. He stank so bad.

5.14 But this was not just a lack of personal hygiene. There was an ideology at work here. He took on his disheveled, unbathed appearance, in his own words, in order, quote, "to live simply and according to the precepts of Rousseau." There's something wrong with

civilization and all of these allegedly progressive habits that are being developed. We need to get back to simple, natural man, but a very different understanding of what simple, natural man is all about. Rousseau is so important that he had died before the Revolution began, but his funeral urn was brought into a grand procession toward the latter part of the French Revolution to Paris, and still to this day in the Pantheon, in the center of Paris. And you can go and visit Rousseau's urn.

- 5.15** So who is this Jean-Jacques Rousseau? Basically, what I want to suggest is, if you take every notion from Locke, Descartes, Bacon, working backward, and including the scientists, and including Voltaire, you made a list of all of those doctrines that the Enlightenment thinkers come to believe in, Rousseau is opposed to every single one of those. That he thinks they are all wrong, false, misguided, to be rejected. But the important thing is that he is not simply a conservative, relativizing again that notion to the 1700s French notion. He's not saying, "We just need to go back to the good old days of French philosophy, French culture, and so on." He is a modern, but he has a very different idea of what modernity should consist in and the direction it should go. And it's not this Enlightenment notion. So he is a Counter-Enlightenment thinker.
- 5.16** Now, some excerpted quotations here. The man wrote voluminously. He was a very clear writer, a very provocative writer, which is essential if one is going to make one's writing career successfully in France. But "on the arrogance of the Enlightenment thinkers, they destroy and trample underfoot all that men revere, steal from the suffering, the consolation they derive from religion, and take away the only force that restrains the passions of the rich and the powerful." So in one sense, you might say, he sounds like a conservative, in this sense. He says, "People need religion, and these Enlightenment thinkers are undermining religion in some way." He is sounding like someone who thinks the rich and powerful are avarice-driven and controlling them, and religion is the only thing, in some ways, that can stop the rich and powerful from doing so.
- 5.17** We know that the Enlightenment thinkers are talking about progress and civilization in the arts and the sciences and medicine and technology and so forth. And what we find in Rousseau is a cynical notion that politics is always about someone trying to control other people. And if it's not the old-fashioned, traditional politics, it's a new-fashioned kind of politics, in that what we call this Enlightenment doctrine is a cover for a new kind of authoritarianism that's coming along. "Princes always view with pleasure the spread among their subjects of a taste for the arts. The sciences, letters, and arts cover with garlands of flowers the iron chains that bind them, stifle in them the feeling of that original liberty for which they seem to have been born, make them love their slavery, and turn them into what is called a civilized people." Civilization is another name for slavery. It's a mask for slavery. So the same bondage is going to be in place, but now we're going to give you some nice theater and some nice technological doodads to distract you from what really is just a new form of slavery.

- 5.18** Censorship. This idea of the Enlightenment, two centuries now campaign against censorship in all forms, for liberty of the press, freedom of thought. Rousseau thinks censorship is a terrible idea. The printing press should be abolished. This is in a letter, meant to be a public letter, written to D'Alembert, one of the co-editors of the Encyclopedia project. "Consider the awful disorders printing has already caused in Europe. And judging by the future, by the progress that this evil makes day by day, one can easily predict that sovereigns will not delay in taking as many pains to banish this terrible art from their states as they once took to establish it." Freedom of the press. Many printing presses available to anybody to publish whatever. No, we need to have controls over the press and who can publish what.
- 5.19** And again, this sounds like just an old-fashioned conservative notion, but Rousseau is going to want the censorship on behalf of a different ideology. This is going to include the theater, painting, and sculpture. "Hasten to tear down these amphitheaters, break these marble statues, burn these paintings, chase out these slaves who subjugate you and whose fatal arts corrupt you." So the art and civilization and all of those pretty pictures and so forth, they are artificial. They're dehumanizing. They're a distraction. What do we want to replace that with? Not yet, but censorship, for sure.
- 5.20** Reason. That valorized faculty of the Enlightenment is a terrible faculty. "Reason is what engenders egocentrism, and reflection strengthens it." I have my mind. I have my own ideas. And to hell with the rest of you, so to speak. You're on your own business. It separates humans from each other, doesn't enable them or lead them to think that, communally or collectively, they are involved in each other's beliefs and practices and so forth. "Reason is what turns man in upon himself. Reason is what separates him from all that troubles him and afflicts him. Philosophy is what isolates him and moves him to say, in secret, at the sight of a suffering man, 'Perish, if you will. I am safe and sound.'" Philosophers distance themselves from the hurly-burly, and they ignore the real suffering of people that goes on as long as they have a nice book to read.
- 5.21** On this entire liberalism and capitalism, or nascent capitalism, coming into existence in the 1700s, and its valorization of property rights: "The first person who, having enclosed a plot of land, took it into his head to say, 'This is mine,' and found people simple enough to believe him, was the true founder of civil society." Now, that's interesting. So he is agreeing that the foundation of civilization is respect for property rights. And that, of course, is what the liberals and the capitalists are arguing. And then, Rousseau rhetorically loves to turn that into its opposite. "What crimes, wars, murders, what miseries and horrors would the human race have been spared, had someone pulled up the stakes or filled in the ditch," or whatever the property line marking was, "and cried out to his fellow men, 'Do not listen to this impostor. You are lost if you forget' —and now we start to get an indication of the positive replacement doctrine —'the fruits of the earth belong to all, and the earth to no one.'"

- 5.22 So what we have then is a suggestion that it's not that property belongs according to class membership. In pure monarchy, the king owns all of the property, and may delegate, by privileges to various aristocrats and nobles, the use of that property. But he can revoke that if he chooses. That conception of property, no. Or the liberal capitalist notion of property. You make something, you own it. Or you make some money, and you buy some property from somebody else, you own it. And as a matter of individual right, you can control your own property, and everybody is responsible for their own property. That notion of property is also suspect. So he's not a conservative, he is not a liberal. He is, as this suggests here, everything belongs to everyone. It's a communal possession. And so we have a different political direction that we are going to go here.
- 5.23 We have attacked reason. Well, if we don't think that human beings are fundamentally, empirically rational, or rationalistically rational, how do we come to form our core beliefs and motivate ourselves and decide what our core values are going to be? And Rousseau is going to be an advocate of feeling and faith. "I have suffered too much in this life." And notice, this is a letter to Voltaire, who was deistic and soft on religion. "I have suffered too much in this life not to look forward to another. The subtleties of metaphysics may increase my sorrows, but they cannot shake my faith in the immortality of the soul." So we have all of these rational investigations of the arguments for and against the existence of God, and many of those seem to lead in an agnostic or atheistic direction.
- 5.24 Rousseau says, "You're not going to get me there by reason. I have a belief in the immortality of the soul. All of these modern sciences, more physicalistic, more materialistic, seem to be undercutting the idea that there is such a thing. Not going to get me there by asking me to read up on the science. I feel it, I believe it, I desire it, I hope for it. I will defend it with my last breath." So, very different epistemology being proffered here as well. Now, this was in a context of a devastating earthquake that had occurred in 1755 in Lisbon. And in the short case of just a couple of short hours, 50 or 60,000 people were just instantly killed. And this, of course, anytime a natural disaster, or maybe it's a supernatural disaster, any sort of disaster happens like that —why would a good God let this happen? All of the women and the children and innocent people who were just killed in this earthquake.
- 5.25 If there really is a wise, benevolent, good God looking out for all of us, how can terrible things like this happen? And so that traditional argument against the existence of a certain conception of God, immediately that debate is rekindled. And Voltaire is saying, "Yeah, well, what about Lisbon earthquake?" And Voltaire is saying, sorry, Rousseau is saying, "Well, you're not going to change my mind by appealing to evidence and facts and taking me down in that direction." This is from Emile. "I believe that the world is governed by a wise and most powerful will. I see it, or rather, I feel it. I see God

everywhere in his works. In vain do you argue this point with me. I feel it, and it is this feeling that speaks more, to me more forcibly, than any reason could dispute it."

5.26 All right, so anti-Enlightenment on religion, anti-Enlightenment on reason, anti-Enlightenment on liberal property rights. Rousseau also, though, is a political philosopher, and he wrote much on what the new modern states should look like. And it's not just to go back to feudalism. It's not certainly to go in any sort of liberal, capitalist, modernist direction. But what we will need is a founder, and there will be a revolution. And after that revolution, the founder will create a new state, and we get some very strong indications of what that new state will look like. "Whoever dares undertake to establish a people's institution must feel himself capable of changing, as it were, human nature." And I'll pause on the quotation here.

5.27 What is human nature? And now, immediately, we're into a philosophical debate. Are human beings merely matter in motion, mechanical devices to be pushed around by physical and chemical forces? Are they a body that has a soul implanted, a dualistic creature? Are we in control of our minds and our bodies, or are we pushed around by forces beyond our control, free will and determinism? Inside our bodies, we have a rational capacity and an emotional capacity. What's the relationship between our reason and our emotion? Is there such a thing as human nature that is fixed? And that maybe we can do some alterations on the surface here and there, but there is a core human nature that is unchangeable across time, and you can't change human nature. So what we need to do is adapt our lives and social institutions to this unchanging human nature. Or is human nature not merely cognitively tabula rasa, not merely morally tabula rasa, more plastic and flexible, to be manipulated and transformed, perhaps at will, in a radically new direction?

5.28 And we find in Rousseau a very strong tabula rasa, all the way down notion, that what we call all of the variations and differences among individuals and societies are entirely artificial. And if we only change the institutions in a proper direction, we can change that underlying substrate that we call human nature in a much different direction. So the idea that we're all belonging to a certain class because we were born into it, and maybe that class hierarchy is ordained by God, or it's traditional? No. The idea that we are all rational and individualistic and self-controlling and living in a market-oriented society? All of that is conditioned into us. We should be able to change all of that. That's what's signaled here.

5.29 And what Rousseau wants us to do—this is on his Social Contract book of 1762 —is suggest that what we should do is take current individualistic man, that the Enlightenment is creating, "transforming each individual, who by himself is a complete and solitary whole, into part of a larger whole, from which the individual receives his life and his being." We're part of a larger communal whole. We're not naturally individuals. We become individuals only if that larger community pushes us in an individualistic direction. But we don't have to do that. "He has to take from man his

own powers and give him, in exchange, alien powers which he cannot employ without the help of other men." This notion of self-responsibility, intellectually, morally, economically, politically, that you are an agency individual—we need to take all of that away and reconstitute human nature in a way such that we all take from each other, depend upon each other, and only do things in concert with others.

- 5.30** The Social Contract. This new modern social contract, when, after the Revolution, we create this new society, we come together and we consent to —this is also from the Social Contract. "Each of us coalesces with all. In this each of us puts in common his person, his whole power, under the supreme direction of society's leaders. When we join the new society, the individual particularity of each contracting party is surrendered to a new moral and collective body which has its own life, self, body, and will." There is a collective being, a collective community, a collective society that is real, and we merge ourselves into it.
- 5.31** Now, of course, a lot of people are believers in old conservative religion, that they have an immortal soul, or they are Enlightenment liberals, and they think that they are autonomous agents. Those people also need to be dealt with. So, "the legislator must have a recourse to an authority capable of constraining without violence. This is what in all ages compelled the fathers of nations to have recourse to divine intervention and credit the gods with their own wisdom, in order that the people, submitting to the laws of the state as to those of nature, might obey freely and bear with docility the yoke of the public good." Now, that complicated language comes down to saying, "If we want people to go along with this new regime, religion is a useful tool." And that's why, in political history, the political use of religion has been so common. And so Rousseau is endorsing the idea that church and state, religion and politics, will be integrated, in direct contrast to the Enlightenment notion of the separation of church and state. Religion is a politically useful tool, and the new legislators need to have access to it.
- 5.32** Now, religion is a tool that we will use to try to get people voluntarily to go along. If they believe religiously, and we have a more communal, authoritarian religion that they adopt that themselves, they will go along, and we won't need to use violence. But what about people who don't? "While the state can compel no one to believe," that Lockean point, we can't actually make people believe anything, "it can banish not for impiety, but as an antisocial being." So we can banish some people who do not get with the new contract. "Being incapable of truly loving the laws and justice, and of sacrificing, if needed, his life to his duty. But if there is anyone, after publicly recognizing these dogmas," that's the principles of religion as endorsed by the statement. If someone understands what they are, refuses to recognize them, "behaves as if he does not believe them, let him be punished by death." So, death penalty for disbelieving in the new state religion.
- 5.33** Now, Rousseau was invited to draft a constitution for Corsica, which was various times trying to become independent from France. And just as Jefferson was invited to write

the first draft of the Declaration of Independence. And this is what he wrote, one of the excerpts. "I joined myself"—this is what it will be to join the Corsican nation—"body, goods, will, and all my powers to the Corsican nation, granting her ownership of me, of myself and all who depend upon me." This again, politically, is the direct opposite of an Enlightenment Declaration of Independence notion of rights to life, individually, to life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness. So what we'd find, of course, is Rousseau is advocating religion. He's advocating a kind of authoritarianism, but it's not a conservative, old-fashioned feudal authoritarianism. It's going to be communalist, collectivist, small "S" socialist.

5.34 And what we find is, this is the birth of that new form of modern ideology here in France. And the point being that he's not a conservative, even though he is in favor of a kind of authoritarianism and a kind of religion, is that the traditional conservatives in France at the time, the established church, the Catholics, objected to Rousseau all the way through—not all the way through, but substantially all the way through—and regularly censored his works. All right, so that's an answer to that question. First of the major Counter-Enlightenment figures, but revered, extraordinarily influential in France during the course of his lifetime.

5.35 Now I want to make a connection now to another, what I'm going to call Counter-Enlightenment, figure. And this is a Scotsman named David Hume. And Hume and Rousseau met each other for the first time in Paris and they traveled together to England. Hume is very gregarious, nice guy, arranged for some lodging for Rousseau. They ended up falling out with each other. Rousseau was a very prickly guy, very hard to get along with in a lot of different ways. But nonetheless, I want to introduce Hume as a Counter-Enlightenment correlate to Rousseau. What we find in Rousseau is, of course, he has some epistemological themes about feeling and faith and so forth. But really, his value added to the Counter-Enlightenment is on moral issues, social issues, political issues.

5.36 The Counter-Enlightenment, with respect to epistemological and metaphysical issues, Hume is the most important person to notice. The idea that we live in a natural world, as the Enlightenment thinkers were arguing, that it's cause and effect, that we have an autonomous, rational capacity that can come to know it, and that we can do all of the science to articulate the laws of cause and effect, and formulate them in scientific principles. All of the optimism that comes out of that, metaphysics and epistemology, Hume is the most important philosopher to subvert that, undercut that, in the middle part of the 1700s. So let's turn to now David Hume.

5.37 Now I want to give an overview because some of this is very, very technical, and we're just going to hit a few highlights. Hume is an empiricist, so he's in that Baconian, Lockean tradition. He's going to reject all of the rationalism that comes out of the more Descartes tradition, that says we can ignore the senses, ignore the external world, turn inwards to our mind, take stock of what ideas happen to be inside our minds, and then,

rationalistically and logically, deduce various things from the internal. Hume is an empiricist, but he is a sensationalist. And that is the technical term in philosophy to say that the starting point of knowledge is the senses. But the senses give us discrete sensations of heat, color, texture, sound. He also then is, as we then say, well, human beings don't just become aware of discrete sensory inputs. We are aware of stable perceptual or stable objects that are moving around in the world.

- 5.38 We have all of those sensations integrated into these percepts. And then on the basis of that, we go on to form abstractions. So, you know, if I look at this gentleman here, I can, I can see various dots of color and so forth on his clothes, but it gets integrated into a shirt; it gets integrated into a human being. And then 5 seconds later, I come back and I look again and I see it's the same human being who has persisted across time. And I go on to formulate a concept that he is a human being, and you're a human being, and all of you here are human beings, out of this general principle of humanity, this high abstraction. And then on the basis of that, I take all of these abstractions and start putting them together into theories and broader principles about the world, how the world works.
- 5.39 What Hume wants to argue is, we have these sensations, and they do get associated, and we do have these things that we call abstractions, but they're not really abstractions. Our concepts are just names for collections of sensations that we happen to have grouped together. And there's not really anything out there in nature that forces us to group them the way they do it. It's a more subjective thing. And this position, again, has a long history of debate in philosophy, but it's called nominalism. And it's against the idea that there are such things as genuine abstractions formed in the human mind, or real generalizations out there in the objective world. So, against what we sometimes call conceptualism or any sort of realism with respect to abstractions, that's the nominalism.
- 5.40 Another important concept is then this notion of meaning. And what Hume is going to emphasize is, a lot of times when we're doing philosophy, we don't even know what we're talking about. We just have these names that have been floating around for these big, wifty, vaguely defined notions. If we're going to be serious empiricists, anytime we use a name, a nomen, we have to be able to specify what sensations give rise to that idea or that name, that word that we are using. So there's a clarity point here. We want to define our terms, but we define our terms in an empiricist fashion by going back to the observable facts. And the observable facts are always going to be the sensations that give rise to them. And you're going to be very ruthless about that. If you're not able to do that, you do not know what you are talking about. You are just issuing gibberish, meaningless words, and we are not going to have any truck with that.
- 5.41 And that is the next point. But what we're going to then do is find, when we try to apply this empiricist criterion of meaning with the sensationalism and the nominalism, that we can't do it. We can't find a way to make meaningful many of the basic concepts that

we use, not only in our everyday life, but in scientific thinking. So we're not going to be able to make sense of this idea that there are stable entities or things out in the world, that there is such a thing as cause and effect, or that we can inductively generalize to principles, or even that we can say there's an external world out there, or that I have a self that persists across time, much less the idea that there is a God of some sort out there. Hume is, by ruthless application of this form of empiricism, going to end up in a very strongly skeptical place.

5.42 And why this is going to be important is that Hume is seen as a development of empiricism that started off very optimistically with Bacon and Locke. But by the time we get to the middle part of the 1700s, ends up in a kind of very skeptical position. What then about empiricism? And then, at the same time, the more rationalistic tradition, when we were looking at Descartes—this is a little sidebar here, just for a moment, that says we're not going to be empirical. We're going to ground our reason in a prior certainty of consciousness and deduce our way to various general principles. I don't know how impressed you are by Descartes' argument for the existence of God, but as the generations after Descartes progress, they become increasingly skeptical about the rationalistic tradition, such that, by the time we get to the height of the Enlightenment, much of the aspiration of the Enlightenment has been undercut by the philosophers themselves. So Hume is important on this point here.

5.43 Now let's go to the text. I'm going to take this as an early work by David Hume, A Treatise of Human Nature. And in it he goes through metaphysical issues, epistemological issues, what human nature is, moral issues. And we have a fairly comprehensive understanding of philosophy. And like many modern philosophers who are well read, he is going to point out that philosophy seems to be in just a terrible state, just arguing about everybody, people talking past each other, flabby arguments. And things are overall pretty bad. So this is what we have as well. We have principles that are just taken on trust, "consequences lamely deduced from them." There's a "want of coherence in the parts, and of evidence in the whole. These are everywhere met with systems of the most eminent philosophers." So if you're a smart person, you can recognize all of these symptoms, even in the best philosophers of the early Enlightenment time here. So, nothing but the most determined skepticism. That concept is introduced here.

5.44 Now, skepticism can mean, in a rough and ready way, a particular judgment. You know, I'm skeptical about this or that claim that people are making. Philosophically, skepticism is a position that is more comprehensively negative about any claim, or you make a generalization about any belief in knowledge that is ungrounded, that is, in fact, not knowable. So all of the success concepts in epistemology—knowledge, truth, certainty—that we will have negative arguments developed against those such that we have to disbelieve that any of those are possible. And when you reach that position, that is skepticism. Now we find commitment to empiricism. If we are going to talk

about knowledge, well, you know, appealing to mystical insights and revelations and old texts, and just what these guys wearing fancy robes are telling you you're supposed to believe, none of those are reliable sources of knowledge. We start with the senses.

5.45 "An impression first strikes upon the senses, and makes us perceive heat or cold, thirst or hunger, pleasure or pain." These are things that we first are aware of. These are the entryway to knowledge, and these are all sensations right upon the body. Then we have this memory faculty. These impressions are stored in us, in our minds in some way. A copy of those is taken by the mind. So now we have sensation and memory, and we know where all of those things come from. Sometimes, though, we also, as human beings, seem to have this capacity. "This idea of pleasure or pain, when it returns upon the soul, I remember it produces the new impressions of desire, aversion, hope, and fear, which may properly be called impressions of reflection, because derived from it." So I have impressions. I have my memories of various impressions, and then I have the capacity sometimes to recall these impressions and reflect upon them and think about them and do various things with them.

5.46 And so now we have three categories of things, and we know what we're talking about, and we can tie all of them back to original impressions. But when we start talking about, say, I see a particular person, that person, that person, that person, that person, all of which are particular collections of in sections. What about that move where I go from all those particular sections and I say, well, then, there I have this idea of humanity in the abstract, humanity in general, and the idea that somehow I have this new thing in my mind that is not a memory of any particular individual, and it's not an impression of any particular individual. We talk about these things. Are they real or not? And Hume is going to argue they are not, not really abstract.

5.47 Berkeley, an earlier empiricist: "All general ideas are nothing but particular ones, annexed to a term which gives them a more extensive signification. Now, since all ideas are derived from impressions, and are nothing but copies and representations of them, whatever is true of the one must be acknowledged concerning the other. Impressions and ideas differ only in their strength and vivacity." That, then, is to say, there are no such things as abstractions. Or sometimes we use the concept of essences that are out there in the world, and our mind can grab these general essences. No, these things really just are copies of impressions that are particular—particular memories, particular impressions that we have gathered together in a group and slapped a label on them. It's just a name attached to a collection of particulars. Not really a generalization, not really an abstraction.

5.48 So what then follows is, if we are going to be serious about getting genuine knowledge, and we're going to start talking about theories and narratives and big comprehensive stories about the way the world works and so on, if we're going to make any progress, we have to be able to take all of those and reduce them, or explain them, in terms of what we know is in fact real—impressions, memories of impressions, and collections of

impressions with a name attached to them. And it was as a methodological point that we get too quickly to the question of, is a position true or false? Someone says something and my reaction is, "I don't believe that, or I think that's wrong." And we argue about whether something is true or not. And Hume wants to insist that, methodologically, the first question we should always ask is, "Do we know what we are talking about?"

- 5.49** Take each of the important terms in that and see if you can trace that back to the impressions. If you can't, stop the conversation right there because it's going to take you nowhere. It's just going to be words that without any empirical reference, and that's a big problem in philosophy. So let's try to do that and take some of the important concepts that we want to believe are foundational to our understanding of the world and can give rise to a more sophisticated scientific project. So let's take the idea of cause and effect, the idea that things are out in the world, that they are what they are, and they act a certain way according to their nature, or that they interact with each other in a certain way. And as a result of that, there are causal patterns that develop this fundamental thing.
- 5.50** So we have this notion of cause and effect. And we want to get to the point where we say, "Here is this thing." And then later in time, say, "This thing." And we want to say, "This thing caused this thing to occur." And then, maybe another time, I see something that's similar to this original thing over here. I have an impression of this thing. Now I have an impression of this thing, and this was after. So I want to say, "This caused this thing over here to occur." And then maybe I want to take this set of observations and that initial set of observations and then go more generally. There's a more general principle of cause and effect at work.
- 5.51** Now, Hume says, "Well, that's how this works." Let's look very closely, though. So I see this; this thing happens; and I have my impressions. So I'm looking at it. I observe all the particular things. And then time passes. I see this thing, and I see those collection of impressions. So, to say "this is" and "this is," and I slap a name to each of those. That makes sense. But then I want to say this other thing. "This caused that." Well, what am I looking at that's this cause thing? What's the impression of the cause? And he wants to say, "You don't see that." You don't have an impression of a cause. I have an impression of, say, I don't know. Here is a fire burning. And I put my hand closer to the fire, and my hand feels hot. And I say, "The fire caused my hand to feel hot." Well, I can see the fire and I can feel the hotness. But where's the cause thing? That fire caused heat? I don't have an impression of causation. There's no little metaphysical flag that pops up, that I can say, "Oh, this thing is identifying itself as the cause of this other thing that happens in the future."
- 5.52** It's not a notion that is based on impressions. In some sense, we are making this association, but we're subjectively adding this association just because certain things happen to be associated with each other in our perceptual field. But the idea that they

are causally associated, we're not observing that. And so we're going to need to be skeptical about that. "We always conclude there is some secret cause." Well, you can't see the cause, but it's there, right? Some hidden causation. Now we're starting to talk like we believe in magic or something. "The same reasoning extends to identity." So, pick over here for a second. So I see you, I look at you, and I have impressions of you, and they go into my memory, and I turn away, and time passes, and I look back over here, and I look again, and I have certain impressions. And so in my mind, I had one collection of impressions; I have another collection of impressions. And both of those are now in my memory. And I say, "It's the same person."

5.53 Well, where's this sameness? Because when I wasn't looking at her, I wasn't getting any impressions of any sort of continuity. And when I look back, I just have a new set of impressions. I don't have any flag, metaphysically, that pops up and says, "Identity, sameness, persistence through time." What's the meaning of those things, if all of our knowledge is based on impressions? So the identity of things across time, cause and effect, which is based on the concept of identity, we need to be skeptical about those things.

5.54 Induction, where we say, this occurred, this occurred, this occurred, and it occurred in the same way, so we want to go to a more general principle—all things occur a certain way. Suppose I take a sample of copper, and I put it in a laboratory setting, and I subject it to heat, and I'm just making this number up, and I say, this piece of copper melted when the thermostat said, say, 1,000 degrees Fahrenheit. So I have all of those impressions in that particular thing, and then I do it again. I take another piece of copper, and I suppose this copper is identical to that kind of copper, and I have this general principle—same cause, same effect. Well, I'm adding all of those things as well. But I melt this piece of copper and I find that it also melts at 1,000 degrees Fahrenheit. And maybe I do it 3, 4, 5, 6 different times. And then I go to this great generalization. All copper melts at 1,000 degrees Fahrenheit.

5.55 All copper? Do you have an impression of all copper? All of the copper that's still in the earth, all of the copper that you have never seen? These great whopping odd—they're not based on impressions, they're based on just some sort of associations and new packagings that we are adding ourselves to. So again, we're going to reach a skeptical conclusion with respect to causation.

5.56 What about the external world, this idea that, even when I'm not looking, the world goes on? So, yes, I am aware of the world, I'm aware of this wall, this floor, this apparatus. So I have impressions of all of that. So the world exists as I am aware of it. And then, I suppose, I close my eyes, stop up my ears, fall into a coma, and I say, in small, oh, objectivist fashion, "The world exists objectively." It's not just a projection of my subjective mind. And even when I'm not looking at it, or even when I'm not aware of it, it still exists. But let's take this empiricist criterion of meaning. What does it mean to talk about something that exists when you are having no impressions of it? You don't

have impressions of things when you're not having impressions of them. So can I really know that there is an external world when I am not having any impressions of it?

- 5.57** Going inward, Descartes, for example, focusing on his self and the stock of knowledge that is within his self. And the idea that "I have this idea, I have that idea, I have these other ideas, and I analyze them." And underlying all of those ideas is this "I", this entity, or this thing that is real and also that persists across time, that is having all of these ideas or generating all of these ideas. What is this "I"? I say, well, if we know what we're talking about when we're talking about the "I", we have to have an impression of it, right? Now, we don't see it with our eyes or hear it with our ears, but maybe there's like an internal sense, where I look inward or I sense somehow this "I", this self.
- 5.58** Well, what is this impression? What would it look like? Or what would it appear like? Whatever language we need to use right here. And then, as Hume goes on to say, well, when I look inward, I see all of the impressions. I see all the memories of the impressions, and I see all of the associated impressions that I'm putting together. But I take all of those impressions away, and I say, well, it's not that impression. It's the thing that has those impressions. But I never catch that thing. I never detect that thing. I don't have an impression of an "I" apart from all of the impressions. So maybe, really, there is no "I" or, at least, I don't have a meaningful concept of an "I" or a self. There is just all of these impressions that are going on.
- 5.59** Now, this, metaphysically, is obviously devastating to not only the Enlightenment project, but many philosophical projects that want to say there is a reality out there. It is what it is. It's subject to certain kinds of causal principles. I am an entity myself. I have a particular nature, and our capacity then, on the basis of that, to generalize to certain kinds of causal principles and to go on to do inductive generalizations about the world as a whole and entire classes of things—all of that is subject to an epistemological skepticism and a kind of dead end for the empiricists' project by the 1750s.
- 5.60** Now, what about moral principles? Hume takes up this issue about ethics, and not so much the question of what's right or wrong, but where do we get our morals from? And we might say, well, traditionally we get them from God, or we get them from our society, or we might then say, "I think for myself and I generalize certain principles," and so on. If I'm a rational person, I'm going to commit to understanding that I need to be a certain kind of person and interact with people a certain way if good things are going to happen, and so on. And Hume, as a good philosopher, then takes up this question of metaethics. That is to say, just take whatever your ethics are, or the issues of ethics in particular, and step back and say, "Where do we get this ethics from in the first place? What's the grounding, or the metaphysics, of ethics?"
- 5.61** And the question about the relationship between moral principle and reason, which is the big question for the Enlightenment, if we are not going to take ethics as supernatural endowments or commandments that come upon high that we are just

supposed to obey, if we are rational, self-legislating , autonomous beings, how are we going to get our ethics off the ground? Any Enlightenment answer is, well, somehow we have to be able to rationally generate and argue for these principles. Going to argue there is no way to get moral principles from reason, moral distinctions not derived from reason.

5.62 He has this very famous argument that now comes down to us as the "is-ought" problem, or another variation is the dichotomy between facts and values. And you look at the semantics of fact language, what we sometimes call descriptive language. This is the way things are. This is true. This is true. This is true. I am just making a claim about the way the world is, without passing evaluative judgments with it. Water is wet, grass is green, the sky is up there, and so on. There's all those kinds of statements. But we also have moral statements. And moral statements aren't necessarily factual statements because we want them to say, "This is how things ought to be." At the same time, we recognize it's not necessarily how they are. But at the same time, we want to say that our ought statements about normativity and how things ought to be, and the difference between good and bad, are somehow tied to facts about the world, if they are going to be rationally grounded. So how do we make the connection between descriptive, perhaps factual, statements about the way the world is and all of these normative, ethical statements about the way the world ought to be?

5.63 And Hume wants to argue, paying close attention, that very often people make a slippery, too-fast move from "is" statements to "ought" statements. They're describing human nature, they're describing facts about the world, and then all of a sudden they're talking about how things ought to be, like they've made a logical inference. And one of the things we know about deduction is that you can't have something in your conclusion that's not contained in the premise, that what you're trying to do in deductive reasoning is unpack and make explicit information that is already contained in your premises. And as a matter of logic, if there are no ought statements or ought concepts in your premises, you should not have any of those in your conclusion. And Hume's criticism is precisely going to be that that's what too many people do. They are smuggling in, and he's going to call them on that.

5.64 "In every system of morality which I have hitherto met with, I have always remarked that the author proceeds for some time in the ordinary way of reasoning and establishes the being of a God or makes observations concerning human affairs; when of a sudden I am surprised to find that instead of the usual copulations of propositions, is and is not, I meet with no proposition that is not connected with an ought or an ought not." So suddenly I'm moving from is statements and is not statements, to ought and ought not statements. So there's been a change here. "For as this ought, or ought not, expresses some new relation or affirmation, it is necessary that it should be observed." When I say, "This ought to be," if the ought is to be meaningful, it has to be based in some impression, and the fact statements are based on fact.

- 5.65 But when I say that this is good, what am I looking at? There's no little metaphysical flag that pops up and says goodness. I can see, say, arbitrarily, it is yellow, it is round, it seems to be giving off heat. It is good. Not based in impressions, not meaningful. Also not rationally derivable from ought statements, or is statements, rather, to speak. So, in another work, later published posthumously, Hume takes all of the arguments for the existence of God and argues against them. They don't work. So we also can't know the existence of God. So we can't know abstractions. We can't know identity. We can't know cause and effect. We can't know the self. We can't know, rationally, any moral principles. We have one suggestion. Why do we do this? And it's a suggestion that there's nothing objective in our awareness of reality that's giving rise to all of these notions. Instead, there's this one phrase that he uses.
- 5.66 "There is a general force, which commonly prevails," an interior type of force, and that's where we're just subjectively associating things in various ways. Now, if this is the case, we do all of this philosophy, this Humean philosophy, and we reach dead end after dead end—what is the point of philosophy? "This skeptical doubt is a malady. It's a sickness which can never be radically cured." There is no way Hume sees out of skepticism. If you're a rational person, you have to be a skeptic about all of these things. The only solution is to try to forget it, just get away from philosophy. "Carelessness and inattention alone can afford us any remedy." So, reason, it seems, can't get rid of these clouds from these skeptical doubts and so forth. And so what we really ought to do, then, is not try to do philosophy, certainly not try to do rational philosophy. It's just going to lead us into cold skepticism. Instead, just rely on, the way he puts it here is, natural feelings, and get back to natural life. Don't be overly concerned with philosophical light. Be merry, hang out with your friends, and so forth.
- 5.67 And then one more claim here about the relationship between reason and passions. And he wants to say, if you have any sort of realistic understanding of what human nature is, that's what we do anyway. The Enlightenment philosophers want to talk about people being rational and self-governing and so forth, but in fact, we're all driven by our passions, by our feelings. And in this remarkable phrase, he says, "Reason is and ought only to be the slave of the passions."
- 5.68 All right, so what we have found then is, as the Enlightenment is reaching its heights of aspiration and social acceptance and transforming institutions, there is a countermovement, called the Counter-Enlightenment, that is taking up all of the claims and aspirations of the Enlightenment and subjecting them to skeptical undercutting or arguing that those are taking humans in the wrong direction, and proposing a counter-agenda, a counter-ideology, to all of those. So we have Hume's skepticism and his passionism, if we can coin that particular word, both opposed to the Enlightenment. Rousseau's political authoritarianism in a new form, a more communalistic form, also counter to the Enlightenment. And to take an assessment of the intellectual territory of the mid- to late-1700s, now we have a large number of Enlightenment intellectuals, a

growing number of Counter-Enlightenment intellectuals, but we should also remember there always are conservative intellectuals, who want to argue that the new ways of thinking and doing are taking us in a wrong direction.

5.69 And so, as the Enlightenment grows in power and prestige, there's also an articulate, or an increasingly more sophisticated articulation of conservative principles, that we need to revert to tradition. We need to not get rid of religion, that if we have reason without tradition, reason unmoored, it's just going to turn us into an intellectual and social chaos. It's too much for reason to do, and certainly reason, if it goes in an agnostic or actually starting in a deistic, then agnostic, then atheistic direction, it's going to take away the foundations for moral principles, the foundations for our political order, and we're going to be left with not only a chaos but a value void. And we then have a three-way debate between a reinvigorated set of intellectual conservatives, the Rousseauians and the Humeans, who are taking things in a Counter-Enlightenment direction, and those in favor of the Enlightenment.

5.70 Now, in transition, I want to suggest 1780. Hume has died recently. Rousseau has died recently. And this is Frederick the Great, switching further east. And our story of philosophy is going to go eastward into Germany next, suggesting, at the height of the Enlightenment, that the Berlin Academy of Sciences—this is a prestigious organization that sponsors an essay contest to get the best German thinking focused in a certain direction for a year with prizes and so on —aware of what's going on to the west, in France, in England, in Scotland, and all of these Enlightenment thinkers. But Germany is quite conservative at the time. Thinking about the Enlightenment principles, are you be aware of Counter-Enlightenment? But raising this, is it expedient to deceive the people?

5.71 This is interesting, because the Enlightenment philosophers, of course, all philosophers have said up until this point, we're interested in truth. And here we have a suggestion. Maybe truth is not expedient. The direction of modern thinking has been increasingly individualistic and rational, and believing that all people have these capacities, and so we can educate the people and trust the people to become more self-governing and progressive. A suggestion here that that politics is dangerous, that those of us who are in positions of authority can and should be willing not to see themselves as working for the people, but perhaps to deceive the people, maybe even for their own good. So the story is going to shift east, and in the next lecture, we will take up who I think is the most important philosopher of the last 220 years, Immanuel Kant.

Lecture 6: Awakening from the Dogmatic Slumber

At a glance — Awakening from the dogmatic slumber — Kant.

- 6.1 The phrase "dogmatic slumber" is from Immanuel Kant, who, depending on one's interpretation, is either the height of Enlightenment thinking or the serious beginning of the Counter-Enlightenment. And anyone's estimate, though, whatever side of that interpretive debate one is on, will agree, virtually everyone, that Kant is the greatest, most significant philosopher of the last two centuries, and a bit. Greatest is not necessarily a positive term. This is a stature term. You can't understand philosophy for the last two centuries without grappling with Kant.
- 6.2 I want to start with the year 1763, which is a key year in philosophical history, because, according to Kant, that's the year he read Rousseau. Jean-Jacques Rousseau. He was an established philosopher at that time, working in fairly conventional ways. But he said Rousseau shocked him, awakened him, in a certain way. "I despised the people, who know nothing." This is before I read Rousseau. "Rousseau corrected me in this. This blinding prejudice disappeared. I learned to honor man," according to the precepts of Rousseau.
- 6.3 It's also the year that Kant read Hume, and on metaphysical and epistemological issues. A great shock. "I openly confess the suggestion of David Hume was the very thing which, many years ago, first interrupted my dogmatic slumber and gave my investigations in the field of speculative philosophy quite a new direction." Now, this phrase, dogmatic slumber, is to say, in effect, he's been sleeping or going through the motions, philosophically speaking. And it was a dogmatic slumber, which is to say, he was doing philosophy in the conventional way, according to the traditions that had come down, working happily within those traditions. But Rousseau shocked him, Hume shocked him, and he realized he needed to do something different. And the Kantian revolution in philosophy is going to be the result of that.
- 6.4 Now, this is 1763. Kant's most important work is the Critique of Pure Reason, which was published in 1781, and it came out in a second edition in 1787. But from 1763 to 1781, if you do the math, that's 18 years of thinking and rethinking and writing what will turn into a landmark work in modern philosophy, the Critique of Pure Reason. Now, from David Hume, we have this shattered universe. If our project is to save the Enlightenment or to advance the Enlightenment, or see the Enlightenment as having secure foundations, so that science, on those foundations, can proceed more majestically than it already has even, by the 1700s, that's under threat. If we don't have these concepts of identity and causality and so forth, if we can't form meaningful, inductive generalizations, it seems like that whole project is now philosophically unmoored.

- 6.5 If we cannot rationally justify morality, if we cannot prove the existence of God and, perhaps, give a traditional religious justification for morality, then morality, again, is philosophically unmoored. So how are we going to be able to then rescue the world of science and the world of morality from what seems to be this virulent skepticism from David Hume? Now, that dead end of empiricist tradition is one serious problem. But there's also the rationalist tradition coming out of Descartes. If we start only with the self and try to deduce this entire apparatus of philosophy, that also had been subject to severe criticism in the century since Descartes' death, such that it was now seen also as a dying enterprise.
- 6.6 So, what are we going to do? Now, I want to highlight, because Kant is a complicated philosopher, and also his writing takes some getting used to. So I want to give some highlights about what Kant's project is to guide our future discussions, also when we plunge into the text, and at that time we're going to be wrestling with some arguments, but also some new vocabulary. So, part of what Kant does want to do is say, science is an important project. It is a good thing. We need to find a secure footing for, a new foundation for science. And the suggestion is going to be, the empiricists' and the rationalists' ways of doing it so far have not been able to do so.
- 6.7 Another suggestion, then, is to say that what we also need to do—this is partly a more Cartesian thing—is to turn inward and to have a better psychology, or a better metapsychology, or a better understanding of what this mind is. And some interpreters want to argue that Kant is then the beginning of psychology as a new discipline. Science so far is focusing on the external world and trying to come up with a scientific understanding. What if we apply the same analytical tools to the inner world? Can we come up with an understanding of the underlying causal structures of the mind?
- 6.8 Now, what Kant is then going to argue, though, is, if we do so, in his fashion, the skeptics are right, that there are some things that we are not going to be able to make sense of or prove exist, much less explore. And this is going to be what he calls the noumenal realm. And this is a piece of terminology here. What Kant is going to argue is that traditional distinction in philosophy between reality and appearance, things as they really are and things as they appear to us, needs to be upgraded and made more fundamental in a certain way. And what he's going to call the world as it appears to us, the ordinary reality, is phenomena, the phenomena that appear to us, and that is a phenomenal world. But reality itself, the real world, independent of how it appears to us or what we are aware of, that's the noumenal realm.
- 6.9 And a skeptical conclusion is going to be that the noumenal world is off-limits to us. We cannot know anything about the noumenal world. We can know the phenomenal world. And this, he wants to argue, as if we take this seriously with the new foundations he's establishing, will put science on a new foundation, and at the same time, it will save religion. Not necessarily robustly traditional religion, but it will salvage the important things from religion, and it will save religion from all of the skeptical,

rational attacks that had been mounted on it, against it, rather, by the original. All right, so that's the plan. We're going to save science, we're going to save religion, but we need a philosophical revolution in order to do so.

6.10 All right, this is the cover of the first edition of the Critique of Pure Reason, published in 1781. I want to highlight again just two things in the excerpts that we are going to look at. What Kant is going to argue is that we need what he calls a Copernican revolution in philosophy. So if we think of Copernicus from the history of science, Copernicus was the first in the modern world to suggest and argue systematically for the idea that we don't take the earth as being the center of everything, we make the sun the center of everything. And that requires a huge mental shift in our thinking. And what Kant is going to argue is, in philosophy, we need to do a correspondingly significant shift in our thinking. What we take as our center and our object needs to be radically refocused to something else. And this is going to amount to a revolution.

6.11 And the other famous phrase, comes a little bit later, is that "I had therefore to deny knowledge in order to make room for faith." So on the one hand, if we engage in this Copernican shift, just as Copernicus the scientist did, we will save science. But at the same time, that Copernican revolution is going to enable us to save a kind of faith, a religious faith, that's going to round morality, but it's going to also have a skeptical price. I have to deny knowledge of something important as well. So keep an eye out for those ones. So let's go next to the text. And here is the famous second preface to the Critique of Pure Reason, which is a multi, multi-hundreds of pages work. Serious students of philosophy should grapple with it at some point.

6.12 But I like the second preface because it was, it's a shorter piece. And what he does in 1787, when the second edition is coming out, is, after the first edition had come out, he had had another six years to think about his work. Also, for six years he got feedback from colleagues pushing him on this, that, and the other thing. And almost everybody was complaining about his rhetoric and his prose, which is rather cumbersome and difficult to grapple with. So, he reformulated a lot of things to try to make things clearer. And he then said, "I'm going to write this preface, in which I'm going to outline the important arguments, the reasons for them, and where they think they are going to take us." So I think it's the best overall introduction to Kant's philosophy, his fundamental philosophy.

6.13 So. "Whether such, the treatment of such knowledge as lies within the province of reason does or does not follow the secure path of science is easily determined from the outcome." So we're interested in science. We're interested in reason, so we're reasonable creatures, have whatever it is that we're doing with our reason take us in the direction of developing a science. He points out we're rational, but we haven't developed physics yet, and it takes a certain amount of groping and wandering and pre-scientific stuff before, finally, we're doing physics, and the same thing happens from

chemistry, moving out of, say, alchemy, and same thing for biology. So, are we making the move from general reason to science? We know from the outcomes.

- 6.14** Then he goes on to say, well, look, "If after elaborate preparations frequently renewed, it is brought to a stop immediately, it nears its goal. If often it is compelled to retrace its step and strike out in some new line of approach, or again, if the various participants are unable to agree in any common plan or procedure, then we may rest assured that it is very far from having entered upon the secure path of a science and is indeed a merely random groping." And he's going to go on to say, that's where we are in most of philosophy, especially metaphysical philosophy, random groping. We start, we have to stop, we have to retrace our steps. Nobody can agree even what we're supposed to be doing properly with respect to metaphysics.
- 6.15** He then goes on to say, not all branches of human knowledge seem to be in that way. Logic, for example, is an exception to the problems that metaphysics and the other branches of philosophy has. A long time ago, Aristotle came up with a treatise on logic, and that became, then, a progressive discipline for several centuries, and a beautiful work, and we haven't been required to revise Aristotle's logic for a huge amount of time. So, why were the logicians so successful?
- 6.16** He goes on to argue that the mathematicians also, and the physicists now, mathematicians for a much longer period of time. We haven't had to go back and revise the Pythagorean theorem, for example. Geometry is a flourishing discipline, and all the more theorems are being cranked out, and we can do all of the applications, and it's a beautiful thing. So, what were the mathematicians doing? They were able to proceed. And then he's making the same point for physics more recently, particularly after Isaac Newton. Now physics is off and running and doing magnificent things. So what do these intellectual revolutions have in common? And then, we philosophers, who want to do our metaphysics, what can we learn from those revolutions to hopefully get metaphysics away from this just random groping, pre-scientific phase and so forth?
- 6.17** So what Kant then goes on to argue, when you look at the history of logic, the history of physics and mathematics, is that they have something in common. This is how he describes it. What these people do is try "to bring out what was necessarily implied in the concepts that he himself had formed a priori, and had put into the figure in the construction by which he presented it to himself." All right, let's pause and unpack that a little bit. That then is to say, what the mathematician is doing is, he has some concepts. He has formed those concepts all by himself, "a priori." And this is a piece of technical term, where "a priori" is to say, prior to experience. And there's a distinction in between objects of our ideas that we have, objects of belief, possibly. Where did they come from? Did we come from experience after experience, "a posteriori", or did they come "a priori", that the mind generated themselves prior to experience?

- 6.18** And so what mathematicians do, the argument here is, form some concepts a priori. He makes them. And then what he does is, whatever, say, mathematically, if there's some geometric figure he is studying, he imports that into the figure under construction, and then he goes and studies that constructed figure. Now, if we generalize the lesson there, "they learned," all three of these, "that reason has insight only." Only is always a strong word. "Only into that which it produces after a plan of its own." Let's pause on that one. That is to say, when we are looking at reason, and what reason can have insight into, reason does not have insight into things that are what they are independently of itself. It has insight only into that which has produced after a plan of its own. It makes up its own plan. It has its own internal resources, and that's what it can have resource or insight into.
- 6.19** Further the suggestion. "It," that is to say reason, "must not allow itself to be kept, as it were, in nature's leading strings." That is to say, pausing, nature doesn't lead us in the direction that it wants to go. We're not following nature. Instead, we need to reverse that and take nature where we want it to go, or where reason wants it to go. "But must itself, that is to say, reason itself must show the way with principles of judgment based upon fixed laws, constraining nature to give answers to questions of reason's own determining." So we're going to make nature give us answers to questions that we have made up a priori, according to concepts that are reason's own. Reason, then carrying on, "must adopt as its guide, in so seeking, that which it has itself put into nature." So we're not reading off what's out there in nature. We're going to put things out into nature, and then we can read them off.
- 6.20** All right, what we found, though, then, if we go back to metaphysics, it has not been trying to do this. Instead, metaphysics has said, well, this abstract, speculative science of reason, we're trying to be very rational, right, and so forth. But what we've been trying to do is let nature speak to us, or maybe let supernature speak to us. And so we're assuming that nature or supernature is going to lead us where it wants to go. And Kant wants to say, "That's why we have been getting nowhere." Reason is perpetually being brought to a stand. And then, once again, it has been just random groping.
- 6.21** Now, this is, then, after those examples, an important transition point, where he says, if you take the entire history of philosophy up to now, hitherto —this is going back not only to the early moderns, through all of the medieval philosophers, all the Hellenistic philosophers, all of the Greek philosophers, to the very pre-Socratics— what has been the assumption of all of philosophy? What has been the guiding principle of its metaphysics and its epistemology? What is knowledge? "Hitherto, it has been assumed that all our knowledge must conform to objects," and we'll pause there. What is knowledge? And the assumption then is, has been, well, there are objects out there in reality, objective reality. They are what they are. Knowledge is a result, hopefully, in the subject.

- 6.22 So if the object and the subject, and the subject is trying to come to know the object, and the assumption then has been that the subject has to conform to the object, that what we call knowledge is in conformity with objects and the way they actually are. And so we have a small "O" objective assumption, or a small objectivism. Small "O" objectivism. It's not knowledge if it depends on the subject. If I could just make it up, or it's just speaking about me, it's not about me. I, as a subject, am focused on what's objectively out there in reality. That's what knowledge is. Sometimes, in one version of this, we will call this the correspondence theory of knowledge, or a correspondence theory of truth. An idea is true if it, in your head, right, it corresponds to the way things actually are, objectively, out there in the world.
- 6.23 So that's been the assumption of all of philosophy up to Kant. "But all attempts to extend our knowledge of objects by establishing something in regard to them a priori, by means of concepts, have, on this assumption, ended in failure." Every single attempt to do philosophy on this objectivist premise has failed. The proof of that is that, in our generation, the rationalists —Descartes, Spinoza, Leibniz—have worked out that tradition, and it's reached a dead end. They don't have knowledge; it's a failure. The empiricists—Bacon, Locke, Berkeley, Hume—worked out that project on objectivist assumptions; it has ended in failure. The best of the best, coming down the entire tradition, has been in a failure, and all of them have been basing themselves on this assumption.
- 6.24 "We must therefore make trial, whether we may not have more success in the tasks of metaphysics, if we suppose that the objects must conform to our knowledge." Let's pause on that one. So, rather than saying that what's going on in the subject, what we call of our knowledge, has to conform to the objects that are out there, what if we say, whatever is out there has to conform to our knowledge? What's going on in the subject and its structures, its nature, its identity, whatever that happens to be. And so, rather than the assumption being objectivity, where the subject conforms to the object, what we will call knowledge of the object will depend on the objects conforming to the subject. And these are terms that have a lot of different meanings. But what we are then saying is we need to reject objectivity and replace it with a kind of subjectivity. And that's what's being proposed here.
- 6.25 And this is what he calls his Copernican revolution in philosophy. So, for the pre-Copernicans, the idea that the earth is not at the center of the universe is shocking, and it's a revolution for them to try to conceptualize the idea that the sun is at the center, and to rethink everything by putting the sun at the center. And what Kant is then suggesting is, it's an equally shocking thing initially to say, all along we've been thinking we should be objectivist and assume that knowledge has to conform to objects that are out there. But what if we recast everything in small "S" subjectivist terms, that the knowledge and the knowing subject sets the terms, and what we call the object has to conform to it?

- 6.26 "We should be then proceeding precisely along the lines of Copernicus' hypothesis." He goes on then to work his way through various things that we try to do when we know, right. Intuition, which has many different meanings in philosophy, but just think about sensing and perception, just an intuitive understanding. How things seem to you in the world. Concepts a little bit later, and then more sophisticated conceptual, epistemological things a little bit later. So he then wants to say here is, if we try with respect to the senses, suppose we suppose that our senses are objectively putting us in contact with reality. " As regards the intuition of objects, if intuition must conform to the constitution of the objects, I do not see how we could know anything of the latter a priori."
- 6.27 Say, our senses are conforming to the way objects are. We end up in a skeptical place. " But if the object as an object of the senses," whatever's out there, "must conform to the constitution of our faculty of intuition," our subjective constitution. If the object has to conform to that, then I can make sense of knowing that object, because it has to conform to our faculty. We try to do the same thing with concepts. We have concepts of humanity and gravity and friction and so forth. Well, if we try to ground those concepts on objectivist grounds, he goes on to argue, then we're going to end up in skepticism again. On the other hand, if concepts of causality and identity and so forth are part of the faculty of the constitution of the subject, and the objects, as they appear to us, are constituted by the subject, then I have some idea of what it would mean to know those sorts of things.
- 6.28 So this is the subject. This is the subjective term, using subjective now, just in this very stripped-down metaphysical sense that Kant wants to use it here. "We can know a priori of things only what we ourselves put into them." We can't know things as they are, only as we have decided we're going to put into them. Now, he says, this is a big shock. This is a consequence which is startling, and it should be startling, given the entire history of philosophy here. "For we are brought to the conclusion that we can never transcend the limits of possible experience, though that is precisely what this science is concerned," this science being metaphysics, "above all else, to achieve."
- 6.29 So what he is then saying is, he's recognizing, if we have this subjective constitution — our senses, our concepts, or whatever, whatever the apparatus is in place that does all of these sorts of things—and then whatever's out there interacts with that constitution, and it gets shaped and formed and manipulated by our subjective constitution, and that result is presented to our mind. And that's what we're supposed to know, or we can know that. But what it sends us to say, that we can't ever know what's really out there, because we're never going to have any impression of it. There's no way for us, so to speak, our minds, to get outside of ourselves, past our subjective constitution, to interact with objects as they really are. So that's their kind of skepticism there. But he wants to say, we are saving the day because we do have now something that we know, and we can make sense of knowledge on these terms.

- 6.30 So, metaphysics has to then not make claims to know what he now is going to call noumenal reality, reality out there. Instead, it knows phenomenal reality, which is constituted by our subjective faculties. "Our a priori knowledge of reason, namely, that such knowledge has to do only with appearances." That is to say, we only know this apparent world. "And must leave the thing in itself as indeed real per se," it really is out there, "but not known by us." We don't know real reality. Now, are we happy or are we sad? Because on the one hand, this sounds like a kind of skepticism. We're never going to know reality. We're trapped in some sort of a subjective world, which, of course, we can come to know. And Kant is willing to say, "Yes, that's exactly where we are." But the value question: "What is the value of this metaphysics that is to be thus purified by criticism, once and for all?"
- 6.31 Well, one thing that we can do is we can do science, because science is interested in stable objects that are in space and time and subject to various causal principles. And if it's the case that the world of appearance is constituted regularly by our subjective faculties, and we causally order things in various ways, and, as he goes on to suggest here, we add space and time to it, then we are going to have the kind of world that the scientists want to explore. And what's interesting here is, he is talking about space and time. And, of course, long physical and metaphysical philosophical debates about whether space and time are real, or whether they are relative, or whether they are objective or imparted, is it the case that there is really space out there and objects are in space, and we are one of those objects in space? Is time really out there, or is time just some subjective way of keeping track of whatever's going on out there? Kant is explicitly coming down on the subjectivist side.
- 6.32 "Space and time are only forms of sensible intuition." That is to say, our faculties of intuition, our sense organs, whatever those are —space and time are how we happen to sense things in the world. They're not out there in reality. "And so, only conditions of the existence of things as appearances." So they're not real in the full, robust sense; they are real only in the apparent world, and that apparent world is largely a function of the constitution of our subjective faculties. OK, now he goes on to say, though, that we do not want to throw the baby out with the bathwater. There is a position in philosophy called solipsism, which is a kind of skepticism about the external world that says, when you get down a certain point, I can't even know that there is such a thing as an external world. I can't know that there are other people. Maybe I am the only existing thing in the world and what I call reality is just some sort of subjective projection that I've just made it all up.
- 6.33 Kant wants to say, "That is not true." There is a real reality out there, and we can think it. We can come up with this formulation that there must be a reality out there. What its constitution is, we don't know for sure. We can think it, even if we can't know it. So we're not going to rule out that there is such a place. So we're going to then take this old objects as objects of experience, and those things as things in themselves, that we

are going to operate. Now, what does this then mean for the plight of religion and morality? Because one of the things, of course, that's been happening, or the existence of God, or the idea that I have an immortal soul, is it seems that, over the course of the project of the Enlightenment, whether you are a robustly progressive advocate of the Enlightenment, those things start to seem suspect, and they start getting pushed into the background. And a much more naturalistic kind of scientific, reductionistic understanding of everything comes along.

6.34 Or even if we're not that much, we are still skeptical about the existence of all of those things on more robustly philosophical grounds. Can we do anything about those concepts? And what he wants to argue here is that, if we think of the world as it's now constituted, we get to think about things in two senses. There are things as they are in themselves and things as they appear to us. If we focus on how they are as things to us, then we don't really get a God, we don't get free will, we don't get an immortal soul. In the world of phenomena, I don't perceive any of those things. Hume is exactly right. And on the basis of what I perceive, I'm not going to be able to argue for the existence of a God. It just doesn't appear in my sensory field or any sort of rational argument.

6.35 Same thing with respect to free will. If I take this now robustly scientific understanding of the world, it's all cause and effect. And the physicists and the chemists and the biologists are making further and further inroads to understanding the human being as a physical system, a chemical system, a biological system, and all of those things are just cause and effect. So there's no room for free will. Everything we know with respect to the human being seems to suggest that it's subject to decay and decrepitude and then eventual death. And we don't ever see a soul pop out of the body and go off on its merry way after death. So it seems like, in the phenomenal world, in the scientific world, we're never going to get any of those sorts of things.

6.36 But if we don't know the real world, as the real world is, independently of the way we experience it, we cannot rule out the possibility that they are real out there, that the self that appears determined in the phenomenal world isn't itself free in the noumenal world; that there is no place for God in our phenomenal world, but nonetheless, out there in a noumenal world, there is a God, and the same thing for immortality. We can't rule it out, even though we can't include it in our understanding of the phenomenal world. So we can understand ourselves in this two-fold sense. I can't know that I'm free, but I can think of the possibility of freedom.

6.37 That then means, if we are going to understand something like morality—this is going to be the next step of the argument—morality does seem to require that we are free agents, that we make choices, that those choices are not determined, that we can be held responsible for, credited or blamed, for the choices that we make. But if it's the case that determinism is true, then it seems to rule out our freedom of choice. And so morality is out the window, in this hyper-scientific, materialistic world. But morality, if it

depends on freedom, if it's possible that we have free agency and some noumenal self that are really out there, then we can still think of ourselves, possibly, as moral agents.

- 6.38** And so the point is going to be that, on these three things, that we have an immortal soul, that we have free agency, really, that there really is a God. We can't know them, but we can think of them as possibilities. They cannot be ruled out, because reasoning and the world of appearances is subject to these limitations. It can only know its own constitution. And therefore we get to the big conclusion. "I have found it necessary to deny knowledge, in order to make room for faith." I can't know the noumenal world. I can only know this subjectively constructed world of sensory intuition and reasoning based on the world as it appears to me. That's fine for science. What's out there in reality? I can't know it. But what that means is that I can't prove that there isn't a God out there. I can't prove that there isn't freedom out there. I can't prove that there isn't immortality out there.
- 6.39** Reason is cut off from the noumenal, what's really out there. And if it's possible, then that opens the door to a kind of faith. So, OK for me to think it, to believe it, to consider it as, perhaps, a necessary possibility for some other values that I want to achieve. The dogmatism of metaphysics, this idea that dogmatically we're going to be able to prove the way the world really is out there, that there is or isn't a God, that the soul is or isn't immortal—all of that dogmatism is undercut. That approach to metaphysics, we get rid of it and we leave that whole realm open to faith, perhaps a kind of religious faith. And so we have saved religion.
- 6.40** And the way he puts it this way is, "But above all, there is the inestimable benefit, that all objections to morality and religion will be forever silenced. And this, in Socratic fashion," so Socrates dialoguing back and forth, "the clearest proof of the ignorance of the objectors." So all of those atheistic arguments that say, "We can prove that there is no such thing as a God. We can rationally prove that there is no such thing as a God." Kant's response, then, is going to be, "Rationality and proof depend on one's subjective constitution." One's subjective constitution creates a world that is the phenomenal world. One's rationality and logic is limited to that world. The real world, the noumenal world, is off-limits to that. No proof extends beyond there. You are ignorant of the rational world, so you cannot disprove the existence of a God.
- 6.41** So, what we then have is a project which involves grounding science in a new way, saving religion in a new way. And the way that we do it is by means of a Copernican revolution in philosophy, from knowledge as conforming to objects, to knowledge as conforming to the constitution of the subject. Now, this is hugely influential, and what we will see in subsequent developments in post-Kantian philosophy is various ways in which people take Kantian philosophy, but that's for future development. But for now, it's an awareness of a rather audacious and innovative move in philosophy. And this is one of the reasons why Kant is great, just because everybody has to pay attention to this argument and say something about it after Kant.

- 6.42 Now we've made room for the possibility of God and freedom and immortality, religion and morality. I want to turn now to Kant not merely as an epistemological and metaphysical thinker, but what he has done also in ethics and in political philosophy, and what his conception of this modernized approach to religion is going to be. And later in Kant's life, this gentleman is very much on his mind. Kant is a professor at Königsberg University, which was now, then part of Prussia, which is now part of Russia, in the far east of the German states. And after Frederick the Great, there is a new king, Frederick or William II, and he is extraordinarily conservative, politically and religiously, and again, relativizing the concept of conservative to 18th-century Prussia.
- 6.43 A whiff of the Enlightenment causes fever, danger, alarm signals to go off. And what King William, Frederick II is —Frederick William, rather, the Second, is concerned with is precisely the end roads that the Enlightenment is starting to make. It's undercutting belief in the soul, it's undercutting belief in religious morality, it's undercutting the absolutism of the monarchy. It's just bad news all around. So Kant is a professor at a university under King William, and William appoints as his minister of education and cultural affairs an arch-conservative who decides that we need to enact a strict regime of censorship to keep this Western disease of the Enlightenment from having inroads into the German states, but especially into the Prussian states.
- 6.44 This is fascinating because Kant then, by some measures, is a philosopher of the Enlightenment. And in some of his essays, he says things that are very Enlightenment-friendly and very Enlightenment-promoting and advocating for a kind of free thinking. And so he is a modernizer in that particular sense. But when political reality inflicts, what he has then is a regime of censorship that is on his own doorstep. And the argument, in increasingly sophisticated form, is something like this. If we follow Enlightenment reason, rather, that's going to generate this kind of arrogant hubris that we can figure out answers to all of life's questions and we can engage in all of this social engineering to remake the entire world. But that's just going to be a disaster.
- 6.45 Or if we think people are going to be rational, and reason is a function of the individual, that's just going to turn people into themselves, thinking that they are their own gods or demigods or whatever. They can do whatever they want, and it's going to generate a kind of rampant selfishness in society. And both of those together are going to self-destroy individuals, but also the fabric of society. And the Enlightenment can only lead to conflict, poverty, death, and all sorts of other really bad things. So we need to protect ourselves, our children, and society from the Enlightenment.
- 6.46 Now, that's not just abstract theory. As we start to get into the 1790s, second edition of the Critique of Pure Reason came out in 1787. The French Revolution begins in 1789, and within a couple of years, what are the French revolutionaries doing under the Reign of Terror? They have torn everything down. They are chasing priests down the street, capturing them, cutting their heads off with the guillotine, and putting their heads on spikes. That's about as anti-religious as you can possibly get. And that's the

French Enlightenment in action, from the Prussian perspective. French Enlightenment means killing everybody associated with religion. And not only that, then the king and the queen, Louis XVI and Marie Antoinette —they had been imprisoned, they tried to escape, they were caught, they were brought back, and then what did the French revolutionaries do? They killed the king; they killed the queen. They are regicides, destroying the monarchy. So everything to do with traditional society is being hunted down and killed by the French Revolution.

- 6.47 Do we want that in Prussia? No, absolutely not. So what we have then is a very stark choice from the Prussian perspective, between Frederick William II and everything that he stands for, or the French Revolution, which is, from the conservative perspective, just death, destruction, torture, civil war. It's a disaster. So we need to protect ourselves against the Enlightenment, and censorship is how we have to do it. Stop those bad ideas from coming into our country. Now, what Kant then decides in this situation is compliance. I'm going to go along with the censorship regime.
- 6.48 "Subjects of the state have no right to disobey the supreme authority in a state, even if the commands are unjust. The people"—right, this is not government for the people; the people are subject—"cannot and may not pass any judgment other than that which is willed by the current head of state." Now here the issue is a contrast then, of course, to the Enlightenment. And we got to understand traditional conservatives who will resist this idea that people can disobey the law, or that in any sense the sovereigns or the rulers of the state are supposed to be subject to the people, servants of the people. The idea that people have a natural right to liberty, and if the current regime is illiberal and unjust, that they have the right to rise up in rebellion. And here we have Kant going along with the idea, that is, the liberals are wrong. We need to have an absolute enforcement of obedience to higher authority.
- 6.49 As for religion, Kant is a religious man. He had been raised in a strictly pietistic family, which is a kind of low church, what we would now call very fundamentalist approach to religion. And I don't think it's true to say that he is traditionally religious in his beliefs, but nonetheless, he carries over the social need for religion and the personal moral need for religion. So I want to say a few things about his view of morality and its connection to religions. So he wants to argue that both of those are absolutely essential to philosophy. But we do have a view from Kant that human beings are not naturally good. They are not naturally tabula rasa. Neither of those more popular beliefs in the Enlightenment are subscribed to by Kant in this work, *Religion Within the Limits of Reason Alone*. He has a long section on the depravity and an innate evil of human natures. And so we can't just wish that away by this optimistic Enlightenment kind of thinking. We have to grapple with this, and morality and religion needs to take this up.
- 6.50 And so, this notion of obedience, that I am going to obey this censorship regime, even though in some ways I think we should be Enlightenment free thinkers, and maybe I'm

just special, or we are just special if we are intellectuals, and we can have a little more liberty than the average person as well, that I need to obey the state, obey the monarch, even if I think the state is unjust and wrong in it—this absolute obedience is a fundamental moral principle. And in several of Kant's essays, you find him hearkening back to Eve and saying they're—religious tradition comes in many different fabrics or many different costumes. But there's a core truth that religion gets, even if much of the apparatus and institutionalization of it is wrong. And that is that obedience is the fundamental. If we go right back to the story of Eve, Eve's sin was disobedience.

6.51 She was told not to take the fruit of the tree, the tree of knowledge. Sometimes it's the tree of the knowledge of good and evil. That's very interesting to think of, that good and evil and the knowledge of them are to be off-limits to human beings. So, Eve's great sin is to take the apple, which is an act of theft, but it is a disobedience. And so what we need to do is take that insight and modernize it, because we're going to obviously have a very difficult time modernizing this notion if we want people now, in the Enlightened world, to believe in Bible stories and that the traditional religions have gotten them all correct and so on.

6.52 But what we find, though, is, in the Bible, is that the lesson "why you should obey" seems to appeal to self-interest. Why do you obey? And the lesson is that, if you disobey, God will find out and he will do bad things to you. And that's what we learn in the Bible. Eve tried to disobey, but she didn't get away with it. She was caught. And so, she had made Adam complicit in the sin as well. So they were both punished in various ways. But if we take that as a lesson, then it seems to be, the lesson is that we should obey, but we should obey because we fear that God is watching us, or God's going to find out, and we are going to get punished. But that means that the reason why we are obeying is that we don't want to get punished. And that's a self-interested consideration. So if I didn't think I was going to get punished, then I would disobey.

6.53 And Kant then said, well, we sort of have a good lesson. You should obey, but we don't have the right justification for it. What Kant then argues happens in the religious tradition as it goes along —and of course, these things take a long time to develop—is there's not so much short-term punishment, that God's not always watching you and he's going to instantly find out and punish you, but rather, things get saved up, and you have a cumulative record about whether you were obedient or disobedient over the course of your life. And then, in the afterlife, if you have an immortal soul, you will get your rewards or you will get your punishments. Now, this is an improvement, because this requires us now not to think as short-term human beings. That's not very flattering to human beings. We are thinking long-term, big-picture, about our lives as a whole and what things are going to add up to, and an ultimate kind of justice in the afterlife.

6.54 And that is an intellectual improvement and a credit to human beings. But Kant wants to say, that is still a self-interested motive, if that's what it is. What you're doing, so to speak, is trying to build up a really good resume, so that when you stand before the

pearly gates, God has to let you in because you've got a really good resume. Or of course, you will recognize if you've done a lot of bad things and you're going to go to hell, well, there's a kind of justice there as well, but you are still operating on a principle of self-interest. I want to go to heaven. I don't want to go to hell. And that's why I am obeying these commands. And so Kant then says improvement, but we are still not justifying morality.

6.55 Where we need to get as human beings, and this is the deepest insight of religious morality, is to the point where we do our duties and we obey independently of self-interest. Independently of the consequences to us, we do the right thing because it is the right thing. It's not consequentialist. It's not that it's going to lead to the pursuit of happiness or the greater betterment of society and so forth. There are moral principles that are imperatives that apply categorically. And a perfectly moral person, if this is possible to us, will recognize that that is what morality requires, and obey on the basis of that. And that is the moral theory that Kant wants to develop in his moral works. There's one on the Metaphysics of Morals. There's a Groundwork of the Metaphysics of Morals and some more popular pieces. The most popular formulation, though, is the one that most students will read, is the Groundwork of the Metaphysical Morals, in which he develops this concept of the categorical imperative.

6.56 Now, the technical terminology is a little bit important here. What he wants to argue is, an imperative is a command. It's an order. You should do this, or you are ordered to do this, wherever the source of the authority is, and you do that imperative. And morality is to come in the form of these imperatives. Do this and don't do that. We have the lists that we are to attend to, but we are to do them not hypothetically. It's not that we obey, if, hypothetically, it's going to lead to certain results, that we favor or disfavor these results. We do them themselves. So what he wants to argue is, much of wrong-founded morality is a matter of hypothetical imperatives. If you want to avoid a spanking, do what your mom says, and then you do what your mom says. So you obey your mom, but you're doing it hypothetically because you want to avoid the spanking. If the disobeying did not lead to the spanking, you probably would not obey your mom. You're operating on a hypothetical imperative.

6.57 If you don't want to go to jail, do what the policeman tells you. If you don't want to go to hell, or if you do want to go to heaven, do what God tells you. All of those are in the hypothetical form. Kant says that's the wrong way of thinking about morality. Morality is about categoricals. Do it, don't do it, and you don't think about consequences. You don't think about results for yourself or anyone else. "Duty is the necessity to act out of reverence for the law." You obey the law because you revere the law. You do your duty. What he wants to argue is that this is not old-fashioned faith religion. So we think of perhaps the story of Abraham and Isaac. And on a standard interpretation of Abraham and Isaac, an angel appears to Isaac and says, "God has commanded that you

take your—to Abraham, take your son Isaac up to Mount Moriah and offer him as sacrifice."

- 6.58** And a traditional interpretation of faith then has to say that Abraham is a hero of faith because he does not question God. He doesn't say, you know, "Why would you ask me to kill Isaac? He's young. He hasn't done anything worthy of the death penalty. This doesn't make sense to me yet." He doesn't say, "Didn't you earlier say, God, that through my child, the future generations of Israel would arise? Well, if I kill this kid, he hasn't fathered any children yet. That means that contract won't be fulfilled. And so there's an inconsistency here, or you've changed your mind." Abraham does not ask that question. He doesn't ask the question, "Why would you ask me, if you think my son is deserving of dying? Why would you ask me? I'm the father. To ask a father to kill his own child? And what am I going to tell Sarah, my wife? 'What did you do today, dear?' It makes no sense." The point is, Abraham did not question, didn't raise any of those questions. He obeyed.
- 6.59** And that is a faithful approach to obedience. And in many religious traditions, then he is a hero, because he isn't asking any hypothetical questions, and he's not asking any rational questions. He is strictly faithful. "Whatever God says, I am going to obey and do it." And Kant wants to argue, centuries later, that the unconditional obedience part of this is right, but not that kind of faith part. And this is the Enlightenment element coming out, that we are rational beings. And what we need to be able to do as rational beings is understand that, if we are going to be worthy of some sort of self-dignity, we will adhere to moral principles. But we will adhere to moral principles that we understand and have formulated and seen the rationale for them. They will be moral principles, not that they're going to lead to good consequences for us, but that we will be able to see as moral principles.
- 6.60** So don't be a liar. Be an honest person, for example. I will be an honest person, not because God told me to be, or not because my mom told me to be, and certainly not because I fear the consequences of becoming a liar. I will become an absolutely honest person, and I will obey, without question, the principle of being obedient to the truth, because I recognize that truth matters. And being a person of your word, that if you say you are going to do something, matters, and that the only way to be consistent in my thinking, in my acting, is by adhering to moral principles. So, something that I need to generate rationally for myself, combined with this notion of absolute obedience.
- 6.61** And this is the point. "The ground of this principle is," and that was him saying, making a foundational point, "rational nature exists as an end in itself." Also, if we are going to be rational beings, the argument is, it has to be that the same principles hold for you, for you, for me. There has to be a universalistic point. And this also is part of the Enlightenment, that the principles are not special to different classes, different sexes, different constituencies in various ways. There is one human nature, one humanity. We all have rationality. And so, what is a principle for you should also be a principle for me.

And rationality is then going to generate logically consistent and universal principles. And so, that's why we have this formulation: "Act on the maxims of a member who makes universal laws for a merely possible kingdom of ends."

- 6.62** Now, unpacking that terminology a little bit, a "kingdom of ends." It's not a republic of ends, interestingly, in the modern world, but imagine you are in a world, an imaginary world, with a bunch of other rational beings, and you are now, in Enlightenment fashion, legislating for yourselves what kind of world you want to create as rational beings. What would all of you agree with, as rational beings, as being logically consistent, laws that you could commit yourself to absolutely, and thereby become obedient to? That is what Kant wants to argue is a proper kind of morality.
- 6.63** Now that morality is going to require some customization, because not everybody is going to be a philosopher. It's then going to be important for adult people who are not philosophical to have a kind of second-best philosophy. Religion, and perhaps a more traditional religion, teaches that there are absolute universal principles that you can understand and you need to obey unconditionally. But he does want to argue that it's also going to require special tailoring for children, because children are born with a natural evilness that leads them to be disobedient in all sorts of ways. And so we're going to need to have a certain kind of strict education, parenting, and in the schools that is going to raise children up to be very obedient to the universal laws.
- 6.64** Now, in closing, I want to just have a couple of passages on this final point about the education of children, because Kant's views here are quite striking in modern times. When you read his lectures on education that were later published in a book, he fairly regularly cites Rousseau. He loves Rousseau and Rousseau's work. Emile, on proper education of children, was very influential on Kant, and he doesn't mention John Locke, even though he's aware of John Locke. And John Locke had written very liberal notions about education, that education should be fun, it shouldn't be just a matter of duty, that it should be a matter of respecting the liberty of the child and not be too strict, that kids are going to be kids not because they're evil, but because they're, they're sometimes a little impish, but a lot of times they don't know any better. So don't be too quick to punish them. Kids will grow out of various things if you set a good example yourself.
- 6.65** And by contrast, Locke is, sorry, Kant is not at all referencing that tradition, is going to argue much of the opposite. Now, here is one passage where he shows a kind of awareness of Locke. As Locke has said, we should respect children's natural liberty and what they want to do, and let them explore. And Kant's saying, no, no, no. Don't put things toward kids, toward inclination. Instead, from the beginning, kids need to learn obedience and duty, and so parenting and education should be quite strict. And I have this contrasting past from John Locke, where Locke had said, about education, "Great care is to be taken, that education be never made as a business to him, nor he look on it as a task." So it shouldn't be like a job that you have to go to, and it shouldn't be

something that you have to do. "We naturally, even from our cradles, love liberty, and have, therefore, an aversion to many things for no other reason but because they are enjoined us."

- 6.66** Human beings are naturally creatures of liberty. Education should work with that. Learning should be a play and a recreation. And then, by contrast, Kant is again very structured, very strict. The lesson of duty and obedience needs to be instilled. Of course, kids are going to mess up at various points, and then what do we do as parents and teachers when the kids mess up? What's the proper place of punishment of kids? Interestingly, a century before Kant, Locke had argued, we should be pretty light on punishment when it comes to kids. "I am very apt to think that great severity of punishment does but very little good, nay, great harm, in education. And I believe it will be found that, *ceteris paribus*," that is to say, holding everything equal, "those children who have been the most chastised seldom make the best men." We make bad people by how we raise them.
- 6.67** By contrast, we find in Kant, "Every transgression in a child is a want of obedience, and this brings punishment with it." And he has a fairly long taxonomy of all of the kinds of ways kids disobey, and the range of punishments that are appropriate for it. Now, I cite this because this is not simply liberal politics versus neo-authoritarian politics, the king of Prussia versus the English Parliament. This extends to how we raise our children. Do we have a more liberal education model? Do we have, as we now call it, the Prussian model, which is very strict, and obedience, top-down-oriented? And the great philosophers of modern time are the ones who have articulated the arguments for it.
- 6.68** Now, in closing, I want to mention, Kant died in 1804, and there is great controversy over how one is supposed to read Kant. And this is an indication by Moses Mendelssohn, who was a philosopher and theologian and a contemporary of Kant, who argued, "Kant is the all-destroyer." What is philosophy all about? It's a quest for knowledge, truth, objective truth, really coming to know what's out there in the real world. Kant has closed that door off to us forever. He's destroyed all of our aspirations for philosophy, as one school of philosophy takes Kant in exactly that direction.
- 6.69** By contrast, this is the poet Johann Hölderlin. Extraordinarily influential after Kant's death. Kant is the "Moses of our nation." We have been in bondage to wrong philosophies. Kant is leading us to the promised land. Extraordinarily positive estimation of Kant's influence and his significance. And then, just to close, this is Georg Hegel, to whom we will be turning next. Interestingly, Hegel and Hölderlin had been roommates in college. One went on to be a great philosopher, one to be a great poet. But I like to imagine the conversations they had, sometimes over beer in those German pubs. But Hegel arguing, "From the Kantian system and its completion"—Kant has shown the way, but we need more work to do—"I expect a revolution in Germany." And that's where we will be next time.

Lecture 7: Resurgent Collectivism

At a glance — Resurgent collectivism.

- 7.1 Our theme today is resurgent collectivism. And I want to start with this date, 1806, which is significant in European history, but particularly in the history of the German states, because this is the year the French army, under Napoleon, sweeps through the German states, meeting very little opposition. Now, this mix of philosophy and history, obviously, as we say now, in our Hegel-inspired language, that Napoleon was a world historical individual. He was also a very self-aware individual about what made him possible. So there's this last line. "If there had been no Rousseau, there would have been no revolution, and without the revolution, I should have been impossible." So, from his perspective, thanks, Rousseau.
- 7.2 But not so much so for the German states. And what is interesting in the history of philosophy is how philosophy is cosmopolitan in the modern world, all over Europe. The major centers do shift around, from significant action in Italy, France, England. But now, certainly, by the time we get into the 1800s, the major action is going to shift to Germany. And in the post-Kant generation, the question is—and it's a huge question, given the towering stature Kant has on the landscape, the fundamentality of his arguments, the shocking nature of the Copernican shift that he is suggesting—what are we going to do?
- 7.3 Because it seems like what Kant has done decisively is said, "Reality, true, noumenal reality, is unknowable in principle." It's not just that we can be skeptical around the margins. In principle, there's no way for reason to come to know reality. What we are left with is a phenomenal world, the world of appearances, the world of phenomena, as they seem to me—that is, constituted and constructed by in-built, subjective, structuring capacities. And reason can play around with those and do systematizing and do its science. But what's beyond that subjectively constituted world, the real world? No way of knowing.
- 7.4 So what we then seem to have is this very hard choice. We can either say, "If knowledge of real reality is closed off to reason, well, we are rational beings. We should follow reason. And that means we have to give up on any quest for knowledge of reality." Follow reason, but give up on reality. Or we can go the other way and say, well, "Really all that Kant has shown is that reason cannot get us to reality. Reason is limited. But we're philosophers, for goodness' sake. What is philosophy all about? It's about a quest for coming to know true reality. And so what we need to do, then, is continue that quest, but abandon reason, or marginalize reason and use non-rational, and perhaps even irrational, methods to try to break out of the confines of the phenomenal, rational world and seek real reality."

- 7.5 So one way of reading post-Kantian philosophy is to sense, see, that there's a major fork in the road. And some philosophers go down one fork of the road. They say, "No, we should be rational." That means philosophy needs to be rigorous, logical, analytical. Set aside your feelings and your sentiments. Be precise, be mathematical, be positivistic, and so forth. Two plus two fundamentally equals four. But you have to understand all of that as dealing with the phenomenal world that reason can construct. And so, some of the later schools of philosophy, we start to hear about analytic schools of philosophy, positivistic schools of philosophy, logical positivistic schools of philosophy, phenomenology. All of that are going to be people who are following this Kantian road.
- 7.6 But there's another possibility, where those who are saying, well, "Look, this is going to turn us into cold robots, take all of the life out of us and what we hope to be this reality beyond." And interestingly, some of the poets, all of whom at this time were very intelligent, well read, smart and sensitive individuals, so Goethe, for example, writing, "Gray, dear friend, is all theory, but green is life's golden tree." So we have a color metaphor here. If you're a theoretical person, kind of abstract ideas, so that's just all gray, right? But life is green. And we need to, the implication being, set aside this theory, set aside ideas and so forth, in order to somehow embrace real life, become really, really alive. And if reason is not the way to go, feeling is all, that feeling is all. Name is only sound and smoke.
- 7.7 And if you think of name, words, and you think of David Hume and nominalism, that these abstract words are just labels that we assign to more, sometimes arbitrarily grouped sensations, but that's just us playing around with words. Feelings are going to be more authentic, more real. So, set aside theory, set aside name, set aside words. Life is felt and lived through a passionate commitment of some sort. John Keats, the young English poet: "Do not all charms fly at the mere touch of cold philosophy?" Philosophy is cold. It's not warm. It takes all of the heat out of everything. It's not charming; it's boring. Yes, it's rigorous, it's analytical, etc. But life should be charming, magical, interesting.
- 7.8 "Philosophy will clip an angel's wings, conquer all mysteries by rule and line." This is going to turn it into a geometrical, graphical representation. It's all abstract and cold. It's going to try to demystify the entire world, take all of the interesting. So if you really want to live, if you really want to be authentic in some way, set aside philosophy. Philosophy is not going to get you there. So we're going to be non-rational. Non-philosophical.
- 7.9 Now, our two main philosophers today, Georg Hegel, Karl Marx, giants on the landscape of 19th-century philosophy, in the case of Hegel. Marx, of course, is more known as a political and an economic thinker. But his PhD was in philosophy, and his political and economic works grow out of his philosophy. And he was also very well read in Hegelian philosophy and earlier Kantian philosophy. So he knew his stuff. So I

want us to focus, when we get to Marx, on the philosophical underpinnings for his political and economic ideas.

- 7.10** Now, another thought in post-Kantian philosophy has been this debate among Enlightenment and Counter-Enlightenment individual philosophers about what we think of the human being as an individual. We have seen there's been a line of thought that says individuals have their own reason; they have their own lives. They should be seen as self-responsible agents who can take control of their own lives. And so we should be freeing everybody and giving them equal rights and letting them pursue happiness in their own way and tolerating individual differences as a matter of social organization. In many of the early Counter-Enlightenment thinkers, such as Rousseau, we start to see a resistance, an active hostility, to this idea of the individual, that we want to socialize the individual, we want to communalize the individual, so we want to collectivize the individual.
- 7.11** And what both Hegel and Marx are going to do is to take Kant and apply him not only to these metaphysical and epistemological issues, but to these issues about human nature and values. Now, if we take this language of the phenomenal world, the world as it seems to us, and contrast that to the real world, or the noumenal world, one possibility that opens up is to say, well, look, if we look at the phenomenal world, yeah, we use our intuitions, we use our senses. It seems like there's lots of individual things around it. It seems like you are all individuals. I am an individual. We have our own minds. So, individuality seems built into the nature of phenomenal reality.
- 7.12** What these are both going to suggest, though, Hegel and Marx, is that our true selves are not phenomenal individual selves. If we somehow get past our understanding of phenomenal reality with its individuality, we will come to see, in true reality, we are all aspects of a collective self. And the quest to go beyond your individuality and somehow merge with a collectivity, or see yourself as a vehicle through which—a particular individual vehicle through which—larger collective forces are working, that is a proper understanding of true reality.
- 7.13** Now, one other suggestion, because the language gets complicated here, is, rhetorically, this language of thesis, antithesis, and synthesis, we find it all over the place in Hegel's writings and in Marx's writing. This is a discussion of a dialectical process of nature. The idea here is that, if we are going to get past some of the problems that they see earlier philosophy as leading us to, we have to reject its metaphysical understanding of logic. You think of the idea this way, is that all previous philosophy, when it's talking about the way the world works, maybe, is there a logic to history, and where the destiny of humankind is going to be, that all of them have been mono-thesis accounts? To say that there's one account, one logic, that governs the entire world.
- 7.14** Now, that logic might be a religious logic. It might be that there's God. God has his ideas. God has his plan for the world. And so the entire history of the world should be

understood as God's plan for the world, unfolding across time. And we just need to figure out what God's plan for the world is. But God is one unified being. So there's a thesis that's running through history, but there's one thesis; it's God's plan for the thesis. Or, if we're not so religious, we might say there is a logic to the way the world goes. There are all of these principles, or logics, so to speak—principles of laws of cause and effect—that the scientists are working out gradually. But ultimately, what we should be able to do is to say, we can go back in time, this happened, and then this happened, and then this happened, and then this caused this, which caused this, which caused this, all the way down.

7.15 And so again, we have a unified set of scientifically discovered causal principles that give us the one true thesis, or the one true story about the way the world is going to go. And what that then suggests is that rationality should be ultimately unified, and all of our rationalities should be on the same page eventually, because there is one logic, one ultimate truth, that we are all trying to discover. Now, what the suggestion is going to be here is that that kind of logic rules out the possibility of contradiction, which it does. Traditional logic rules out the possibility of contradiction. You reach a contradiction, the thinking is, you've made a mistake somewhere in your thinking, and you need to go back and find out where that mistake is in your thinking.

7.16 This is going to be a contradiction-friendly understanding of the way the world works, that there is an initial thesis, so to speak, the way the world is, the rules of the game, or the principles that are animating the way the world goes, but it generates its anti-thesis. And it's not just that there's an opposite situation or potentiality in tension with that. It is a literal, real contradiction. So we have two different logics, or two different states of reality, that contradict each other, and it's out of that clash of contradictions that then a synthesis is going to emerge. And then that synthesis will in time generate or become the new thesis, but it will generate another antithesis.

7.17 And so we have to see, logic of the world is not harmonious, ultimately unified, but rather clash and contradiction are fundamentally built into reality. And we're going to need more than one logic to sort out what is going on, that what is scientific and logical and true of one era might be contradicted entirely by what is true and logical in a subsequent era. This is going to open up the door also to certain kinds of collectivisms. Sorry, relativisms.

7.18 Now, one of the great coincidences is that, also in 1806, as Hegel, or, sorry, as Napoleon and the French army are sweeping through the German states, is Hegel is just finishing his very first book, *The Phenomenology of Spirit*. And there's that word phenomena, phenomenology. And he's at a small university in the southeast of Germany, and that's when the French army reaches there, and Hegel makes this remark about actually seeing Napoleon, when there was a great famous battle in 1806 at Jena. "I saw the emperor, this world soul, riding out of the city on reconnaissance. It is indeed a wonderful sensation to see such an individual, who, concentrated here at a

single point, astride a horse, reaches out over the world and masters it—this extraordinary man, whom it is impossible not to admire."

- 7.19** So, one of the ruling philosophers of the 19th century meeting the ruler of Europe in the early part of the 19th century. It's an interesting historical coincidence, but this language is also going to factor into Hegel's writing and why he sees Napoleon as emblematic of a certain stage in world history as part of our story today. All right, now, this book that Hegel is just finishing, this is the book that first puts him on the intellectual map. He's 36 years old, so certainly coming into his intellectual prime. And the title is *The Phenomenology of Spirit*. So this is how, so to speak, spirit—one's consciousness or self-consciousness—appears to oneself. That's the phenomenal world. He's going to argue that spirit goes through various developmental stages. This is going to be his solution. This is one of the major things going on in this work to the traditional theodicy problem.
- 7.20** The theodicy problem is—to take from the Greek, "theos", god or gods, and "dikas", the concept for justice—how can we come to understand the justice or the goodness of God in the world, if we think of God as the creator of this world, and he is a good being, but nonetheless, the world has a lot of badness in it, a lot of evil in it? So here we have a problem. On the one hand, we have a thesis. We understand God as a perfect being, and he's also the creator of the world. And yet, when we look at the world, we see an imperfect world, a radically imperfect; that's an antithesis. So we have God, perfect world, imperfect. Thesis, antithesis. How are we going to put these two together? And the problem is that it seems like a contradiction to try to put it together. So we can elaborate the contradiction this way.
- 7.21** If God is a perfect being, we can say, there's three important dimensions of his perfection. Well, he's perfectly good. He doesn't have bad moods, he doesn't have wicked motivations, he doesn't do evil things. He is a perfectly good being. And if you are a good being, then what you want is for goodness to exist, as much goodness as possible. You don't want any badness or evil to exist in the world. OK, that makes sense. Seems logical. God is also perfect in his knowledge. He knows everything—past, present, future—however that's integrated in his godly mind, and he doesn't make any mistakes. He is perfect in his cognition, his recognition, his understanding of the world. And he is all-powerful. He's perfect in his power. He can do anything that he wants. There's nothing that is outside of the power of God.
- 7.22** So if we then imagine God, this perfect being, in the act of creation, we have to say he wants to create a perfect world. He knows how to create a perfect world, and he has the power to create a perfect world. And he did create the perfect world, but it is a mess. And now we're into thesis and antithesis; and squaring this circle, if I can use that metaphor, or trying to resolve this contradiction, is a traditional problem in philosophy of religion, obviously. So, now Hegel wants to address himself to trying to solve this problem. The short answer is going to be, and many heretical versions of Judeo-

Christian and Islamic philosophy will then say, well, if we're going to be logical, what we have to do is give up on one of these premises.

- 7.23 And what we can do is say, well, maybe God is not all-powerful. Maybe he's just very, very, very powerful. But there also is another powerful being out there in the world, a dark force, variously called Satan, Lucifer, the devil, whatever you want to call it. So God is all-good, he is all-knowing, but he is in this titanic struggle. There are the forces of good and the forces of evil, and they're both very powerful. And sometimes one wins, sometimes the other wins. And that's how we explain evil in the world. But that then is to say—and you're giving up on one thing—God is no longer perfect because he's not perfect in his power.
- 7.24 And there are other variations that are possible. What Hegel is going to do is say the second premise is the one that we need to adjust, that God is all-knowing, but we have to understand his knowingness as spread out in time, that he starts out all-powerful, starts out all-good, but he's not fully conscious or self-conscious yet. Instead, the process of history is going to be God realizing himself, realizing his plan, and as it goes along, increasing in awareness and self-awareness and adjusting the plan as it goes along. And the ultimate course of history then is God will reach perfect self-awareness. So it's going to be a developmental—and now I'm going to introduce—it's an evolutionary process that the world goes through, and we'll highlight that word evolution, which becomes increasingly important as the 1800s progress.
- 7.25 Now in the Philosophy of History, this is the work I want us to turn to, where we'll get a summary and we'll excerpt some key passages where Hegel is developing his account of the way history goes and how his understanding of history, philosophically, can solve the theodicy problem, along with any number of other things. So, subject of this course of lectures is the philosophical history of the world. And that then is to say, we're going to try to understand history not just as, well, this happens and this happens, and isn't that an interesting story about the Egyptians over here and the Babylonians over here? But it doesn't really add up to anything except a bunch of interesting stories. Instead, is there a lesson to history? Is there a logic to the development of history, that it's going from here and it's going to here and it's trying to get somewhere? So there's a big philosophical meaning of history. That is what Hegel is interested in.
- 7.26 Now some language. "The only thought which philosophy brings with it to the contemplation of history is the simple conception of reason, that reason is the sovereign of the world." Now we are philosophically alert. Reason, of course, is the great important fundamental concept from early modern philosophy on through the Enlightenment. Kant, whom we have just spent significant time, and Hegel would have been immersed in Kant as a philosophy student, wrote the Critique of Pure Reason. Then he wrote the Critique of Practical Reason. Reason, it's all the way through. But what we understand, of course, is that when people use the word reason, they're no

longer meaning the same thing by it. And that is partly going to be indicated here by the capital letter Reason, "R" in front of Reason.

- 7.27** Now, partly this is an artifact of the German language, which tends to capitalize proper nouns. But in philosophy, anytime you see a proper noun or a noun capitalized, that typically is significant, that they're trying to say that there is going to be reason as we might ordinarily understand it—your reason, our reason, my reason, and so forth. Reason with a capital R is going to be something bigger, the same sort of way when we say we use pronouns—he, she, it, and so forth. But if we want to say "he" in some significant metaphysical way, we capitalize it, "He", and then we're talking about something more elevated, a divine or a godlike kind of being. So being aware of capitalizations is going to be important.
- 7.28** Now, this sounds like an Enlightenment formulation. "Reason is the sovereign of the world." Reason governs the world. OK, interesting. What do we mean, then, by Reason? "It is there proved by speculative cognition, that Reason—this term may suffice us, without investigating the relation sustained by the universe to the divine being—is substance, as well as infinite power, its own infinite material underlying all the natural and spiritual life which it originates, as also the infinite form, which sets this material in motion."
- 7.29** So, that's Reason. It is substance, infinite power, infinite material, infinite form. So, right off the bat, so to speak, we know that Hegel is not talking about my reason. My reason is not infinite. It's not talking about your reason. I'm going to guess that your reason is not infinite, either. It's not infinitely powerful. Our reason individually is finitely powerful. You can only think about a certain number of things. We get tired, we get mistakes. There's a limit to our power. And it's not certainly an infinite material. It's underlying all the natural and spiritual life, we would say, as individuals. Well, mine is part, perhaps, of individual and spiritual life. So, we are talking about a grand metaphysical reason, some sort of spirit, some sort of substance, something that is much more divine.
- 7.30** And when Hegel then says that Reason is governing and sovereign of the world, that's the kind of reason that we have in mind here. "It is exclusively its own basis of existence and absolute final aim. It is also the energizing power, realizing this aim." So we have to understand Reason. So if we think of all of reality as a giant mind or as a giant spirit, but it's a rational mind or a rational spirit, it is not dependent upon anything else. It is its own basis of existence. So, it's not dependent or coming into existence basing on something. It's the original source and foundation. It's also its own ultimate end. And it also is energizing itself. It doesn't need any sort of external energy source to make it move and make it do various sorts of things. So, think of a godlike being, as much as we possibly can. Now, that's a little bit premature.
- 7.31** "Reason," this is the next point, "reveals itself in the world." So it is what it is, but then it does something in the world. It realizes itself in the world, and then it comes to be

aware of itself as a result of what it has done in the world, and so becomes a little more knowing, a little more development. Now this, then, he goes on to say, "sounds like a religious truth," and it is a kind of religious truth. And traditional religion has tried to capture this understanding of the world, but I want to make it more up-to-date—I, being Hegel, philosophically. "Providence controls the world." It's not just random groping, random happenstance. There is a plan. There is a providence.

7.32 So, "the truth then, that a providence, that of God, presides over the events of the world— divine providence is wisdom, endowed with an infinite power which realizes its aim, namely, the absolute rational design of the world." So it wants to realize and make possible this rational design of the world. And then, having done so, fully realize itself as the being that made that possible and come to a full self-realization of its identity. "Reason is thought conditioning itself with perfect freedom." OK, now, the language is hard. We have a strong suggestion here that, when we're again talking about reason and individuality, we're not talking about us as human individuals. This is a much more collectivized notion. So we're not interested in the desires of individuals. So, all of those earlier philosophers who put the individual as the unit of reality, as the unit of moral significance, that's going to go by the wayside.

7.33 What we are interested in as God, providence, this ultimate Reason, is working its way through, its instruments are collectives, social units. "In the history of the world, the individuals we have to do with are peoples, totalities that are states." So, collectivized individuals. And so, we will talk about the German identity, and we're not talking about particular Germans. We're talking about the Germans collected into a unity that is a real, then collective, individual. "I have touched implicitly upon the prominent question of the day, that of the possibility of knowing God; or rather, since public opinion has ceased to allow it to be a matter of question, the doctrine that it is impossible to know God."

7.34 Now, who is Hegel talking about right here? "The question of the day." Hegel is writing in 1806 and on through the next years, early 1800s. He is talking about Immanuel Kant, who has just died in 1804, and Kant's doctrines have conquered the German intellectual world. And the idea that it is impossible to know God, because God is out there in the noumenal world, and our knowledge is limited to our phenomenal construction. So he is taking this Kantian idea, and saying—he's putting us in a position of skepticism here, saying that we cannot come to know God. "The doctrine that it is impossible to know God." And then Hegel is saying, look, we cannot accept this. "In direct contravention of what is commanded in the holy scripture as the highest duty."

7.35 What are we supposed to be doing as religious people? What are we supposed to be doing as philosophers, coming to know reality? And if reality is ultimately God, then that means, "We should not merely love, but know God." So I'm not going to give up on this quest, despite the prominence of Kantian philosophy. And what that then is to say is, if Kant has said, we can't get there by reason, with that old-fashioned understanding

of what reason is, then we need to get there somewhere else. And maybe what we need to do is collectivize and re-understand what reason is in this more divine providential fashion. Because if, for example, my individual reason is just a fragment of this divine reason, then perhaps I can come to know God through myself, because we are made of the same stuff, so to speak. I am a part of the divine collectiveness.

7.36 He says this is also morally dangerous. "While the divine being is thus placed beyond our knowledge"—if we tell everybody, God, you can't know him; he's beyond all human knowledge—"outside the limit of all human things," well, then "we have the convenient license of wandering as far as we list, in the direction of our own fancies." If Kant is right, then he's just telling everyone, "Just do whatever you feel like, just do whatever you want." And so it's not only violating the, so to speak, the cognitive commandment of philosophy to know reality, it's going to turn us into immoral, subjectivist kinds of beings. So, "I have been unwilling to leave out of sight the connection between our thesis—that reason governs the world and has governed the world—and the question of the possibility of a knowledge of God." And so, therefore, "our mode of treating the subject, in this aspect, is a Theodicaea," a theodicy.

7.37 That's what we're trying to do. We're trying to, so to speak, reconnect this apparent thesis, right? God is unknowable, but we know this world. We have another thesis, antithesis there. God is good, but the world we are in is evil. We have another thesis, antithesis there as well. How do we solve this problem? Why, if God is this ultimately powerful being, we do find, in fact, all of this evil in the world? And he makes no bones about it. When we look at the world, we look at history. It is a nasty, nasty story. "History is a slaughter-bench, at which the happiness of peoples, the wisdom of states, and the virtue of individuals have been victimized." Why does God let so much terribleness happen in the world? "To what final aim these enormous sacrifices have been offered?" God is all-powerful. The world is a slaughter-bench. How do we put this together?

7.38 One suggestion is, we need to set aside a certain kind of moral reflections, a certain kind of moralizing and ethical repugnance. "We have all along purposely eschewed moral reflections as a method of rising from the scene of historical specialties," etc., etc. So this common notion of people doing history and philosophical history, and looking at the world empirically, and saying, "This is bad, this is terrible," and then just generalizing to some position of disgust with the world or cynicism about the world. That's not what we are going to do. That's putting your personal moral evaluations at the fore. Instead, what we need to do is step outside of our personal moral reflections and try to take a more God's-eye view of what's going on in the world. We have to see the historical special things in the light of the general principles which they embody.

7.39 OK, now, this is this theodicy problem. We're going to understand God as a process of coming from a state of lower consciousness to higher consciousness, from unconscious to more conscious. "The whole process of history is directed to rendering this

unconscious impulse a conscious one." So God, in his infancy, so to speak, has an impulse, and he externalizes that, and he becomes more and more conscious as he externalizes his impulses, and they are realized in the world. And so, that then is to say that we should understand even the particular events that are going on in the world as not fully themselves realizing the significance of what they are doing, that in part they need to learn the significance of what seems to be a terrible thing right now in the light of a larger aim. But they also then become more close to understanding the mind of God as it is working out.

7.40 Now, what Hegel then wants to argue is that the way divine providence does this is it operates at the level of whole states. And so we can see, it's the Greeks versus the Persians. It's the Romans versus the Scythians. There are all of these colliding totalities of people. And it's natural for us then to write the history of the world in terms of those states, but treating them as individuals that have their own ends and goals through history, and Hegel was perfectly happy with that. But at the same time, these states don't have everybody equally participating and contributing to the process. And so what Hegel wants to argue is that God chooses certain individuals for certain special purposes.

7.41 Now, we're familiar with this idea from religious history, that God chooses prophets and has special communication with them, visits revelations upon them, that are then significant for their people, and then become the collective identity of those people, the organizing principle. But typically, we don't see the military leaders who are creating the slaughter-bench of history as doing the work of God, so to speak. We say they're bad guys; they are conquerors. Or we might sneakily admire them and say, "I wish I could be Napoleon or Alexander the Great." But what Hegel wants to do is embrace such individuals. And these are the ones he's going to call world historical individuals. And they are individuals who are in a state, but they assume positions of power and significance, such that they take that whole people in a certain direction.

7.42 Now they, of course, might think that they're just doing their own thing, having their own personal ambitions, but really, they are tools being used by divine providence to take the world in a certain direction. So, Caesar here is mentioned as one such example. "Such individuals," like Caesar, "had no consciousness of the general idea they were unfolding, while prosecuting their aims. On the contrary, they were just practical, political men. But at the same time, they were thinking men, who had an insight into the requirements of the time—what was ripe for the development." And then we go on to have another example, Alexander the Great. And then the more recent example, Napoleon. And it also then points out a historically interesting point, that they all died relatively young. Alexander in his thirties. Caesar was assassinated, I think, in his fifties, but he had a lot of time still ahead of him. And Napoleon was marginalized, also in his prime.

- 7.43 This idea here is, I am, so to speak, the divine providence. I'm using these individuals for a purpose. Once they've accomplished their purposes—they've conquered the world, they've created a dictatorship in Rome, such as going in an imperial direction, Napoleon has basically conquered Europe, North Africa, and so on—their work is done. History discards them, sets them to the side, and they die. Now, how should we morally evaluate them? And we say, well, look, they just killed a lot of people. They destroyed other societies, in many cases. They allowed their soldiers to rape all sorts of people and take whatever it is that they want. These are bad people; they are immoral individuals.
- 7.44 And what Hegel wants to argue is, we need to get away from that individualistic understanding, that people have moral dignity and perhaps ethical rights, and that what we want to do in politics is have our leaders respect their rights and so on. All of that Enlightenment stuff. Hegel wants to say, "That's just the wrong perspective." What happens as a result of God realizing his aim? That's the perspective. Whatever's necessary for God to get where he needs to get to, and if numbers of people need to be slaughtered and abused, that's the way it is.
- 7.45 So this language here. "So mighty a form," that is to say, these world historical individuals, "must trample down many an innocent flower." So, all those innocent flowers who get trampled, that's just tough. "Crush to pieces many an object in its path." And notice what he's saying. Look, we're just talking about phenomenal beings. "It is phenomenal being that is so treated." That's a lower order of being. And of this, part of—sorry, "part is of no value. The particular," particular individuals, "is for the most part of too trifling a value as compared with the general. Individuals are sacrificed and abandoned. Individual life," each of us, each of you as individuals, "is essentially subordinated to that of man," the more collective entity, "and is to be used as an instrument."
- 7.46 And thus we have solved the problem of evil. "This good, this Reason, in its most concrete form, is God. God governs the world. The actual working of his government, the carrying out of his plan, is the history of the world." He works through states. States are the proper level of analysis. It's not individuals with their rights, their freedoms, their goals and so forth. It is states—whole collectivized peoples that God is using. "The essential being is the union of the subjective with the rational will. It is the moral whole, the state, which is that form of reality in which the individual has and enjoys his freedom, but on the condition of his recognition, believing in and willing that which is common to the whole."
- 7.47 So to be a moral person in the proper sense is going to be to merge your individuality with the whole, to do what the state requires, because the state is the vehicle through which God is realizing this plan. And of course, God is choosing particular individuals, Napoleons, Caesars, Alexanders, in order to realize his will. So you, as an individual, have an obligation to obey what those world historical individuals do. "The state is the

actually existing, realized moral life. It must further be understood"—this is a very strong statement—"all the worth which the human being possesses, all the spiritual reality, he possesses only through the state."

- 7.48** So we have now a complete inversion of that Enlightenment politics that had been developed from Bacon and Locke and Voltaire on to Jefferson and the Declaration of Independence. Olympe de Gouges in France, with her declarations of the rights of women and men, that it is individuals who have their own lives, their own purposes, their own rights, and their own individual freedoms, and that we should understand the state as the servant of individuals protecting their rights. We are now flipping that to the exact opposite. Individuals have no significance except to the extent that they merge themselves with the collective and do what they are told in the state. And that's how you realize your true reality and your true moral purpose.
- 7.49** "The state is the divine idea as it exists on earth." So again, this Enlightenment idea that we're going to separate church and state, we're going to separate religion and politics. That also, as an Enlightenment thesis, is rejected. And now we're into the Counter-Enlightenment. We need to merge religion and the state because they are serving the same ultimate end, and they are both necessary. "On this account, the state rests on religion," and we come to the end. This is the true theodicy, the justification of God, in history.
- 7.50** Now I want to move on immediately to Karl Marx. Marx is in the next generation. He's a PhD in philosophy. He wrote his thesis and many early essays on Hegel. And so he's well versed in Hegelian philosophy. And one accurate but kind of flip way of saying—this is borrowing from Friedrich Engels, who is Karl Marx's sometimes co-author—is to say that what Marx did was flip Hegel on his head. That, what do you mean by that, is a metaphysical point, that what we see in the case of Hegel is we have this dialectical process that's pretty self-realizing. It goes through a lot of conflict. A lot of people get sacrificed, and there are revolutions and there are certain individuals. But all of it is seen as ultimately a spiritual process, that it's the spiritual that is primary. And whatever we call this material, phenomenal world, it's just the vehicle through which, ultimately, those spiritual forces are working.
- 7.51** Marx is going to flip that around and say that, ultimately, it is material forces that are operative. So he is a physicalist, or he is a materialist, in a particularly strong reductive form. And so that's why, a little bit later, he's going to argue that his form of politics, the socialism, the communism, is scientific socialism. And what he means by the scientific part is that it is not about gods and spirits and all of these mysterious forces and so on. It's about matter. It's about physical reality, things that we can verify and so on. It's going to be a scientific.
- 7.52** But I want also to suggest that the divide between scientific Marxism and religious Marxism is not so clear. There's a couple of interesting early poems that Marx wrote that I want to just share a couple of excerpts for you, where he seems to be much more

of a romantic poet-type of person, but also with a lot of angst. We might just write this off as just teenage angst and alienation and so forth. But there do, at the same time, seem to be some seeds of what is in the mature Marx. This notion about conflict and stress and the necessity for a great deal of destruction in order to realize whatever one's aims are in life. So this is from a poem he wrote in 1836 as still a young man.

- 7.53** "Worlds I would destroy forever. Since I can create no world, since my call, they notice never, coursing dumb into magic whirl." Now that's poetic language. But if we put it in simple English, you're saying, I can't create a world. I'm not a creative person. Maybe I'm a frustrated artist or whatever. "My call, they never notice." Nobody pays attention to me. I'm socially alienated. And this fills me with certain feelings. I would just like to see worlds destroyed forever. What we make of that?
- 7.54** Next year. "I plunge, plunge without fail, my blood-black saber." Saber, a type of thick weapon. "Into your soul that art God neither wants nor wists. It leaps to the brain from hell's black mists, till heart's bewitched, till senses reel. With Satan I have struck my deal." Now high, religious, romantic language and certain amount of alienation and conflict and willingness to do violence and destruction.
- 7.55** Jumping a couple of decades later to 1848. Actually, 1848 is when the Communist Manifesto is published. And this is a work that brings Marx a great deal of notice. 1848 is another very important date in European history. But right toward the end of 1847, his co-author, Friedrich Engels, just before his publication, is suggesting in this, interestingly, in this letter to Marx about the Communist Manifesto, which is now in manuscript form, a title change. And what he suggests is, "Give a little thought to the Confession of Faith," which is the title of the Communist Manifesto at this point, the working title. "I think we would do best to abandon the catechetical form," which is a more religiously rooted rhetorical form, "and call the thing Communist Manifesto."
- 7.56** So this line between religion and materialistic philosophy, between being scientific and being feeling-based in the early Marx, anyways, it's not very clear, and it's an interesting thing for further discussion. OK, all of that said by way of preamble, what I really want to focus on in our time here is on the Marx, the philosopher, the mature philosopher. A lot of this earlier, more autobiographical stuff can be integrated a little bit later. But the way in which Marx's political and economic ideas, for which he is most famous, turn on underlying philosophy.
- 7.57** And just to highlight what those philosophical presuppositions are, first point is that Marx is a determinist. If we are operating in the natural world, in the physical world, he takes the lesson of science and philosophy to be, that leaves no room for free will. The world is material. Material operates, the world operates according to the laws of physics, chemistry, biology, and so forth. And that is deterministic, ultimately. And that's then going to apply to human beings and to their social organization. So society is going to develop in a deterministic fashion. As we know from the politics, it's necessarily going to go from a tribal stage, to a feudal stage, to a capitalist phase, to a

dictatorship of the proletariat stage, to a withering-away of the state, to communism. And there is no will, there's no options. Things necessarily have to go this way.

- 7.58** So, "it is a question of these laws themselves, of these tendencies working with iron necessity towards inevitable results. The country that is more developed industrially only to show to the less developed the image of its own future." So all nations of the world are going along the same developmental process as built into. "Why, though, is violence necessary?" One of the interesting things is, of course, all of the Enlightenment liberals are talking about respecting other people's rights and tolerating and not using and putting limitations on the power of the state and on the power of churches and so forth to do what they want, to maximize the amount of freedom. If we can't work out a deal, we just have to go our separate ways and tolerate each other differently.
- 7.59** Socialists, many of them, early ones following Rousseau, will want to say that we should be able to bring about some sort of socialism also through peaceful means, maybe through a democratic process, and so on. And one of the signal things in Marxism is a consistent rejection of any of that. It has to be a revolution. The revolution has to be violent. Why so? And there are philosophical reasons for that. Now, here's the claim that it has to be violent. This is Marx writing again in 1848, the same year as Communist Manifesto. "There is only one means, only one, to curtail, simplify, and localize the bloody agony of the old society and the bloody birth pangs of the new. Only one means—the revolutionary terror."
- 7.60** Now, at this point, we're seeing a certain trend from Rousseau, who's willing to use violence, to the Jacobins, who were disciples of Rousseau, and their willingness to use violence and terror. Now, two generations into Marx, in his version, also signaling necessarily revolution requires blood and a lot of terror. His co-author Engels, writing, "The next world war will result in the disappearance from the face of the earth not only of reactionary classes and dynasties, but also of entire reactionary peoples." Entire classes, entire peoples are going to be wiped over, and this is a good thing. "That, too, is a step forward."
- 7.61** Now, why the necessity for blood? Here's the quotation about turning Hegel on his head. If we understand materialistically the way the dialectic process goes, the materialistic process deterministically means we end up in settling our differences only by force. Now, this then, is to say, if the world is deterministic, how are we going to understand human beings? Because it seems like, as a human being, I have my own ideas, I make my own choices, and I don't necessarily have to resolve my differences with you by means of violence and so forth. Marx wants to argue that all of that is phenomenal and epiphenomenal. Your sense that you have agency and freedom is ultimately an illusion. What is really going on is, you are being driven by underlying forces.

- 7.62 Now, this is an implication of the determinism. So one way he works this out is the religion point, where he wants to argue a contrary to Hegel's more religion-friendly approach to philosophy. We should see religion as epiphenomenal, as a merely superficial force upon it. Because human beings don't have any essence. There is no such thing as a human being with its own in-built identity, a human nature that is going to work its way out. Instead, human beings are pretty thoroughly tabula rasa, more plastic, such that whatever physical environment, material environment, they are born into, it shapes them into what they are. And being shaped into a certain kind of being, your ideas, including your religious ideas, are just going to be an outgrowth of that.
- 7.63 So if we imagine people in earlier tribal societies, if they live in places where they hunt lots of animals, their religion is driven by their material circumstances. All of their divine beings are animated versions or divine versions of the lion spirit or the zebra spirit, or whatever it happens to be. If they happen to live by the sea, and their material circumstances are that they make a living by, from the sea, then they have lots of water gods and water divinities, and they then will divine-ize, or make religious significance, those sorts of beings. Religion is a reflection of underlying material circumstances.
- 7.64 In the case of modern-world Catholicism, with its hierarchy, where we have priests and bishops and archbishops and so on, all the way up to the Pope, the Marxist interpretation is to say that that hierarchical structure in religion is really just a reflection of the underlying political and economic reality of the times, which was feudalism, where you have the serfs and the slaves, and then the peasants and then the craftspeople, the lords, and all the way up to the king. So that's the reality, physically. Materialistically, the religion is just a reflection of that.
- 7.65 When we get into the early capitalism, the argument is going to be, with its idea that people are all individuals and free agents and doing their own thing, buying and selling and trading with each other in this decentralized fashion. It makes sense the Marxists will argue that religion will shift to be more like the Protestants, because the Protestants want to emphasize that we're all individuals doing our own thing with respect to religion. "And I joined this church for a while, but I don't like it. So I go over here and I start my own church." And religion then is just a reflection of capitalistic practice. So we are inverting Hegel. It's the material that is fundamental, the spiritual that is secondary.
- 7.66 "The phantoms formed in the human brain"—notice, that's our ideas. They're just phantoms—"are also, necessarily, sublimates of their material life process, which is empirically verifiable and bound to material premises. Morality, religion, metaphysics, all the rest of ideology and their corresponding forms of consciousness, thus no longer retain the semblance of independence." Your thinking is not independent. It's totally dependent on the material circumstances in which you find yourself. "Life is not determined by consciousness," at the end of that section. It's not that I have ideas, my

consciousness, and I try to externalize that. Make my dreams real. Rather, consciousness by life.

7.67 So, we are all constructed by our social circumstances, our political, but more primarily, our economic circumstances. "As individuals express their life, so they are. What they are," that is to say, your nature, "therefore coincides with their production, both with what they produce and with how they produce. The nature of individuals thus depends on the material conditions determining their production." So you're born in the peasantry. You live as a peasant. That then is to say, your lifestyle is the peasant lifestyle. All of your thinking, all of your values, all of your ideas are conditioned by your life as a peasant.

7.68 You're born into the skilled craftspeople class. Different lifestyle, different values, different ideas, different thinking. You're born into the aristocracy. Same thing, different material circumstances, different values, different ideas, different religion, different philosophy. And it's all social. You're not an individual because you are born into a society in which your material conditions of production are set by the time you are born. You are born to be a peasant, and you are conditioned to become a peasant. "Activity and mind are social in their content as well as in their origin. They are a social activity and social mind."

7.69 And so, if we really want to understand who we are as individuals, and again, phenomenally, superficially, we might think we have our own ideas and our own goals and dreams. Marx wants to argue none of that is true. "Man is a unique individual." Phenomenally, we can identify and see each other as unique individuals. "And it is just his particularity which makes him an individual—a really individual communal being." You really are a communal being. You are part of the society, part of the community. Conditioned by it. Serving a function within that community as it realizes its aims. And so we have to understand, this is why the word socialism is not primarily a political concept. For Marx, it's primarily a metaphysical concept. It is social-ism. That's your true identity as a human being, not individualism.

7.70 "The human essence is no abstraction inherent in each single individual." That is to say, it's not essentially you, that you have your own mind, and you have your own ideas and your own goals and your own dreams. Or, in religious formulation, that you have your own unique soul that is special. And the care and ultimate destiny of your individual soul ultimately matters. None of that is real. Those things do not exist. "In its reality, it is the ensemble of the social relations." You are the collection, the ensemble of the social relations. You are a vehicle through which society happens to be congregating. And so, this notion that we get out of Enlightenment liberalism, that we should have individuals with their freedoms, and, for example, also with their property rights. I make my own stuff. I control my own stuff. I have my own family. All of that also needs to go.

- 7.71 The politics follows. Communism is "the positive transcendence of private property, etc.—the complete return of man to himself as a social being." Eliminate the privacy, eliminate the individuality and social relations. People will realize their true communal nature. Now, we still are trying to get to the violence. Why does all this require revolutionary violence? Well, we're getting there, closer and closer. Now we come to this thesis about whether there is one story that runs through history. Is there a single plan of God working its way out? Is there a single set of scientific laws of cause and effect that we capture in principles? And then we understand the scientific, natural process in terms of one true theory, about how the universe is going to go.
- 7.72 An implication of this, then, is for Marx and earlier for Hegel, that logic is plural. There are logics. Because what is logic? Logic is a set of ideas in our mind about what we're going to believe and do, and the inferences that we make. But if we have different societies and different individuals in different social circumstances, and those different social circumstances generate different kinds of ideas, different kinds of values, different kinds of beliefs, different kinds of religions, then you're going to have contradictory philosophies, contradictory ideologies out there. And there's no way for them, rationally, to adjudicate their differences. Because what they think of as rational is totally determined by and dictated by their economic circumstances that they're raised in.
- 7.73 The way these people think and value is in contradiction to the way these people think and value. They have their logic. They have their logic. And there's no way for these people to step outside of their conditioning and look at the world the way these people look at it. There's no way for these people to step outside of their beliefs and their conditioning to look at the world the way these people look at it. All we have is different logics and no way to adjudicate between the two of them. Reason is now impotent in this kind of social circumstance.
- 7.74 So, the idea then, what we need to do is just get together and have good discussions and resolve our differences. Pipe dream. It's not possible. The idea that somehow we can have a democratic republic, that the way we're going to think about politics is we're going to get people together. We're going to have lots of arguments about all sorts of things, and people will change their minds. I voted for this guy. Now I can see he's not really working out. I'm going to change my vote, and I'm going to vote for this other sort of person over here. Or that you can convince my mind, to change my mind, on some sort of public policy. No, that's just completely impossible.
- 7.75 If we have two different societies, two different cultures, two different social groups with radically different ideas, different logics, and they are in contradiction with each other, there's only one way now for them to resolve that conflict. Not reason, violence. Someone has to use force and prevail. So Marx has some harsh things to say about Jews and capitalists, as we know. In our language, he sees the Jews as the modern representatives of premodern philosophy, the old ways of thinking. But that's been just

socially conditioned into this group of people for a long time. So they are completely alien culture. And there's nothing in Judaism that favors communism from his perspective, where he wants to go, that particular ideology.

7.76 We also have this modern philosophical system, this Enlightenment liberalism, that prizes individualism and freedom and toleration and so on. Obviously, they don't like the old Jewish and other ancient religions and their way of doing so. There's this collision between the premodern way of thinking and the modern way of thinking. And then Marx wants to argue, we are another group of people with a completely different philosophical way of understanding the world, and the logic of history is taking us in a certain direction. Necessarily, it has to be a physicalistic, violent contradiction, resolution that happens. Let's see if I can get this to work here.

7.77 I want to wrap then, by saying, we now have gone, in the space of a couple of lectures, from the height of the Enlightenment—Locke, Voltaire, Diderot and the others —and their aspirations for not only a new kind of philosophy, but a new kind of society. There's going to be, ultimately, ideals captured in the declarations of independence, declaration of the rights of man and citizen, to a skeptical, collectivized, more irrationalistic undercutting of all of the fundamental principles of the Enlightenment. To some extent, the door is opened by Kant, but now we find Hegel and Marx marching through that open door and taking philosophy in a completely different direction. Now, Enlightenment is still motoring on in philosophy and in the sciences and politics and economics as well, which is largely why the 19th century was such a fascinating and complicated century of things going on.

7.78 There's also a religious resurgence that comes on after Kant. If we can't get to God through reason, we should try to get to God through feeling, through sentiment. And there's a resurgence of a new kind of premodern religion in the modern world. Various great awakenings. But our questions for the next session are going to be these ones here. After the Enlightenment has reached its height, after we are now educated people in the middle part of the 1800s, we're aware of Kant, we're aware of Hegel, we're aware of Marx and these various other currents. Do the Enlightenment thinkers and the liberals have a response? How vigorous is that response? Or if we are already post-Enlightenment and happy with being post-Enlightenment, have we gone far enough in rejecting the Enlightenment? And when we turn next to John Stuart Mill and Friedrich Nietzsche, we'll take up that story.

Lecture 8: Liberal or Anti-Liberal?

At a glance — Liberal or anti-liberal?

- 8.1** We have been beating up on the Enlightenment. Kant, putting limits to its aspirations, opening certain other doors that Hegel and Marx march through. But it is also true to say that the Enlightenment was still a significant, and continues to be, actually, a significant intellectual, cultural, economic, and political force. What we are looking at is the philosophers, often in abstraction, arguing about the big concepts that may or may not be applied. But for more than two centuries, the buildup to the Enlightenment had generated a huge amount of intellectual energy, moral fervor, and the Enlightenment did continue to animate large numbers of intellectuals and continue to revolutionize and reform elements in society.
- 8.2** I want to start, in this session, with the year 1859, which is one of the most important years in human history for publishing. Amazing number of works that we all will recognize, published in 1859, from Charles Dickens, Florence Nightingale, Samuel Smiles, and others, some of whom we will be talking about today. But I want to talk a little bit initially about what the Enlightenment has been doing in developing the sciences, physics, chemistry, biology, perhaps the beginnings of psychology. All of the modern sciences we now recognize coming to maturity. Women's liberation, the battles against slavery, going full force, both of them, women as second-class citizens, slaves as subordinate, semi-human social status human beings, obvious affronts to Enlightenment aspirations for respect, for the liberty and equality of all individuals, and seeing everyone as a potentially rationally self-governing free agent.
- 8.3** 1859. On that battle against slavery front, slavery had been increasingly a thorn in the side, a stick in the eye of everybody. Anti-slavery societies had been founded in America, in France, and in Britain. In the 1780s, there had been the great compromise with respect to the founding of the United States. But anti-slavery continued to be an increasingly important issue in the Americas. The British had passed various acts limiting and then abolishing slavery in various forms. And by the time we get to 1859, the British navy has been active for decades trying to suppress the slave trade all around the African coast, with increasing success. 1859, in the American context, was the year of John Brown's raid at Harpers Ferry. One of the great anti-slavery initiatives in the lead-up to what became the Civil War.
- 8.4** 1859 is, in microbiology and chemistry, Louis Pasteur and the germ theory of disease. The idea that many illnesses that beset us, that would have been mysterious in what their causes are, and what we could do—we can now understand them as tiny microbes and other forms of life that are bad for us. We can see them with these new microscopes that we are developing and, with scientific method, develop various ways to kill them without killing the healthy organism cells. Great advances.

- 8.5 Part and parcel of other medical advances in anatomy, microbiology, anesthesia, which is going to open up entire possibility of surgery, so that you can put people to sleep, so the shock of pain of surgery doesn't kill people outright. And then better understandings of antiseptic and developing of various sorts of antiseptics, so that, after surgery, people aren't beset by diseases. And due to all of these advances in all of these fields, we start to see dramatic increases in life expectancy. Scientific method undergirded by reason, empirical, experimental investigation, dedication to the improvement of life, all of those Baconian themes still going strong 250 years later.
- 8.6 Also 1859, this book, Charles Darwin, *Origin of Species*, landmark work, huge amounts of empirical biology behind it, lots of logical analysis, a great deal of experimentalism, with domestic breeding of animals, all of that integrated into a new evolutionary theory by Charles Darwin. Scientifically, a huge landmark. And also philosophically, one of the themes we're going to see is philosophers grappling with this new understanding of the world and our place in it, in the light of evolutionary theory. "We need to stop," many philosophers will be saying, "thinking in terms of there is a single eternal being that created the world exactly as it is, gave us a special place in that world, setting certain rules in place that hold for all time, to a more flexible, changing, evolving understanding of the world of human beings and our place in it."
- 8.7 Now, Darwin, obviously not just a scientific theory, but very early, we find political implications debated hotly, not just religious implications. What does this mean for our understanding of God, God as creator, human beings as having a soul, but what we should be doing with respect to society if we are now going to be modern and scientific. Does this mean that we should allow the government, if we're going to empower the government, to improve the condition of human beings? That the government, so to speak, treats its citizens the way farmers treat their animals? That it only allows the healthy bulls and cows to breed with each other, so to speak, and it doesn't allow the less fit ones to breed? That's an immediate implication that some embraced.
- 8.8 Does it mean that we should see human beings, like other species, as divided into different species, with different capacities and traits, including psychological capacities and traits? And so, we need to have a different evaluation of this group of humans compared to this group of humans, underscored by their different biological evolutionary histories? Or is it the lesson that what evolution teaches us is that what we call a species and its identity and its nature is malleable? It can be changed over time if it is subject to different environmental circumstances, and so what we can do with proper government policy is mold and remold human beings into what we desire them to be.
- 8.9 Does it mean that nature teaches us that life is a struggle for resources, and it's the strongest that survive and the weakest that go out of business, so to speak? Or in the business of life, and we apply that to the marketplace, and say that the good of society

is going to be by allowing the weaker businesses to go out of business and the stronger businesses to continue? So, as scientific idea, Darwinian evolutionary theory, with huge philosophical roots behind it, as having huge implications for religion, politics, and all of that, is to be engaged over the next century.

- 8.10** Now, today, we're going to focus on two figures, a British thinker and a German thinker. And then partly that's going to be a sub-theme here today. But also, one thinker is pro-Enlightenment, the other anti-Enlightenment. That will be a second theme, and one strongly liberal, one strongly anti-liberal, and that will be a cultural political theme. Now, a couple of lines from Friedrich Nietzsche. He was born in 1844. Partly, I want to flag that Nietzsche was born in 1844, and he's one of these precocious individuals, extraordinarily brilliant, extraordinarily well read, even as a teenager, which means that he is reading everything. And he also is aware of Darwinian ideas, because, when he was 15, that's when *Origin of Species*. And one important theme for him in his philosophy is then rethinking philosophy in the light of some sort of evolutionary understanding of the cosmos.
- 8.11** But nationalism, and nationalism not just as a political, cultural, economic concept, is significant, increasingly. And lines like this from Nietzsche are important. Here, philosophy starts to be couched in nationalistic terms, that perhaps people's philosophies are expressions not of their individual thinking, but of their national, communal, collective, cultural experiences. And Nietzsche is signaling with a line like this, that we know what the Enlightenment is philosophically, and we know what the Counter-Enlightenment is philosophically, and that the essential German way of doing philosophy is anti-Enlightenment.
- 8.12** That's a very strong claim. It's not to say that there aren't some German philosophers who are in favor of the Enlightenment. There were, but he's making a claim that, from Kant to Hegel to Marx, we would include Schopenhauer, whom we don't have time for, unfortunately, and now Nietzsche himself, it's a Counter-Enlightenment trend. And then, by contrast, what do we say about these English? Because we know the names Bacon and Hobbes and Locke and Hume and the others and so forth, all of those Englishmen. Actually, Hume is a Scotsman. But all those British thinkers. Notice what we say here, scornfully and dismissively. Friedrich Nietzsche.
- 8.13** "They are no philosophical race, these Englishmen. Bacon signifies an attack on the philosophical spirit. Hobbes, Hume, and Locke, a debasement and a lowering of the value of the concept of philosophy for more than a century." And then Nietzsche is also the best name-caller in, I think, the entire history of philosophy. He's a brilliant rhetorician. "But I am told they are just old, cold, tedious frogs." So we have Enlightenment versus Counter-Enlightenment, England versus Germany, the great philosophical collision. And for those interested in projecting philosophical history, if we think about 20th-century history, English versus German, Enlightenment versus

Counter-Enlightenment, some seeds are being laid or planted for some other significant later developments.

- 8.14** Now, by contrast, here's John Stuart Mill, speaking in Enlightenment mode. We have now freed the world as much as we possibly can. We're trying to free the slaves, we are freeing the women, we are increasingly freeing individual human beings such that even all men can now vote, as the 1800s go on. We are free in our religion, we have free participation in political governance, and we have free trade and capitalism developing and so forth. And this is taking us in a direction of greater peacefulness. And we start to have an articulation of what is sometimes called the liberal peace theory, or the capitalist peace theory, that liberal societies like to respect and tolerate differences. And they don't go to war over little things. It's very hard to get them to go to war.
- 8.15** Or capitalist nations, they want to trade with each other. My vendors are over in that nation. My customers are over in that nation. In order for me to continue to make my profits, I want peace, because the first thing that happens, as soon as war happens, is all of those trading relationships go away. So we're bringing the world together in a free, prosperous, and tolerant way. "Commerce," the way John Stuart Mill puts it, "first taught nations to see with good will the wealth and prosperity of another. Before, the patriot wished all countries weak, poor, and ill-governed, but his own." It's a win-win. "It is commerce which is rapidly rendering war obsolete. And it may be said without exaggeration that the great extent and rapid increase of international trade is the great permanent security for the uninterrupted progress of the ideas, institutions, and the character of the human race."
- 8.16** So let's carry on this Enlightenment agenda, individualism, liberty, tolerance, and we will now extend that internationally and create a giant, tolerant, free-trade zone. And we will be peaceful. And it is interesting if we look at this. 1848. This is now a couple of generations since Napoleon has been confined. The Napoleonic wars have ended in 1815, and Europe has been surprisingly relatively at peace, in contrast to many centuries of war between each other, the English and the French, the French and the Spanish, and various other groups that were constantly back and forth at war. Now they are seemingly peaceful and trading with each other. Can we project this, not just philosophically, but as a cultural trend? So we want to go in a peaceful direction. But of course, what we have just seen in Hegel and Marx is the idea of conflict suppression, the slaughter-bench, violence, as absolutely necessary. So definitely there's a different tendency in the one tradition compared to the other.
- 8.17** Now, 1859, again, that significant year is the year John Stuart Mill publishes one of his most famous works, called *On Liberty*, and it's an extension of the Enlightenment project. But what he especially is noted for in this work, and this is the passages I want us to focus on as we go to each philosopher and read some of his or her own words, is his fundamental identification of free speech as important. Obviously, this has been implicit. And freedom of the press and the eliminations of censorship in the more

Enlightenment liberal nations is now an older story. But Mill wants to strengthen and deepen this argument, particularly as various sorts of reactionary forces and Counter-Enlightenment forces are trying to reintroduce censorship. So he wants it to update our understanding of what liberty is all about. Individual rights.

8.18 "Let us suppose, therefore, that the government is entirely at one with the people, and never thinks of exerting any power of coercion unless in agreement with what it conceives to be their voice." Suppose we go in this more collectivized, communal direction. We say the government should be the representative of the people, but the people united into a collective, communal being, and absolutely everybody is on the same page. And that's the ideal that we are striving for in some way. But there's a person who excepts to the tendency of going in that direction. What can they do with respect to such an individual?

8.19 "I deny the right of the people to exercise such coercion." The individualism matters, and that is fundamental. "If all mankind, minus one, were of one opinion, and only one person were of the contrary opinion, mankind would be no more justified in silencing that one person than if he, if he had the power, would be justified in silencing mankind." So a strong reiteration of this individual, universal, absolute principle of free speech. And his point is, it lays it on a spectrum. We all now in the modern world recognize, if we have one person, the king, and the king says, "I want to silence everybody who disagrees with me," we would say, "That's wrong." If we said, "Well, what if the king and the aristocrats, now 10 or 20% of the population, they all agree, and they want to silence the rest of the population?"

8.20 That would be wrong. We're democratic. We're republican. And they say, "Well, what if we're democratic in this way? What if 51% of the population, now it's a majority, wants to silence 49%?" That's wrong. What if it's 99.99% wants to silence just this one guy? That's wrong. Individuals have the right to their own free speech. I'm going to put that word "right" in quotation marks and just hold that for a little while. That's what we need to defend.

8.21 Now, in one sense, this is old news. Freedom of the press, freedom of publishing, freedom of speech, freedom of arguing, built into the parliamentary democratic process in England and other nations, very well regarded. But Mill wants to make an argument here that's important. Why is it so wrong to silence other people, not merely as a political matter, but as a social matter? Important passage here. "The peculiar evil of silencing the expression of an opinion is that it is robbing the human race, posterity as well as the existing generation. Those who dissent from the opinion, still more than those who hold. If the opinion is right, they are deprived of the opportunity of exchanging error for truth."

8.22 So, what if we're suppressing a correct opinion? Well, obviously there's a problem there. If the opinion is wrong, the one that we want to suppress, "they lose almost as great a benefit, the clearer perception and livelier impression of the truth, produced by

its collision with error." How do we learn the difference between the true and the false? It's rarely the case of just a true idea is presented to you. You see it's truth, and therefore you adopt the truth instead. Truth is in collision with error. And by comparing those two, we have a clearer perception of why the true idea is the true. So we want to have false ideas out there as part of this ongoing social process.

8.23 Now, in some sense, you can see this as an extension to the intellectual realm or the realm of ideas. What goes on in a marketplace. It's not simply the case that there is one product that is put out there, and it is perfect all by itself. That product needs to have competitors, and those competitors force it to be a little bit better. Of course, sometimes the competitor comes along and has a better idea, and we then exchange the worse or, sorry, the better product. We exchange the worse product now for the better product that has come along. But sometimes the better product is out there, and a worse product comes along. But it's by comparing those two we can really see that the better product is the better product. And of course, sometimes the worse product forces the already-better product to become even better.

8.24 So we take all of that understanding of how market economics work and transpose that into the intellectual realm. What does this imply for how I think, how we think together when we're having discussions and debates and so forth, and especially in those very important educational institutions, where we're raising children to learn how to think for themselves? We want them to get to the truth, but they have to go through a certain kind of process. Now, this is a very long chapter two in *On Liberty*. I recommend that you read it in its entirety, but I want to just give an overview. The way Mill argues is to say, look, any idea that we are thinking about censoring or suppressing falls into one of three categories. Either the idea is true, or the idea is false, or we don't know if the idea yet is true or false.

8.25 So he makes a claim about the epistemological status of all ideas. And of course, since there's hundreds and hundreds of thousands and millions of different ideas, we can't go through all of them. We want a principled way of dealing with ideas. "What happens if we censor true ideas?" will be one line of the argument. He's going to argue bad stuff happens if we censor true ideas. What happens if we censor false ideas? And this is the harder part of the argument. But he's going to argue, "Bad stuff happens even if we censor false ideas." What if, when we're in the circumstance of not yet knowing if an idea really is true or false, we're still learning, we censor ideas in that process? And the argument is going to be, "Bad stuff happens as a result of doing that." Therefore, we shouldn't censor true ideas. We shouldn't censor false ideas, and we shouldn't censor ideas of indeterminant truth status. Therefore, general, that's the strategy of the argument.

8.26 Now, first, then. "The opinion which it is attempted to suppress by authority may possibly be true." And we say, what's wrong with suppressing true ideas? What's wrong with—and we say, well, it's the obvious thing. The whole idea of thinking is to come to

know the world. It is to have true ideas about the way the world is. So partly we can understand it, but also when we take those ideas and act in the world on the basis of our ideas, we're acting on the basis of the truth, because we want to be successfully acting in the world. We run into problems in action when we believe false things and try to act on the basis of false ideas; that's where we fail in our action. So if we are suppressing true ideas, obviously we are undercutting the entire human possibility of successful action in the world.

- 8.27** Now, that's kind of an obvious point, but Mill goes on to make an historical point, and here he's also functioning as an empiricist, the importance of reading history, lots and lots of history, around various generalizations. And he goes through all the times in history, the standout cases where ideas that later came to be known as true were suppressed. What happened to Socrates in Athens and his method of teaching young people to think more philosophically? They killed him. What happened to Jesus? If you think Jesus has had some true ideas? They killed him. What happened constantly through various reformers, through the Middle Ages, with respect to religion? Many of them tortured, killed, and so on. What happened to Galileo, with his ideas about adopting the Copernican hypothesis? Censored, silenced, and so on. History is full of examples of true ideas being silenced .
- 8.28** So, we might easily adopt the idea—well, obviously, we don't want to censor true ideas, but human beings being what they are, their entire history tells us, this is a big danger we need to always be on the alert for. And it's very easy for us to think that somehow we uniquely have locked onto the truth. And if I get a little bit of power, then to start using my power on behalf of my conception of the truth, have a little intellectual modesty. Yes, you're smart. You can become smarter; you can know a lot of things. But don't ever think that you are infallible, just because of the long history of other really smart people in history who were absolutely wrong about lots and lots of things.
- 8.29** All right, now, the second division of the argument, and Mill has this charming, or not charming, depending on your rhetorical preference of saying in 25 words what could be said in eight, but let's read a little bit. "Let us now pass to the second division of the argument, and dismissing the supposition that any of the received opinions may be false, let us assume them to be true, and examine into the worth of the manner in which they are likely to be held, if their truth is not freely and openly canvassed." OK, so suppose we have ideas. It's not actually a false idea. It's a true idea, but we're going to hold it not in a way that's openly and freely canvassed. That is to say, we don't argue about it a lot. It then becomes a dogma. And what happens to our thinking, individually and socially, when we have just dogmas in our minds?
- 8.30** Especially, Mill wants to argue, "when we turn to subjects that are infinitely more complicated, to morals, religion, politics, social relations, and the business of life. Three-fourths of the arguments for every disputed opinion consist in dispelling the

appearances which favor some opinion different from it." And he goes on to point out what good lawyers do, what good rhetoricians do, when they go into a debate, or when they are going into a formalized legal system, and why, when we really are interested in truth and falsity in a legal conflict, but the matters are very complicated, what we do stylistically is encourage a freedom of speech in a certain stylized fashion, because we recognize dogma, even if you have the truth, is not going to work in that context, and we will generalize from that.

8.31 "The greatest orator, save one, of antiquity, has left it on record that he always studied his adversary's case with as great, if not with still greater, intensity than even his own. What Cicero practiced as the means of forensic success—"this is a debate, and the earlier figure is Demosthenes, the famous Greek orator. But what he is saying, "I'm going into debate. I'm going to go into a law court. My preparation on any matter of complexity means, of course, I'm going to know what side I'm trying to argue for. I'm going to know what all of the arguments are, what all the evidence it's going to be based on that I am going to marshal, and I'm going to put it in a nice, logical structure in order to make my case."

8.32 But that's only a part of the preparation, and that's the easiest part of the preparation. If I really am interested in knowing whether my position is true or not, I need to know what the other side's argument is, what conclusion that person is going to reach, what evidence he or she is going to marshal, how they are going to structure it. So I need to know both sides of those arguments really well. And actually, if I'm going to know that my position, ultimately, is the correct position, I have to know my opponent's position better than my opponent knows it, because chances are good that he or she believes it, but it's wrong. And so I have to know not only what his argument is, but why it's wrong. And what are my counterarguments to that person's arguments?

8.33 And I also know that he's going to throw lots of counterarguments at me. So I have to have a list of what all of the counterarguments are going to be against my position and how I'm going to respond to all of those counterarguments. This is hard work, and we have to, as individuals, be open to it in our own individual thinking. Any dogmatism, looking for shortcuts, just wanting to blank out certain ideas and set aside certain claims and arguments and so on, is short-circuiting the very process that makes it possible for us to know anything that is complicated. And particularly in a social context, any subversion of people entering into that process is going to make it possible for us.

8.34 Very strong claim here. "He who knows only his own side of the case knows little of that. His reasons may be good, and no one may have been able to refute them, but if he is equally unable to refute the reasons on the opposite side, if he does not so much know as what they are, he has no ground for preferring either opinion." Until you've done the work, you shouldn't have an opinion. "Nor is it enough." Now we consider an educational context. What does this apply for education? We're raising children, we're

raising adults to be thoughtful people. We want them to form a significantly reasonable philosophy of life for themselves, make big decisions about all of their careers, and be able to be the kind of people who, in a social context—family, business, other circumstances, law courts—be able to function the way rational citizens in a free society will do so.

- 8.35** We need to educate all of these people because this is a lot of work and it's very difficult training up the rational faculty for all of this. How do we educate people? And the claim here is going to be, if we have any sort of dogmatic education where there's one truth and all of the teachers are on board with that one truth and no deviance of opinion is allowed, that is not education. That is actually miseducation. So the ideal form of education, particularly on anything about which there is some controversy, is going to be to say, "It is not enough that he should hear," he being the students, "the arguments from adversaries from his own teachers, presented as they state them, and accompanied by what they offer as refutations."
- 8.36** So even if you have an open-minded, liberal education professor who says, "Yeah, here are my positions and the arguments for all of my positions," and of course there's controversy and there are these other people who believe these other things, and that person does a fair-minded attempt to reconstruct all of their arguments and make them lively and put them in—that's a good step. That's not enough. "This is not the way to do justice to the arguments or bring them into real contact with his own mind. He must be able to hear them from persons who actually believe them, who defend them in earnest, and who do their very utmost for them. He must know them in their most plausible and persuasive form."
- 8.37** So a good school, a good university, will make a point of hiring teachers and professors that they know have a diversity of opinion, so that those professors and teachers will be arguing amongst themselves throughout the course of their career. But the students will then be taking courses from all of the different professors and hear the best arguments from their most articulate true believer. That's what true education will consist in. So we're not going to censor true ideas, obviously, but we're also not going to censor false ideas, because we want lots and lots of false ideas in the mix, with all of the true ideas, so that we are constantly considering them. And new people to these ideas consider them. And then the better ideas emerge as a result of this social process.
- 8.38** But then there's that third possibility, and he wants to say, this is actually a more frequent possibility. A lot of times we don't know if an idea is true or false, and particularly when we are trying to do new, interesting things, advance the sciences, advance technologies. We don't yet know. We have to do a lot of investigating and experimenting and arguing and changing our minds and so forth. "We have hitherto considered only two possibilities, that the received opinion may be false, and some other opinion consequently true, or that, the received opinion being true, a conflict with the opposite error is essential to the clear apprehension and deeper feeling of its

truth. But there is a commoner case than either of these, when the conflicting doctrines, instead of being one true and the other false, share the truth between them; and the nonconforming opinion is needed to supply the remainder of the truth, of which the received doctrine embodies only a part."

8.39 Now that high, fancy 19th-century British language, what this boils down is to say, when we are in that circumstance, we don't yet know what the truth is. What we need is this theory and this theory, and this one might be a mixture of true and false. This one might be another mixture of true and false. It's going to be out of the collision of those ideas that we will winnow out the false elements from this one, winnow out the false elements of this one, put them together into, ultimately, a true package. Only a regime of free speech committed to by the institution, or the individuals who are participating, and the institutions as a matter of principle is going to enable us to carry on that kind of project.

8.40 Now, Mill is known as a great liberal, right, of the 19th century, and obviously, in many ways, he is carrying on that Enlightenment project, as we further go along. I want to suggest, though, in a couple of ways, where Mill is indicating a slight weakening and opening the door to other trends from Enlightenment principles. One is in his later work called, sorry, the earlier chapter which I omitted in *On Liberty*, where he says, when I'm arguing for free speech or any liberal principle, and he argues for several others, he wants to say, I'm not arguing this as a matter of abstract rights or absolute a priori types of principles. And what we find here is some influence now coming down from the Humean part of empiricism, where we are aware of various things and their practical consequences, but we're very suspicious of getting too high up the abstraction, too high up the inductive generalization ladder, and appealing to things as kind of absolute, universal truths and principles.

8.41 So, "I forego any advantage which could be derived to my argument from the idea of abstract right as a thing independent of utility." So it's not that free speech is going to be an absolute right that human beings possess by their very nature. It's going to be a matter of usefulness. It's, as a rule of thumb, as a general way things seem to be working, people function or seem to get better results if they are free speech in their orientation. It's a utility, not abstract right, that is the important thing. But that can be for a later discussion.

8.42 Another indication that there's a shift in Mill's thinking, away from a more robust Enlightenment liberalism, is his attitude toward the individual. In 1859, when he published *On Liberty*, it was very individualism-friendly. By the time we get to his most important ethical work, *Utilitarianism*, in 1861, he seems to be shifting from a strong individualism to a more collectivized understanding of what moral principles require. I'm going to commend this to you when you read this work, to note for this, where he wants to argue, when we are talking about what the good is —what's useful, what's not

useful, what's good, what's bad—he's going to argue that the proper standard of understanding good and bad is not an individualistic one.

8.43 So we had this line in chapter two where he says, "No human being should be a selfish egotist, devoid of every feeling or care but those which center on his own miserable individuality." And so that's fairly harsh distancing. The individual in your individuality—there's something miserable about that. Instead, the famous slogan, "the utilitarian standard of the good," is a more majoritarian or more robustly collectivized notion. This phrase we've all heard, "the greatest happiness of the greatest number"—it's not the greatest happiness for each individual to pursue by his or her own lights. Rather, the good is the good that yields, as a result, matter of consequences, the greatest happiness for the greatest number. Not everybody's going to be satisfied, so it's going to be a more majoritarian notion of the good. And this obviously raises the question, well, what if you're not among the greatest number? He had earlier argued, if you are, you know, the single person who disagrees with the majority, you should be left to your own devices. Here, he seems to be changing tack, that those in the minority position are properly subordinated to the majority.

8.44 Now with that, I want, though, to switch to Friedrich Nietzsche, a younger contemporary of John Stuart Mill. Born in Germany, he has a distinction of being recognized for his brilliance when he was extraordinarily young, and pointed to a university professorship prior even to receiving his PhD dissertation. His work was in process, but it hadn't finished yet, and that was an unusual thing in the German-speaking world. The famous thing that we get from Nietzsche's ethics is this distinction between master morality and slave morality, and this language of masters and slaves, ancient to the human being. But one important element of this here is this idea that somehow morality is no longer this universal thing, that there's one proper moral code that we all should aspire to, but rather there are poly-moral codes. There's more, more than one. So we're going to start relativizing, more significantly, the notion of morality.

8.45 We are also now skeptical about many of the arguments for the existence of God. One of the phrases that Nietzsche picks up is this theme of the death of God, that in some sense we have killed off God with our Enlightenment modern thinking, and thereby, what we mean metaphorically is, we've killed off religion with its idea that there is a supreme legislator of morality, and morality is a matter of commands that we're supposed to obey, no matter what. So we are secularizing or naturalizing morality. If we're not getting it from God or the gods, where do we get it from? And do we all get it, whatever that source is, in the same way, or do we end up with conflicting moral codes?

8.46 And this language of master morality and slave morality is—there we go—the thesis of a work called *On the Genealogy of Morals*. This came out shortly after he wrote another book with the very dramatic title, *Beyond Good and Evil*. And this one is written in more structured essay form, and it's meant to be a more accessible guide to

understanding all of the arguments that he developed in *Beyond Good and Evil*. Now, what's interesting about the title here is this notion of a genealogy. And a genealogy is a certain kind of history. And the idea here is that morals have a history.

- 8.47 And again, we need to stop thinking about morals as absolute and universal and unchanging. We are now into an evolutionary world. Animals don't have an absolute and unchanging history. They evolve. And various species have a genealogy. And we have to understand the genealogy to figure out why they adapted to being the kind of species that they are. And that we should do the same thing to moral codes. Moral codes are part of nature. We are a human animal, and we adopt them and use them and adapt them for various purposes. And that's what a proper understanding of morality is going to be about.
- 8.48 Now, a couple of key opening things. "Fortunately," he says, if I'm going to do my philosophy of ethics here, he said, "I learned to separate theological prejudice from moral prejudice and ceased to look for the origin of evil behind the world." So we're not going to adopt theological understandings of ethics anymore. God is dead. We're moving on to a purely secular, naturalistic understanding. "A certain amount of historical and philological schooling." This is his saying, "I learned a lot of history as a student." As it turns out, he was fascinated by language and classical languages. His PhD is actually in philology, which is the love of words, but it's the study of languages and ancient languages. And so, he is well familiar with Greek and Latin and a number of other languages. And what he's going to do is look at how moral vocabularies and words of ethical significance are defined and used in different languages, and how they change over time. This is a very, then, evolutionary approach to understanding not only language, but a subset of language, moral language.
- 8.49 His question is going to be, "Under what conditions did man devise these value judgments good and evil? And what value do they themselves possess?" So, we study this group of people, and they have a moral code that they've developed, and we have this group of people, and they have a different moral code, and a lot of the anthropological studies that we're doing, along with all of the language studies that we're now doing as moderns exploring the world, seem to point up this great diversity of moral codes. What's moral in one culture seems to be very immoral in another culture. And then we start to wrestle with this problem of relativism, and are there really absolutes? And so on. But Nietzsche is more interested in saying, well, we can make sense of why these people came up with their moral code if we understand the circumstances within which they were living. And these people were living in different circumstances, and so we can understand why they would come up with different moral codes, given those circumstances. And that's then going to be the project.
- 8.50 So did those moral codes, not were like absolutely truths, general principles revealed by rational insight or commandments from God and so on? But can we understand moral codes as instruments or tools that people use in trying to get along with the

business of living? Purely naturalizing ethics. "Under what conditions did man devise these values judgements, and what value did they themselves possess?" Because it might very well be that a certain moral principle or a moral code is useful under certain circumstances, but circumstances change, and then that moral code is no longer useful. And what we then need to do is change our moral code to adapt it to the new circumstances.

- 8.51** So it's always a good question, whatever moral code we're considering, or whatever moral principles, is not to say, well, I guess it's a moral principle, and I just have to accept it, and it's been around for a whole lot of time, but is it still useful? Is it still a good moral principle? And will it continue to be a good moral principle? And should I drop that one and perhaps try some other moral principle in order to survive?
- 8.52** "Have they hitherto hindered or furthered human prosperity?" That's an interesting way. He wants to suggest some moral codes help human beings live better. Other moral codes don't seem to do so. They seem to be signs of distress, signs of impoverishment, signs of the degeneration of life. "Or is there revealed in them, on the contrary, the plenitude, force, and will of life, its courage, certainty, and future?"
- 8.53** Suppose we were trying to read the mind of a lion, for example, a little science fiction experiment here. There's a lion, and we have a sense for what a lion should do if it's going to succeed in life as a lion. But then we have a very philosophical lion, right? And it has been reading too much of, you know, some skeptical, nihilistic, other lion philosophers, and it is saying, "You know, I think there's no good in the world, right? I'm a little bit ashamed of my sharp claws, right? I think I'm going to file down my teeth because, you know, that's just bad, right, to be so aggressive and so on." Nietzsche's question is to say, there's something wrong with that lion. It has a moral code, but that moral code is kind of anti-lion. It does not help that lion flourish as a lion in the world.
- 8.54** And the same thing is going to be true of human beings. We look at all of the moral codes, the moral codes that come out of the Greeks, out of the Romans, out of the Jews, out of the Christians, out of the Hindus, and so forth, and we are going to put them to that test. Do they work? Do they seem to be instead signs of sickness, signs of weakness? Or do they seem to be signs of vitality and health? Particularly, when we consider in the modern world, the kinds of moral codes that seem to have a lot of staying power.
- 8.55** "What was especially at stake was the value of the unegoistic, the instincts of pity, self-abnegation, self-sacrifice." So we have moral codes that emphasize pity, self-abnegation, self-sacrifice. Now, what moral code are we primarily thinking about here? Well, we're trying to think about Judeo-Christian moral code, particularly in its strongest representatives, where you have people like, for example, monks or priests of a certain vigorous sort, who say, "I am going to not be at all interested in wealth. I'm taking a vow of poverty. I'm not going to be interested in doing my own will. I'm going to try to become as weak and small and self-effacing as I possibly can. I'm just going to

be an obedient servant of others. I am not going to be interested in sex and being lusty and chasing women and so forth. I'm going to be chaste and keep myself pure and take a vow of celibacy."

8.56 What do we think about a moral code that embraces poverty and obedience and chastity as values and says that those are good things? Is that healthy? Is that what it is to be a good human being? Is that going to make us be vigorous and improve us as individuals and as the species? Or is this not, perhaps, a moral code that's taking us in the opposite direction from what full, vigorous, healthy living is, toward, well, what's the ultimate of shrinking from life? Death. And death is the opposite, very unhealthy thing to embrace. So these are Nietzsche's questions.

8.57 And then he wants to say, "It was precisely here that I saw the great danger to mankind." Some moral codes are a great danger to mankind because, in many cases, they are very seductive, they're enticing, and a lot of people get sucked into them, and then they start to become institutionalized in cultures and last for a very long time. But they mean that those individuals don't realize their full human potential. And the cultures that embrace them are going to not develop their own potential. In fact, they might be committing a kind of individual and cultural suicide to the extent that they adopt those kinds of moral codes. So we know who the enemy here is. It is going to be, particularly in Western philosophy, the Judeo-Christian tradition in its strongest forms, and then in Eastern philosophy, some forms of Hinduism and Buddhism, where they try to withdraw from the world as much as possible, eat as little as possible, drink as little as possible, let the elements have their way with their bodies, and not, in effect, live their life.

8.58 It's nihilism. And nihilism is the end result of a wrong moral code. And more broadly, a wrong. Nihil is Latin for nothing. It's a nothingism. Now, in sarcastic farther, the morality of pity, feeling sorry for people, we go back to the example of the lion, and it catches the zebra, and says, "Oh, I feel sorry for the zebra." Something wrong with that lion. Pity has no place in a healthy lion's life. "The modern effeminacy of feeling." We all are supposed to be nice and sweet and sensitive, rather than the opposite of that. Do nice, sweet, sensitive guys change the world? The answer is going to be no. "What if the reverse were true? What if precisely morality would be to blame if the highest power and splendor actually possible to the type man was in fact never attained? So that precisely morality was the danger of dangers?"

8.59 So some moral codes, you get in, they get inside your head, they get inside your psyche, and they do damage there. They undercut your thinking that you are worth doing your best, that you are worth receiving certain values, that your ideas should be manifested, that you can be a world shaker, a world conqueror. They are the danger to your life. Now, he had read Darwin, he mentions this, and then all of that understanding of Darwinian evolutionary theory, different species, different modes of life, different strategies, they are in conflict with each other. But out of that conflict

comes the advancement of each of those species. Human beings need to be understood as a part of that story. Now, here's where we have the English psychologists, and here he is thinking exactly of someone like John Stuart Mill and his *On Liberty*. If you take the notion of "the greatest happiness for the greatest number" as a possible slogan exactly for here.

- 8.60** And we subject this to a kind of Nietzschean analysis. What is Nietzsche—what is Mill saying with a notion like that? Here I am as an individual. I want to be a good person. I have some ideas, some energy, some resources. What should I do with them? And Mill has said, well, I shouldn't be thinking about myself, my own dreams. Instead, I should just look at everybody else and say, what will make you happy? What will make you really happy? I collect all this data about what's going to make all of you happy, and then I do it in a kind of social survey way. And I say, well, if I put your happiness and your happiness together, you guys seem to be pretty close, and you guys seem to be the majority, that's going to be the greatest happiness, doing what these people want. And then I dedicate myself to serving to bring about the great happiness of all you other people.
- 8.61** And Nietzsche wants to say, that's disgusting, literally disgusting. What kind of person thinks that way? The good is what other people want and what the majority of other people want. And then not only, have you looked at most other people? And what kind of people they are and what they want? And you want to just say, I am just a servant of what most of those other people want. That's pathetic. But there are moral codes. And he wants to say, utilitarianism is the latest, somewhat secularized development of that kind of tradition, where you're supposed to be selfless, you're supposed to be self-effacing. It's all about the other people, and you are just a servant of them. And that's why they are old, cold, tedious frogs.
- 8.62** "Now it is plain to me, first of all, that in this theory, the source of the concept 'good' has been sought and established in the wrong place. The judgment 'good' did not originate with those to whom goodness was shown." So it's not the case that I do good things, thereby showing goodness to you. And you are the ones who are the standard in evaluating that as the good. So it's the others who are the standard of good. "Rather, it's the good themselves, that is to say, the noble, powerful, high-stationed, and high-minded, who felt and established themselves and their actions as good." Comes from me. I have my ideas, my agenda. This is what I want to do. I am good. I like myself, and I want to realize my plans, and that's where the good comes from. You might have a relationship to this, but you are further down the road. I am going to realize my agenda and bring it into.
- 8.63** So it's egoistic, not altruistic. It is self-generated, not other-generated. I am an artist. I have my vision. I have my ideas. I want to make my artworks. And they have to be a certain beautiful way. Don't you try to tell me what's going to be in my artworks. That's what it is to be an artist. Maybe after the fact, you will like my artwork, but that's

secondary. What kind of self-respecting artist is going to say, "I am an artist. What would you like me to paint? Tell me, please. I probably should put it to a vote. What do most of you want me to paint? And whatever that comes, OK, great. I'll just paint that." Is that an artist? No, not an artist. Scientists, people in business, people who are in adventure, explorers and so forth. They are egoists. They are not altruists. They are self-driven. They are not other-driven.

- 8.64** And what is striking, then, about Nietzsche is that he uses his interest in philology and his expertise, actually, in philology to trace the origin of this. He wants to say, if you start to look at the ancient languages and their moral vocabulary, what you find is that the words good and the words bad, which are our moral vocabulary, follow his pattern. In the earliest of the languages, the words good are always associated with noble, high-minded, aristocratic, strong, powerful, proud, and so forth. And what's bad? Well, bad is anything that is less than that. It's, as he puts it here, actually, low, ordinary, boring, common. So the good and bad in these ancient languages reflects all of that.
- 8.65** But then, of course, if we look at the Judeo-Christian language, we look at the Hebrew, the Aramaic, right, and so forth, then what we find is an inversion of that moral vocabulary. And instead it starts to be, if you're proud and strong and rich and aggressive, now you're a bad person. And who are the good people? They are the ones who are self-effacing and forgiving and pitying and self-sacrificing. So we have these two moral vocabularies in these ancient languages with completely different origins.
- 8.66** Now, he puts it in slightly culturally political terms. He talks about a priestly moral code and a knightly, aristocratic moral code. And we know most ancient societies, tribes, as they then became more sophisticated and generated into empires and feudal structures and so forth, they would have various classes of people, and almost always at the top were the aristocrats, who were martial artists, so to speak, who came to their positions of power, and then people who were priests, who were looking after the religion and the moral code. And he says that both of those have two different moral codes, typically. What's good to you if you are a member of the knightly aristocratic class? Well, you need to be powerful, physically. Develop your body so you can be a good fighter, a good warrior, learn how to shoot an arrow, fight with a sword, wrestle when necessary, and so forth.
- 8.67** "A flourishing, abundant, even overflowing health." And what's good for you? What do you like? What are your values? What do you want your life to be? Well, war, adventure, hunting, dancing, games, and of course, lots of sex. "Vigorous, free, joyful activity." There's a whole moral code built around that lifestyle. And then if you're a knight or an aristocrat, how do you look at the common people? Well, you look down at them. It's not necessarily that they are evil. It's more that they're just like beneath your notice as much as possible. They are just of a lower order. And so we have this entire moral code that is based on that.

- 8.68** By contrast, what do we find when we look at the priestly moral class? Well, these are not very physical beings. They're kind of weak. Often they're kind of scrawny. They don't have any muscles. They say, oh, I don't like competition. I don't like to play games. And war is icky. And I want to retreat to my silent prayer room and think thoughts and so forth and follow my orders and look after my flock of other sheep. That flock of sheep language is there. Yeah, it is a bunch of sheep. And you're just like the head sheep. This is not an attractive picture, but nonetheless it is a strongly ensconced moral code down through our history.
- 8.69** And what he wants to argue is, what we have had is an ongoing battle in Western civilization between these two moral codes. The Jews started it. He wants to then go back to that earlier question. When did the Jews start it? The Jews started it when they were slaves in Egypt, under powerful Egyptian masters. And the Egyptians were masters. They had no problem with rising up, conquering. And I'm going to rise to the top of the social hierarchy, live exactly how I want, and make everybody else serve me. And we'll try to, of course, conquer as many neighboring people as we possibly can. We conquer the Jews. We bring them in and we make them slaves.
- 8.70** OK, what happens when you find yourself in that circumstance? You're a Jew and you're a slave and you want to survive. What you have to do is learn how to live as a slave. If you try to be self-assertive and say, "I have my own ideas, my own goals, my dreams. Master, I'm not going to obey," you die, or you get beaten. So what you have to learn is to be patient until the master tells you to do something. And when the master hits you and beats you a little bit because you didn't hop to it fast enough, you don't do the natural, healthy, human thing of trying to seek revenge, because if you do that, you're going to die. You have to just stifle it and suck it up and do what the master says because he said so. You have to find a way to not let that poison your mind, that you let this guy make you do his beck and call.
- 8.71** So you have to be patient. You have to forswear any possibility of revenge, rather, maybe even forgive the person. And if you become a parent, as a slave, what do you teach your kids about how they're going to survive as a slave? From day one, you tell them, "Don't think your own thoughts. Don't have your own will. Be patient. Be not revengeful. Do what you are told. Follow orders." That's the only way, as a slave, you can survive. That's the only way you can keep your people together. Make sure that your children survive. And as this happens for generation after generation, you have a whole slave culture that has a new set of virtues and values that they have been totally conditioned to, and they think that's the right way to live.
- 8.72** And of course, then eventually they get out of slavery and they go on their way. And their moral values, they think them eternal, unchanging, and so they pass them on as eternal and unchanging. And here we are 2,000 years later. Meanwhile, of course, there's been this entirely other moral code that the Egyptians represented, and the Japanese samurai represented, and the Vikings represented, and the Romans

represented, that was all about aristocratic imposition of your will and living a good, healthy life of war, adventure, exploration, and danger.

8.73 "Now, you do not comprehend this? You're incapable of seeing something that required 2,000 years to achieve victory?" And now Nietzsche is bringing us to contemporary times. The Jews on slavery begat Christianity 2,000 years ago. And we know there's a great historical story about Christians versus Romans, different moral codes. Rome declined, but here we are 2,000 years later, and what are the prevailing moral codes in the 19th century? Well, there's lots of Christianity, there's lots of Judaism, there's increasing amounts of Muslim, but they're all variations on this old priestly-slave morality theme, Nietzsche argues. And we have some people who try to secularize them by saying, "Well, we should just let the majority rule," as if the majority of people are admirable enough and smart enough and energetic enough to know what good policy is. Most people are not that smart. Why do we give them political power? But the idea that we think democracy is a good idea.

8.74 Socialism in the modern world. Everybody should be equal. We should all take all of our stuff and share it equally with everybody else. More slave morality in a slightly secular form as well. Where are the Napoleons now? Where are the Caesars? Where are the Alexander the Greats? Where are the Vikings? Where are the samurai? What happened to the Romans? Why did they decline? And what Nietzsche wants to argue is, we've had this ongoing battle now for 2,000 years. It seems like the slaves are winning with their moral code. And what he is interested in is the master moral code, reinvigorating that one in modern times. And it's going to be only the masters who take human beings and their human potential off in the proper direction.

8.75 "The masters have been disposed of. The morality of the common man has won." Right? Everything is becoming Judaized, Christianized, mob-ized. It's mob rule. Lowest common denominator morality. All right, the way he likes to put this in historical terms is to say, the Jews have been extraordinarily successful as a species, obviously. The Romans were obviously very successful as a species as well. And I'm using the species language because Nietzsche wants to say, this is not only just psychological stuff at work. What we might also learn from biology is that human beings, like other species, evolve into substrains with their own physiological types and differentias, and that what their moral codes and what goes on in their psychology is a byproduct of their underlying biological and physiological codes.

8.76 We know the Roman type was able to create the great Roman Empire. We know what strong religions do in cultures as well. That's the choice. Rome against Judea. Judea against Rome. And we'll end on this note. There's a dark point for Nietzsche. The Roman Empire, of course, was centered in Rome. And he says, if you go to Rome now, who's there? It's the chief priest. It's the Vatican with the Pope, who is now the representative of the long-standing version of Christianity that was itself an outgrowth of Judaism. So that's symbolically from Nietzsche's perspective. The Jews and the

Christians won. They took over Rome, and they planted their flag right in the center of Rome. That's their victory. What is the fate of human morality?

8.77 All right, I want to just have one more point. This is my final point here. Nietzsche is a German thinker, and in early 19th-century German thought, this idea of dialectical processes, Hegel and Marx, dialectical spirit, dialectical matter. Nietzsche, toward the end of his writings, seems to embrace a kind of dialectical understanding himself, as a German thinker as well. This is toward the end of *The Will to Power*. It was the book that Nietzsche was working on before he died. He was close in various points to getting it published, but he was never entirely satisfied with everything. But he lost his mental faculties before he was able to bring it to completion. So it was published posthumously.

8.78 But there is this fascinating section toward the end of it, section 983, where he talks about the evolution of human beings, and his hopeful evolution of human beings, toward a new and better type of man and mankind. But he adopts this somewhat dialectical phrase where he says, I have portrayed all of human history, at least in terms of its moral developments, as this great collision between slave moralities and master moralities, or more religious moralities and more naturalistic moralities, between nihilistic, sickly moralities and healthy, vital moralities, or between the Judeo-Christian tradition and the Greco-Roman tradition, and that Western civilization has been this great battle down to our time of that. And the great representative of the one tradition is, of course, Jesus Christ, and the great representative of the other tradition is, of course, Julius Caesar. And they are opposites, they are contradictions, they are thesis and antithesis. Maybe the future will involve a synthesis of the two types. What we need to strive for will be to create a "Caesar, but with the soul of Christ."

8.79 And that's provocative. Now, Nietzsche died in 1900, so there's, I think, a nice symbolicness. We started in 1500 with this course. We've come through some centuries of development, and the new century, the 20th century, is about to begin. This is where philosophy has taken us so far. Now, I think we have covered some of the big names. Sadly, I have to say, we didn't get to include everybody I would have loved to have talked about. So, in addition to all of these people, read more of them, think more about them, put them in collision with each other. But also remember that we only mentioned Hobbes once, and he's pretty important. We only mentioned Berkeley once. We didn't say anything about Spinoza or Schopenhauer. There's lots more good stuff in the modern era. I commend it to you, and I hope that this has been a good introduction to modern philosophy.